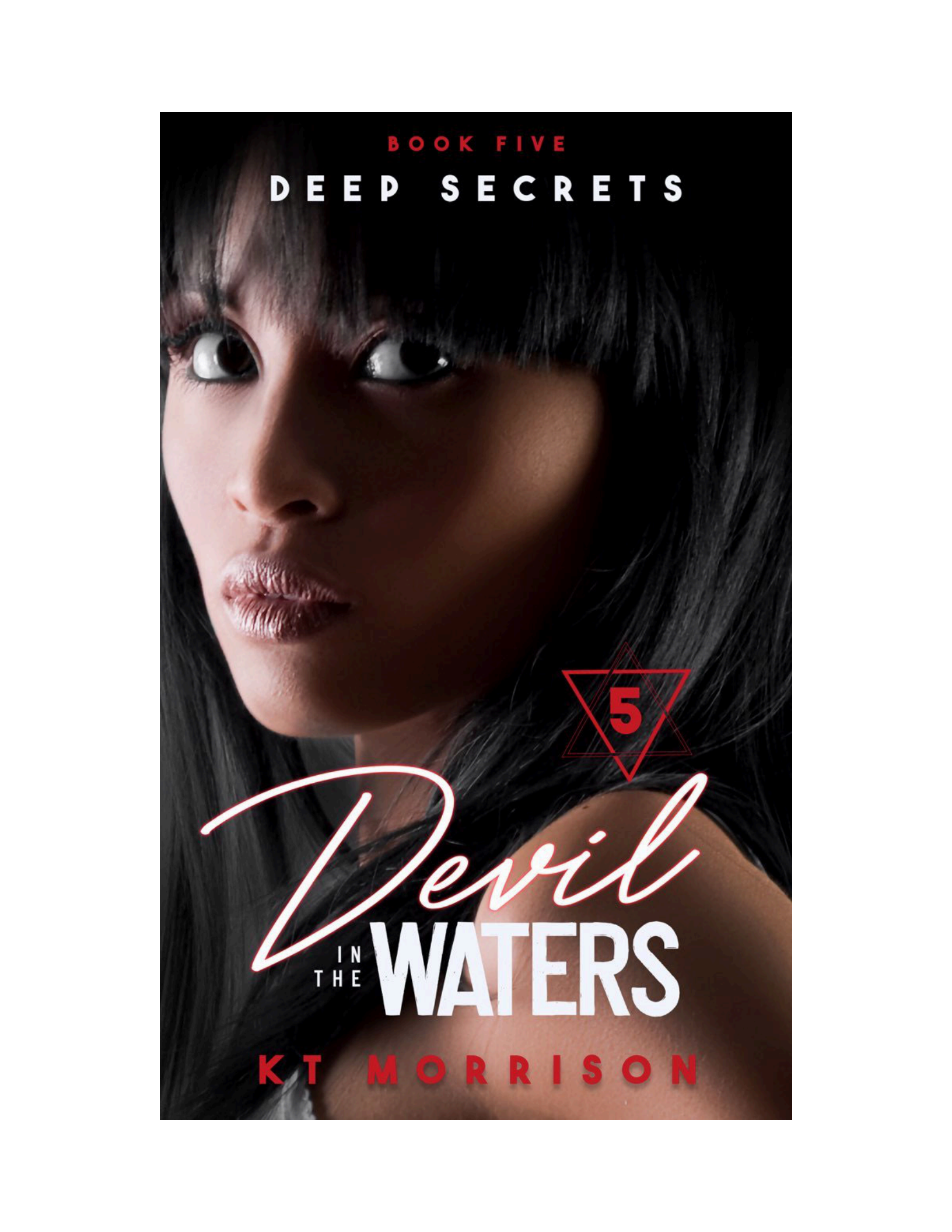




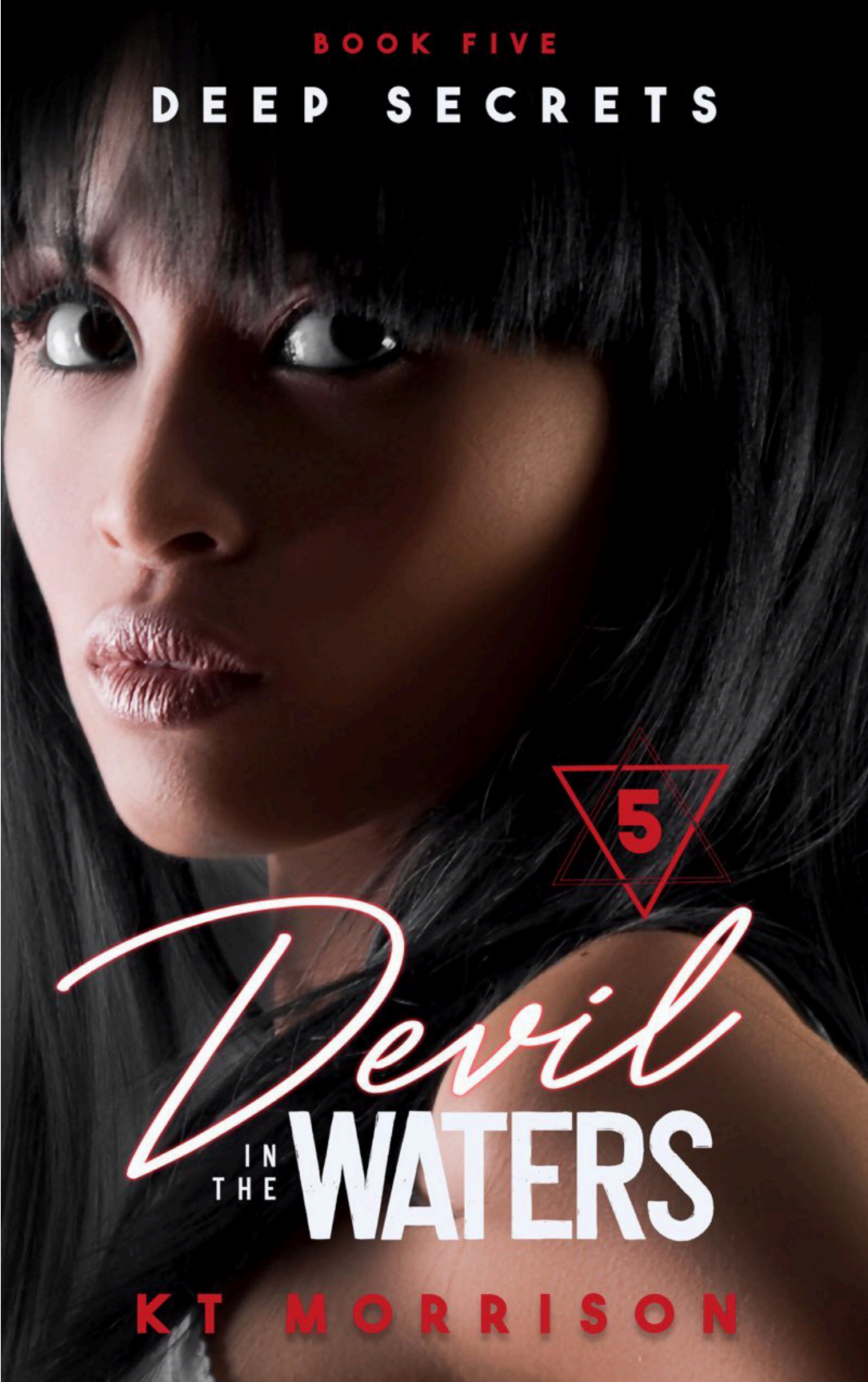
BOOK FIVE  
DEEP SECRETS



*Devil*  
IN THE **WATERS**

KT MORRISON





BOOK FIVE  
DEEP SECRETS



*Devil*  
IN THE WATERS

KT MORRISON



Deep Secrets

---

Devil In The Waters

KT Morrison



## Contents

[About the Author](#)

[More Licorice Books](#)

[Introduction](#)

I. Tuesday, August 11

1. Treats

2. Arrangements

3. Bad Egg

4. Spectators

5. Gift

6. Horse

7. Gems

8. Messes

9. Alarm

10. Stern

11. Signals

II. Wednesday, August 12

12. Winchester

13. Wild Horse

[Afterword](#)





## About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

*Visit My Website!*

[ktmorrison.com](http://ktmorrison.com)



# More Licorice Books

*Please visit [www.licoricebooks.com](http://www.licoricebooks.com) for an updated catalog*

---

## ONGOING SERIES

[\*Landlord\*](#)

[\*Obsessed\*](#)

[\*The Cayman Proxy\*](#)

[\*Separate Schools\*](#)

[\*Keely\*](#)

[\*Six Weeks In Winter\*](#)

[Chelsea Hates Libby](#)

*Devil In The Waters*

---

## **EPIC NOVELS**

[Cherry Blossoms](#)

[Maggie](#)

[Learning Lessons](#)

[Happy Endings](#)

---

## **NOVELS**

[Going A Little Too Far](#)

[Pool Party](#)

*Après Ski*

*Rachel's Truth*

---

**NOVELLAS**

*Watching Natalie Cheat*

*Watching Natalie Again*

*Inconceivable*

*Mary's Pledge*

*One Night Only (by Becky Haze)*

*A Week On The Big Snake (by Allie Castro)*

*Amazing Grace*

*Two Days In Malta*

*One Of The Gang*

---

**BDSM**

*Safe Words (by Keeva Lashley)*





This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

Models on cover are meant for illustrative purposes only.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

---

## **DEEP SECRETS**

### **A Devil In The Waters Novel**

#### ***Book 5***

*45,000 words*

---

First Edition. Aug 2, 2020.

Copyright © 2020 KT Morrison

Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison



## Introduction

A few months ago I began a Patreon. It's a website where creators can garner support from their fans who wish to be patrons.

The aim of my Patreon is to help support the quicker finishing of series' I have still left hanging, and in return I offer a frequent-update series appearing first on Patreon where all the patrons analyze and debate every character's actions and motivations—it's grown to a great and active little community . . .

*for more info:*

[ktmorrison.com](http://ktmorrison.com)



**I**

---

**Tuesday, August 11**



## Treats

It hurt between her legs when she sat up in bed. She was slow to get to her feet—hands on her knees for support—but once she was up, walking wasn't affected. No limp, no toddling, no pain. Some tenderness.

She left Josh in bed, walked in the predawn light into the bathroom, closed the door, sat on the toilet with knees pressed together and a hand over her mouth. She relaxed her muscles. The pee-tingle began and soon her bladder knotted, and she felt the tinkle coming. It burned, and she winced her eyes but at least didn't cry out.

When it was done, she felt a dull pervasive ache throbbing from the interior of her canal and right up inside her, a threadlike tug on the knot in her navel. But she got up, turned and flushed. Brushed her teeth, lifting one foot off the floor, bending until the heel touched her butt. Alternated, doing the other leg. Stretching it out.

Then she was back in the bedroom, coming around Josh's side of the bed. It might be a little too much to get down and kiss him while he slept, but she did want to.

*If you lay it on too thick, it might make you seem suspicious.*

But the feeling was genuine. And that gave her an idea.

Now she was padding down the hall and into the kitchen, getting her phone out, laying it on the counter. Putting on toast, boiling a kettle. While last night she had made a secret surreptitious phone call, the one this morning was of a kinder nature. She moved around into the foyer and hid behind the



wall and peeped down the hall, dialed Meyer's number. He answered, and she spoke quietly.

"What are you doing tonight?"

He told her he was doing nothing, and then she asked if he wanted to go out and have some fun with Josh and maybe a couple other people. He said he would like to. Then asked: "Like who else?" She said she didn't know but she would call Steve, maybe get some of the people from Swanson. Meyer said, "What about that girl Quinn?" It took her a moment to remember who that was, but then he reminded her, saying she was the one with the kid named Harley. Right: the nurse.

She Ooh-la-la'd Meyer and he said, "No, it wasn't like that." She said she would be sure Quinn got an invitation when she spoke to Steve. Then the bad news.

"Do you have Sophie with you?"

"Yeah, she's with me one more day."

"Shoot—do you think you can get a sitter?"

"You want to go late?"

"I thought we would have some fun. Maybe have some drinks and stay out late, yeah . . ."

He exhaled, thinking about it. Probably thinking this would be his chance with Quinn. "Yeah," he said, "maybe . . . There's a family on the street here . . . I've never talked to them about watching Soph before, but . . . Gosh, I never use sitters whenever she's with me . . ."

She said, "What about Hyun?"

"Yeah," he said, draggy, still thinking about it, a creaky sound in his throat.

"Is that no good?"

“No, that could work . . . Shoot, though, Hyun won’t be home until after nine, and I’ll already be at work. If I could get Sophie there, Hyun would take her a day early without hesitation.”

“Hyun’s working an overnight?”

“She is.”

“And you need Soph there after nine?—Maybe I could . . .”

“What—you’d take Soph to Hyun?”

“Let me come get her now, I’ll take her out for breakfast. Once Hyun gets home I’ll drop Sophie off.”

“Won’t you be late for work?”

“I will, but my hours are flexible. Plus I gotta go into the city, not the office anyway. I have an appointment at eleven . . .”



Shame was the first thing on his mind when he woke. He sat up, rubbing his face before that awful feeling settled on him too heavy, laying in bed looking out at the dismal sky. Best to be up and moving if you wanted to get away from it. But it was impossible to escape completely . . .

He passed into the bathroom, seeing Kimmy’s spot empty and getting a funny feeling. Like maybe Kimmy couldn’t sleep last night thinking later about all the weird things her husband’d said. Maybe she got up, was looking online for Weird things husbands say and what you should do about it.

He avoided his eyes in the mirror and replayed some of the things he’d asked his wife. Did Devlin have a big cock? . . . That was pretty much what

he'd said. Hey, you know how you and I are having sex, and I hate Devlin and I'm really worried about him being in your life, why don't I bring his dick up right at the worst time? Is that cool with you? You must think a lot of me right now. I know, don't get too excited. Aw, baby, don't worry, I'm already yours . . .

Kimmy had jerked him off and he'd asked his wife if she would say that she had been thinking about Devlin's huge manhood. And Kimmy was reluctant. Reluctant until he pressed. And then she played along. Sure, Josh, I often think about that big dick. The one he humped against me . . .

But see, there: that was arousing.

Of course she wouldn't think of Devlin that way. The guy forced himself on her. That wasn't arousing. Or maybe it was? How well did he know women? But it wasn't women at play here. It was one woman. Kimmy. Kimmy didn't like being held down and humped.

*But apparently didn't hate it enough to never work for the man . . .*

He growled now, mad at his own annoying irresoluteness, his inability to settle his thoughts on one idea. The perpetual self-doubt, self-loathing, worry, and angst was killing him. Just let it go . . .

Or talk to her. As much as it pained him to flash to Kimmy some of his weakness, what had happened last night had worked at stitching the imaginary tears. He'd cracked open his door to let some air in, and Kimmy got a peep into his unkempt room. She was supportive . . .

Or was it just sympathy?

He tossed his toothbrush into the standup container where it rattled. Wiped his face, looked at his reflection. It was a one time thing. I don't know what came over me, Kimmy, I just had this weird thing I wanted to hear.

When she'd come back to bed, he let what he'd said go. Put it behind him. And she hadn't mentioned it either. Best to leave it behind.

Now he was on the prowl and looking for his wife. Passing through the bedroom, going out into the hall. Disappointed to find her in the foyer, ready to head out.

“You’re going in already?”

Kimmy was dressed in a black suit, showered already. He’d slept through it.

It was a grim and gray day out there, with the threat of rain. So over her black suit, she wore a light crinkly black overcoat that came down to her knees. She was shrugging her arms into it, hair tied back in its bun, an entire square piece of plain toast held between her teeth. With one arm shoved through, she waved her fingers at him, and managed to smile around the piece of bread. He came to her, and she shoved her hands out of the sleeves, plucked away the toast, and kissed near his cheek. “Good morning,” she said.

“You sneaking out on me?”

“I’m going to go in early,” she said. “There’s so much I have to do today, and I’d like to get it all done so I can be home at not-so-late an hour.”

Boom. First thing in the morning, first thing out of his wife’s mouth reminds him of Devlin. “You’re not going out after work with Devlin tonight?” . . . Keeping it light, not so accusatory in his tone. But the message itself was clear: I’m still sore about what happened.

Kimmy deflected it, saying, “You’ll be glad to hear there is no Devlin in my life at all today. He’s out in Kingston.” Now she came and wrapped her arms around his shoulders, kissed his other cheek. She said near his ear, “Unless maybe that’s not what you want to hear.”

His stomach flinched. What was that supposed to mean? Was that a reference to his dirty talk last night?

She stepped back, said nothing more of it, and his scalp tingled, his fingers went to pins and needles considering what she said. Was that what she’d

meant? Did Kimmy think he liked to hear about her with Devlin? He didn't. No fucking way he did. Don't get this twisted, Kimmy.

As she gathered her things, getting her keys and her briefcase, he was thinking now he was sure it was. He was at once offended and yet also aroused. Mad that Kimmy was still thinking about it. But glad she was still thinking about it—and for some reason curious if she was going to inject this into their sex life now.

*But wasn't that a bad thing? What if she got home tonight and they started getting frisky with each other, and she starts whispering bad things about Devlin in his ear. Well, shoot, he would love it. But then wouldn't she start thinking of Devlin that way? What if you're just putting this stuff in her head? The first thing she's going to think about the next time she sees Devlin is the size of his penis. You did that, Josh. That's on you. You put that in her head. You put it in her head, and there's no taking it out now.*

Shit, Josh, maybe for once maybe you could just enjoy it . . . Have you thought about that? Kimmy's not exactly trying to escape out of the apartment now, is she? Not so turned off by your weird thoughts that she needs to get away from you this morning. Maybe she'd like to play around a little with some kinky ideas . . .

*One step at a time.*

“What do you have to do?”

“This morning? I've got a meeting right downtown on Front Street with Border Services at ten-fifteen. But there's a bunch of stuff I have to do first, so I want to go by the office on my way in. Then in the afternoon it's—”

He waved her off. “You don't have to check everything with me,” he said, worried now his theatrics last night would make Kimmy verify everything with him. It would lead to resentment.

“I don't feel like I'm checking in, Josh,” she said, eyes half-lidded, eyebrows raised calmly. “I'm an open book.”

“Go to work,” he said, “maybe I’ll sleep in.”

She smiled, looked him up and down, from messy bedhead to PJ pants and bare feet. “Calling in sick today?”

“Never,” he said, joined her at the front door. “I’ve got important things going on, too, big shot.” He opened the door, pulled her close and kissed her neck.

“See you after work,” she said, tapped his cheek lightly with her piece of toast, one half-moon bit out of the corner now. “I love you.”

“I love you too,” he said, and watched her walk to the elevator.

He couldn’t let her think he liked to hear about her and Devlin. Couldn’t bring dirty talk about her and Devlin into their sex life. It would push Kimmy’s thoughts in that direction. Any dirty fantasy he revealed could become license for her to flirt with Devlin at work. And if Kimmy flirted, Devlin could respond. These awful, lusty thoughts he had could hurt Kimmy. He had to stop being selfish . . .



Three driveways down from Meyer’s townhouse, she stared at her phone, thumb hovering and ready to send but still undecided. Do it. But what if there’s something you’re not thinking of?—No, she’ll never mention it to Josh. No way. She hit send.

It’d been almost a month since she’d last talked to Karina, and she wasn’t ready to let the friendship go. Karina was too good a person to not have in her life. She missed her friend. It was the new job that had kept them apart. The new job and, of course, the bad thing she’d been caught doing with Devlin, then the whopper of a lie she’d told her friend. Not so much a lie, though, really . . . she’d told Karina she’d divulged to Josh what had

happened at Tiffany's party while he was passed out and that was mostly true. She'd only left out the worst. Left out the parts Josh would be crushed to hear. And now she was working for Devlin and the sex had happened and was over. She was ready to open her life up again, ready to get back on track.

Kimmy: Long time no talk, sister! I miss you I miss yoga, work is a drag. I'm throwing Josh a surprise get-together tonight and I'd love it if you could make it. Not too many people, Meyer will be there, some of Josh's friends from work. Josh would love to see you, and so would I. Hope you can make it. Call me or text and I'll pop you the deets!

Phone back in her raincoat, she pulled forward and nosed into Meyer's gravel drive, butted up behind his SUV. It had started to mist so she popped her hood up, mounted the steps to his unit and was greeted by Sophie coming out in a hurry in a clear rain slicker. They hugged.

"Hey, you gonna go stay with your mom?"

Sophie said she was, Meyer came out and locked up behind him, saying, "Perfect timing, Kimmy."

She stood, held Sophie's hand.

Meyer said, "What's the special occasion?"

"What do you mean?"

"It's not Josh's birthday."

"Oh," she laughed, "Ha, no. It's been a tough month to get used to. I'm not around like I used to be and . . ."

Meyer laughed, said, "You're too good to that guy."

“Nah,” she said, “He deserves it.” Then: “I hope it clears up,” looking past the rim of her hood at the greying sky. “I pictured the party on a patio.”

“It’s supposed to clear,” Meyer said, fishing his keys out of his pocket.

They walked down the steps together, Sophie leading her by the hand, the little girl with a good grip.

Daddy said bye to daughter, and Kimmy told him she’d text him later, and they all hustled into their vehicles and closed the doors before they got too wet. Sophie struggled her way into her car seat on her own. It’d been a pain in the ass to get it figured out in the new car this morning, worried Josh would look down and catch her putting it in the car, but she thought she got away with it, just tossing it in the back then getting it sorted when she stopped for coffee.

Sophie brushed back her damp hair, said, “What’s the party for Uncle Josh.”

“Just ‘cause he’s an awesome uncle. It sucks it’s a grown-up party and it’s going to be late. You want to go with Josh and me to see a movie next week?”

She brightened. “Okay . . .”

“Now—where do you want to go for breakfast? My treat . . .”





---

## Arrangements

At the brick gingerbread cookie house with the insurance broker sign out front, she turned left onto the narrow drive that led to Hyun's apartment. What used to be Hyun and Meyer's apartment, before they separated and Meyer took the basement apartment in his buddy's townhome.

The building was a five-story nestled behind fifty-year old family homes along a busy Ajax side street, red brick with black railing balconies; not upscale but not inexpensive and very clean and well-kept. She and Josh had visited here often since they married, back when Hyun and Meyer were still a couple and Sophie was littler.

She and Soph had gone to an all-day-breakfast family place Soph sometimes went with her mom, called The Great Eggs-Crepe. Sophie had French Toast with real maple syrup and bacon. Had asked for chocolate chips in her French Toast and Kimmy obliged her, feeling bad they were having an adult party when Sophie was staying with Meyer. And Josh would have liked to see his niece. But she and Sophie had a big-girl breakfast date, and with that Sophie was happy. She swore they'd make it up to Soph, and they would.

Hyun met them at the apartment door. Though she knew they were coming at ten (and it was ten on the nose), they used Sophie's key to get in the building and they didn't buzz up beforehand. It was like they'd caught Hyun unprepared. She looked harried; hair damp, like she'd just jumped out of the shower, she was tied up in a robe. She held the door, and Sophie bounced into her arms, Hyun stooping to pat Sophie's back.

"Come in, Kimmy, come in," she said.

“I can’t stay long,” she said, stepping in and closing the door behind her.

“Stay for a cup of tea,” Hyun asked, and Kimmy said she would. There was genuine friendliness in Hyun’s eyes—not a lie or politeness provoking the invitation for tea. It was hard to accept Hyun as no longer a part of the family but the truth was, without the marriage to Meyer, they saw almost nothing of her anymore.

“Should I have come later?—I hope I didn’t get you out of the shower . . .”

“I was late coming home, and I had to have a shower.” Hyun worked for Children’s Aid, sometimes doing overnight shifts at a foster care center. Kimmy asked her how school was going.

“Well, the workload . . .” She set the kettle on, shot a pained expression over her shoulder then shrugged with a half-smile.

“You’re doing the right thing,” Kimmy said. After the divorce, Hyun went back to school, going to U of T at the Scarborough campus—graduate work, going part-time for her MA in Adult Education. “Hard work pays off.”

Hyun chuckled, turned to lean on the counter. “Tell me about it—look at you. You look so different.” Sophie had gone to her room but was back now, coming to hug Hyun’s waist.

Kimmy touched her hair, laughed, said, “This work isn’t like being in Immigration.”

“Meyer said he didn’t recognize you when he first saw you . . .”

“Once I was working there?—Yeah, I remember. I must have been a real mess before . . .”

“Not a mess at all. You always looked very professional.”

Sophie said, “I had French toast for breakfast.”

“You ate already?”

Kimmy said, “She’s fed and watered, ready for her day. What are you guys going to do?”

“She’s going to watch her mother sleep for an hour or two, then . . .?”—looking down at Soph—“What would you like to do?”

“Watch TV?” Soph was hopeful.

Hyun caressed Soph’s cheek, said, “I want you to read a book.”

“Can I pick?”

Hyun said she could and Soph silently—but happily—skipped from the kitchen headed for the family room.

She couldn’t help a smile as she watched her husband’s cousin’s daughter, saying, “She really is wonderful.”

Hyun said, “She has her moments, that’s for sure. Thanks for taking her out to breakfast this morning,” as she scissored open the dishwasher and rattled out two mugs. The act of stooping, leaning, and reaching, opened Hyun’s robe, and Kimmy got a glimpse of her bare collar and a little more. It looked like Hyun wore nothing under the robe, at least up top. Hyun’s skin was pale to the point of ghostly. A beautiful shade of porcelain, with the tiniest hint of lavender.

“It was honestly my pleasure,” she said as Hyun set the mugs on the counter then brought closer a stoneware teapot and tossed two teabags inside. “We had a fun breakfast date.”

Hyun asked where they’d ate and what, and Kimmy told her. They talked more about how her Masters was going, and Hyun poured boiling water in the pot then came to the kitchen table and they both sat. Hyun poured.

Kimmy said, “You seeing anyone?”

Hyun put fingers in her damp hair, looked up. “There’s no time.”

“That’s a shame.”

“How about Meyer? He wouldn’t tell me if he was.”

“No. Not at all. Whenever we see him, it’s just him and Sophie.”

Hyun nodded. “Well, there is . . . someone.”

“At school or at work?”

“School.”

“Tell me about him.”

Hyun made a face, said, “Nah, it’s nothing. We’re just friends.”

“That’s how things start, though. But I know it’s hard with your schedule. We should go out sometime.”

That brightened Hyun. Her eyes went lively and she smiled. “I think I need a night out.”

“We’re both busy, but we should stay in touch.”

“I’d like that.”

“I should’ve invited you tonight,” she lamented as she sipped her tea.  
“Sorry.”

“I’m happy to watch Sophie so Meyer can go.”

“You guys get along?”

“We try. He’s mad at me. He blames me.”

“Oh. Not to me. I mean he’s never mentioned . . .”

Hyun changed the subject, brushing a lock of hair from her face, saying,  
“You’re throwing Josh a surprise party?”

“Yes,” she said, hissing her S sound happily.

“You’re so nice. Maybe if I’d . . .”

“Don’t say that. I’m throwing it because . . . I don’t know—I guess like I feel maybe I’m letting him down, being at work all the time.”

“That’s hardly letting him down.”

“We were stuck in that place where we’re supposed to be . . . having babies . . .”

Hyun averted her eyes a moment, nodding, but avoiding the subject of the incomplete pregnancy.

“. . . Then out of nowhere I get this amazing job opportunity and . . . I’m away all the time, or at least a lot more than he’s used to. And I know it’s going to get worse.”

“Your schedule you mean?”

“Yup.”

“Josh is sensitive. Like Meyer.”

“I’m throwing him the party to cheer him up.”

“That’s very sweet,” Hyun said, patting the back of Kimmy’s hand.

She smirked, admitted: “I’m kind of looking forward to seeing his face when he walks in. His face has been one way for so long . . .” She sunk her cheeks and drew her thumb and fingers down her face, narrowing her mouth to an unhappy shape. “He’s been on edge and mopey and it’s like—”

“You’re going to hit him with it.”

“Bam,” she said. “You’re right. Hit him with it.”

“I know the look on his face. Meyer gets it.”

“Maybe it’s a Waters thing.”

Hyun chuckled, gathered her hair up behind her head, both arms raised. She said conspiratorially: “Sophie gets it, too.”

“Aww,” Kimmy cooed, knitting her eyebrows. “She’s so cute.”

Hyun was watching her, cocking her head. “I love your new hair.”

“Sophie really likes it—I think, or maybe she’s just fascinated by the change in appearance.”

“Where do you get it done?” Hyun reached to touch, going slow as a request for permission. Kimmy allowed it, nodding her head forward.

“Same place as always—”

“Where’s that?”

“Here in town, Heather Lauren’s, over on Westney. But this isn’t . . . this is the same cut, I just put it back myself. Oh—and I trimmed my own bangs.”

“I love it,” Hyun said, bringing her hand back, then sipping tea. “I wish I could do mine like that.”

“I could do yours in a few minutes. Want me to trim your bangs?—you already have the same kind of style as mine . . .”

Hyun’s eyebrows popped up. “Would you really do that?”

She said she was sure and stood, came around Hyun’s chair. Hyun shifted it away from the table, and Kimmy gathered Hyun’s wet hair and pulled it back. “Yeah, I can definitely do something with this.”

“Now I just need a killer suit like that and I’ll be in business.”

Kimmy laughed, stroking back Hyun’s hair with her palms. “Where are your scissors?”

“Left of the sink, top drawer,” Hyun said, her own hands working over her hair now, right next to Kimmy’s, and in the moment before she turned to

retrieve the scissors, a glimpse of Hyun's aureola was revealed. For some reason it made her chuckle, but it also brought a pang of hurt, a ghostly reminiscence. The thing she'd done . . .

But that would be made better. "Let me text work," she said, "let them know I'm going to be a little later . . ."



The text had just about killed him. Ten-thirty in the morning in his office, during a meeting, Rafe and Rita across the desk from him, he sees a text coming from his wife. He'd had a fairly clear-skies morning. Hadn't considered much his situation with Kimmy and Devlin. It had eased out of his mind. But mid-sentence, him angling the phone on his desk to read it, catching a glimpse of her message, and he's distracted, trying to struggle his way through the face-to-face with his team members. The text so consumed his thoughts, he had to hustle out Rita and Rafe, calling the meeting short. Once they were gone, he closed his office door, huddled up with his phone and read Kimmy's message. It was what he'd thought from his peripheral reading.

Kimmy: sorry, brief plans change. Going to be a little late tonight, not too late, I swear! Something came up after work, I probably won't be home for dinner, go on and eat without me... But I swear I won't be late!

And that was when his gray mood turned black.

So now he was out for fresh air with Steve at lunchtime, the two of them avoiding the Swanson cafeteria and instead across the street at the souvlaki place in the industrial plaza. He wanted self-destructive food. French fries,



onion rings, a big Coca-Cola, two souvlaki loaded with glistening meat. His treat, so Steve's plate was loaded the same way.

And Steve knew something was up, biding his time, eating slow and letting the conversation hang—leaving plenty of space for Josh to step in and tell him what he brought him out for.

One souvlaki down, and he felt like he had the resolve: “You know she’s driving me crazy?”

“I guess you mean Kimmy.”

“Oh, I definitely mean Kimmy.” He laced together his fingers, felt them slippery, wiped his hands with a napkin, wiped his mouth too, then resumed fingers-interlocked composure.

“Tell me about it,” Steve said.

He took his time, drawing out a long silence which Steve filled by plopping another onion ring in his mouth. Finally he said, “She didn’t get home last night till almost eleven.”

Steve raised his eyebrows, drew in a breath while he was chewing, leaned back from the table. “That sounds pretty late.”

“Eleven o’clock is very late.”

“Did she say why she was home so late?”

“She was at a business meeting,” he said. He put “business” in air quotations.

“You don’t think it was?”

“No, I think it was. Naw, I don’t want to make it sound like that . . .”

“What then—what are you saying?”

“Just that she’s driving me crazy. Why would she do that—stay out that late?”

“Maybe . . . she had a business meeting . . .?”

“So you think I’m making too much of it?”

Steve put his elbows on the table and mimicked the intertwined finger pose.

“Maybe not . . .”

Now his brow knitted, and his expression grew perplexed. “You really think maybe not?”

“I don’t know,” he said, “tell me more . . .”

“Okay,” he said, “the meeting was downtown with her boss . . .”

“Why would they meet downtown? Why wouldn’t they just talk in the office?”

“No, it was them and some other people . . .”

“I see . . .”

But that’s not the bad part. “Well . . . Look, the meeting was downtown . . .” And here was the part where it was getting tricky to say. Was he going to cast doubt in his friend’s head about his wife’s fidelity? What a terrible thing to do to Kimmy if she wasn’t cheating on him. She wasn’t. But still . . . “The meeting was at a hotel. At the Royal York.”

“Fancy-schmancy.”

“They were at the hotel for hours.”

“Her and these guys they were meeting.”

“That she told me they were meeting . . .”

Steve said, “But if she was at the Royal York for bad reasons . . . Why would she even bother to tell you she was at the Royal York? Why not just say they were meeting somewhere else that’s . . . You know that didn’t have . . .” Steve had problems committing out loud to the accusation as well. Too timid to say that Kimmy’d met her boss at a place that had beds.

He said, “Maybe she knew I could track her on my phone.”

“She could just leave her phone at the office . . . Or maybe turn off her tracking . . .”

“But then I would . . . She knows I would ask why she turned off her tracking . . .”

“Then she could act mad—because, you know, you’re tracking her.”

That was true. “Am I crazy?”

Steve thought about it, wiped his hands on his own paper napkin, looked out the window past Josh’s shoulder like he was seriously contemplating. “Maybe not,” he said.

“Really?” He was so used to Steve telling him he was being crazy that when Steve didn’t tell him he was crazy it got his stomach knotted up.

“It’s not crazy crazy. You know . . . I guess it is a little worrisome.”

“You really think so?”

“Even if you hadn’t told me all those things beforehand—you know about the fight and everything that she had with the guy who’s her boss now at that party—just coming out and saying what you told me now might make my scalp tingle . . .”

“Spidey-sense.”

“Yeah, Spidey-sense.”

“Wow,” he exhaled, sitting back now heavily in his iron chair, making the metal legs squeak on the tile floor. “So you don’t think it’s totally crazy?”

“Josh, it’s not totally crazy. Your wife went with her boss who she has this love-hate kind of thing with—”

“She doesn’t love him—what’re you saying?”

“No, not love-hate, but you know that thing where girls are like . . . they say they hate some guy but that means they don’t really hate him they’re just thinking about him all the time and they want to hate him and they’re kind of mad at themselves because they don’t hate him as much as they say they do . . .”

Now his stomach literally cramped. He thumbed forward his tray so he could rest his forearms on the table. “Really?”

“Yeah, and then she goes to a hotel with him . . .” Steve shook his head, mouth quirked to one side as if he was suffering on his own.

“Wow . . . Yeah. She doesn’t even get home until eleven o’clock. Maybe there is something . . .”

“Are you freaking serious?”

Steve showed his palms saying, “You wanted my honest opinion, why do you ask if you’re only wanting to hear what you want?”

“I want your honest opinion. I think I just preferred it when you used to say that I was wrong.”

“Yeah,” Steve said. “You are probably wrong. But I see what you’re saying now. This time I can see it . . .”

He slumped back into his chair, rubbing his forehead. And the morning has started out so positive.

Steve said, “I wouldn’t worry about it too much for now, Josh. Don’t let it get you down.”

“But you just said you could see it . . .”

“I do see your point of view. I’m not agreeing with you . . .”

He shook his head, his knee bobbing up and down. “And, you know, there’re little things. Lots of little things . . .”

“Like what?”

He leaned forward again now, looking around to see if they would be overheard since this was of a more embarrassing nature. The place was packed, but everyone engaged with their own table conversations and no one would hear him. Still, he said quietly: “Like last week I called her phone, but she had her calls routed through her secretary . . .”

“Why would she do that?”

“She was in a meeting. That’s not what went wrong.”

“What went wrong?”

“I was talking to her secretary, and I tell her, you know, that I’m Kimmy’s husband.”

“And . . .?”

“We didn’t talk long, but for the rest of the conversation she kept referring to me as Mr. Chang.”

Steve shook his head and made a confused face.

He said, “She goes by Kimmy Chang at work. Because her boss wants Chang on her business card.”

“Sounds kind of racist.”

“It’s not,” he said. “I wish it was . . . Kimmy is Chinese.”

“So her secretary—”

“Her secretary thinks I’m Chinese.”

Steve nodded, and for a moment he thought Steve had indigestion. But then Steve brought his hands together over his mouth. He went walleyed then pinched his nose. Quick squeaky grunts snorted in his throat.

“Fucking go ahead and laugh.”

Steve released his nostrils, and blubbered honest laughter that had him hunching over his remaining souvlaki. “Her secretary thinks you’re Chinese . . .”

“Very funny,” he said again.

“You are not Chinese . . .”

“I know I’m not Chinese. Go on and laugh . . .”

“Okay, oh sorry Mr. Chang . . .”

“I’m glad you’re getting a kick out of my wife not using my last name and obviously not having my picture in her office.”

“So that’s getting you down? It’s an honest mistake. Maybe her secretary was afraid to not call you Mr. Chang in case you were a white guy whose last name was Chang. That can happen . . .” Steve’s cheeks had gone red, and he knew that his friend could enjoy a lot more laughter but was holding himself together for Josh’s sake. He took a clean napkin, and wiped his leaking eyes. His body shuddered occasionally with an oncoming laugh which he choked off. “Sorry, buddy. Sorry, that is just . . . that’s too funny.”

“I’m so glad you’re enjoying it.”

Steve crumpled his napkin, laid his forearms on the table, hands extended toward him. “Hey. What are you doing tonight?”

Now his stomach crumpled again. There was no way he was going to finish the second souvlaki. He said, “Kimmy said this morning she’d be home at a regular time, then she texted me while I’m in a meeting with fucking Rafe.”

“Asshole.”

“I know . . . she texted me to say that she’s not going to be home early. To go on and have dinner without her.”

“Ouch.”

“Yeah, you got that right. That’s why I’m having lunch with you right now because I wanted somebody to talk to.”

“Well shoot, Josh, if you’re not doing anything after work, come out with me. Come on, you bought lunch, let me take you out for a couple of beers . . .”

---

A pitcher of Creemore was split between the two of them at The Poddy Kilt, the two of them at the bar with a baseball game playing on the high mounted screens. At the end of the seventh inning Steve got a text, nudged his arm and said, “Hey, my brother’s over at the Dragon, in the old village . . .? Let’s go sit on the patio over there.”

The baseball game was almost over, and the Jays were ahead by four. Plus the misty gray day had opened up, the gray-green skies giving way to a brilliant blue and bright sunshine. And maybe he wouldn’t be home until eleven o’clock tonight. “Yeah,” he said, rubbing his cheeks, “I could use some sunshine and fresh air today.”

“That’s the spirit,” Steve said, settled up with the bartender and they headed to the cars. “We should probably take an Uber,” Steve said, and ordered one on his phone. They wandered up and down the sidewalk outside of the bar, and Josh did everything he could not to bring up Kimmy again.

But in the back of the Uber it got quiet, and his thoughts were heavy. He said quietly to Steve, “What do you think I should do about this thing with Kimmy?”

“You got me. I don’t know what to tell you. No, I do . . . Just play it cool. There’s nothing going on. But you should keep your eye out . . .”

“You really think I need to keep my eye out?”

“I’m always defending Kimmy,” Steve said, looking up toward the ceiling of the Uber. “But maybe you’re right and I’m wrong . . .”

“You think?”

“I don’t like what I’m hearing. I always pooh-pooh you—most of the time I used to think you’re just a whiner. No offense.”

“No, I know . . .”

“But, yeah . . . Could you imagine? Like what would she be doing at the Royal York that late?”

“I know,” he said, guts squirming. “Kimmy said she was at a business meeting with some Chinese people . . .”

“Family of yours, Mr. Chang?”

“Fuck you,” he said, “I’m serious.”

“Boy, you’re getting snippy. I thought it was rye that made you feisty, not some beers.”

“No . . .”

“That’s right, that was Kimmy that got feisty.” He put up boxing fists and fake punched the back of the driver’s head rest.

“At the reunion party? She wasn’t drinking, I was drinking bourbon.”

“So when you drink bourbon Kimmy gets feisty.”

He laughed, appreciating the good-natured squabble, but unable to shake an uneasy feeling. “I’m sure it was a business meeting like she said. Kimmy’s not like that.”



“I used to think she wasn’t,” Steve said, and Josh turned to see his friend looking pensively out the window, an index finger hooked in the divot under his lower lip.

“She really isn’t like that.”

“Josh: Eleven o’clock for a business meeting . . .?”

“She got home at eleven, she wasn’t there till eleven.”

Steve said, “So ten o’clock?”

He was quiet for the rest of the ride, looking out the windows as they got to the Pickering Village, working their way toward Old Ajax where the Dragon was.

When they got out of the Uber, he shoved hands in his pockets, could feel his expression shrink down to a surly pinch. Maybe he would get a real good drunk on tonight. Maybe he wouldn’t even be home at eleven o’clock. Maybe Kimmy would be lying in bed tonight wondering where the hell he was. Maybe he wouldn’t even text her. Maybe he and Steve and Steve’s brother would go out to a strip joint . . .

“Come on, cheer up, look it’s a brilliant sunny day. We’re going to sit on the patio, and I’m going to buy you another beer.”

“Just one more?”

“That’s the spirit,” Steve said, and they headed under the brick archway that led alongside the Tudor-style pub, into the alcove of shop fronts where the Dragon’s brick patio opened out to a garden.

He was saying, “It’s just, you know, I don’t even think it’s Kimmy that’s getting under my skin, it’s the . . .”

They were coming past the bar now, and a familiar face had his eyes raising from the brick pathway where he was walking and focusing. It was Meyer. His cousin was sitting at a table on the patio raising a pint glass of beer to him. And he had a momentary brain fart where he thought they were here to

meet Meyer, but as his brain found its footing he realized no, it was a coincidence. They were here to see Steve's brother and it was a surprise that Meyer was here. But then he could see Karina. Karina and Meyer, and Gabrielle, and Samara . . . And then standing was Kimmy. Still dressed in her black suit, hair pulled back, blood red lipstick on her pretty lips that now spread in a wide smile that showed her bright teeth.

Steve gasped: "What the hell are they doing here?"

He stopped short, stumbled, took another step, and stopped again. His heart thudded in his chest.

Steve broke out laughing. "I mean what are the odds that they're here?"

He was such a fucking sucker.

Everyone at the table cheered and raised their glasses to him. Kimmy came around the table, gesturing for him to come up the steps onto the patio but his feet had gone to lead. He looked to Steve sheepishly, his eyes pleading Don't tell Kimmy any of the shit that I just said . . .

At the top of the stairs, Kimmy held out her hand, said to Steve, "Great timing, Steve-O, we just got our drinks," then to him, "Josh, what the hell are you doing here at my important meeting?"

"What are you doing here?" he said, feeling his cheeks absolutely blazing hot.

"I told you I wouldn't be home for dinner."

"What is going on?"

"Something came up after work, I've got this meeting here. Do you want to come and join me?"

"Kimmy . . ."

There was a flood of embarrassment that rose up from his guts. All that stuff he'd said to Steve today, and Steve playing along. He said to Steve,

“When did you . . .?”

“Come on up and have some more beers, you douche bag,” Steve said, then skimmed past Kimmy, his hand brushing up her arm and squeezing her shoulder. Steve took the cheers meant for Josh, raised his hands over his head and joined the table, slipping in to sit next to Meyer.

“Oh my God,” Josh said, palming his forehead. “How did you do this?”

“It’s just a small dinner. It’s not a big deal.”

“Why didn’t you tell me?”

“What—and ruin the surprise?”

His eyes strained in their sockets, then went wet. All that hurt he’d suffered today from 10:30 in the morning until two seconds ago was twisting inside him like a damp rag being squeezed dry. A wonderful transformation, but a wholly uncomfortable one. He blinked tears as happiness reluctantly took the driver seat. He’d been so comfortable with anguish behind the wheel today, that anguish was reluctant to get out of the way. He almost still wanted to be mad at her. He stared at her wondrously, then she licked her lower lip, and waited for him to say something, smiling wide. Cupping her neck, he kissed her mouth.



---

## Bad Egg

It was even better than she'd expected. She and all of the invitees were sitting at two butted tables under three angled umbrellas that shielded them from the bright sun. Josh had come around the corner with his hands tucked in his pockets, obviously embroiled in a serious conversation with Steve. Her partner in crime. And Josh's features were harrowed. Disgruntled. Josh was in a bad mood. And that made her gleeful because she would be the one who would change that all around. Turn that smile upside down. Josh looked up, then there was a moment of dazedness that melted then into bewilderment. After that, raised eyebrows indicated shock and surprise. And she rose from the table, made sure he could see her. And then, his expression turned over. From grump to glee. The storm clouds broke on his features, that thunderhead of a furrowed brow easing away, and underneath it was clear his eyes showed sincere emotion. And that was what she wanted for her own sake. Yes, this was prankish, maybe silly, but she was the source of her husband's gloom. More so than he would ever know, but the look on his face now lifted her feet out of her shoes, and she tiptoed around the table, coming to the top of the stairs and extending a hand to him. Steve continued the joke, prodding Josh, laughing and chuckling, patting her on the arm and heading to the table while she wagged her hand at her husband urging him to come up. At last, he put his fingers in her hand, and they came together on the top step, her slinking her arms around him. Someone at the table made a long sound of affection seeing the two married lovebirds in such a wonderful moment. And it was wonderful.

She whispered, "I told you I was busy after work."

"I think you're a jerk," he said, pure love in his eyes.

She kissed his mouth, brought her face back and tilted to look down her nose at him, wiped the smudge of red she left on his lips. Her handsome and decent and good man. His eyes were wet and she could feel hers were too.

She whispered, “Come say hi to everybody.”

“You really did all this?” he said, taking her hand.

“Looks like it,” she said, then to the tables: “The guest of honor, everybody,” and all Josh’s friends raised their glasses.

---

Josh looked so happy at the head of the table, straddled by Steve and Meyer sitting opposite at the table’s end. Steve and Josh had already split a pitcher at another bar, and now they were into another. The food had arrived, and his cheeks were lively. And he was smiling. And laughing. Order had been restored.

Also in attendance, thanks to the aid of Steve, a huddle of girls from Swanson (all of Josh’s friends from work, other than Steve, were girls; Josh had a certain appeal) that included Samara and Gabrielle and Leah. And Quinn’s invitation had been extended via Samara, and Quinn had showed without her little one. Made her wonder if Quinn’d arranged for a sitter. If she had, it may be a good sign for Meyer. Though after the morning spent with Hyun, she somehow felt guilty for facilitating a meeting, like she was betraying Hyun in some way.

She sat at the other end of the table, with Samara on her left, and Karina on her right—which was a perfect non-conversational distance from Josh. Plus it kept her closest friend at hand, since she was buffered from her husband all the way across the table by his girl friends from work.

First thing Karina’d asked her once they got a moment alone was: “How are you guys doing?” Meaning her and Josh. It’d been a long time since she’d talked to Karina, and she’d been avoiding her friend, sadly, because she lied to her. Avoidance was easy with the change in her life circumstances. She used to see a lot of Karina, and text to her a lot, but once this job thing with Devlin had started . . .

Karina had seen it happen, had caught her rolling in the grass with Devlin. Caught her with her legs around Devlin's hips, Devlin with his cock out and trying to get it up her short leg while they wrestled in the grass. And had pursued her doggedly in the aftermath when she'd gone off with Devlin like they needed a moment to talk quietly and work out what happened (because, yes, he was trying to fuck her, but the whole thing had begun as a real argument and then a real fight). Karina was a true and good friend with nothing but her best interests in mind. Like, maybe Karina could even understand Devlin's appeal. Knew that in a moment of Kimmy's weakness what she'd witnessed in the grass could happen again. It brought her knocking on the bathroom door.

She owed Karina the apology, and would love to deserve her friendship again.

Karina had arrived after the carload of girls from Swanson, so when they met it was just a little casual, "Hey, I've missed you," hugging, and small talk. But once they were segregated from the group, Karina'd leaned close and asked if "you guys were still doing good." Translation: how is Josh doing since he knows you cheated on him? Only, it wasn't really cheating. It hadn't really happened. Of course, now it had really happened, though Karina didn't know that. And worse: she'd never told Josh the real truth. Wrestling with Devlin, yes. Penis out of his pants? No, she hadn't told him that part.

Given the dirty talk with her husband last night, she wondered if she could actually have told him the truth in the first place. Not now, of course, because she'd already lied. But what if she had told Josh the truth about what had happened between her and Devlin at Tiffany's? Told him Devlin had his cock out and was trying to get it inside her . . .

Well, you wouldn't be working for Devlin right now. And you like working for him. Well, liked the job.

So things with Karina would have to be mended, but she would have to mind where she stepped.

---

It was the two of them together now at the end of the patio table, two friends united in a larger group more familiar with each other than they were with the majority. It was good to be with Karina. Even her drink choice was better: sparkling water with lemon. Like getting back with Karina steered her return to the times they would do yoga and go out afterward for a vegan meal. In the last month—since starting at Stone—she'd been often imbibing alcohol. Not something she'd done regularly ever before, not even in college. That was Devlin's influence. But drinking with him wasn't about impairment or loosening up, it was usually about appreciating something of a finer quality. She did now enjoy a good whiskey—or at least the concept of a good whiskey. A pallet would develop with experience. Although, just like the events within the Royal York's suite last night, perhaps a passion for whiskey should be left in the past.

Karina said, "So when am I going to get you back in yoga class?"

"I really do miss it."

"Have you been going to the gym at all?"

"No. I have time in the evenings, but by the time I get home, have dinner with Josh, I'm just exhausted."

"Is he working you too hard?"

*Was that innuendo? Probably not. "It's not the work. Seriously, it's the commute . . ."*

"I hope you guys aren't thinking of moving into the city."

"We're not thinking about it all. We were looking at houses just the other day . . ."

"Are you serious? Are you guys in the market?"

"Not right now. We were fantasy shopping. But it is our goal."

"And here in Ajax?"



“Yes. We want . . . we want a family, I guess . . .”

Karina smiled, and her face showed a warmer expression that she liked to see. She hadn’t even intended to mention having a family, but definitely enjoyed the reaction. It was reassuring, like a feeling of returning after being away.

“Are you going to try again?” Karina asked the question softly. It was a delicate thing.

“Not right now. In a few years. Right now . . .” She shrugged. “I like this career.”

Karina nodded. “Do you see him often?”

“Devlin? Maybe a few times a week. He spends most of his time in Kingston. But I do know that he wants to move the head office to Toronto, and if that happens . . .”

“What’s it like?”

“Working for him? You know what?—Totally fine. It’s professional.”

“And what’s the work like?”

“Easy. No, I don’t mean easy. Straightforward. There are challenges, but I have to be honest, I really love solving them . . . let me tell you what happened today . . .”



Meyer wanted to know, but Steve was enjoying too well a hearty chuckle that prevented him from talking.

Josh said, “Never mind, anyway.”

Meyer said he really wanted to know. Steve refilled all their glasses from the pitcher, saying, “Josh has some mental problems he needs therapy for.”

Meyer said, “I already knew that.”

Josh resisted. “This isn’t . . .”

“Aw, come on, Josh, it was funny—and I hope you learned your lesson.”

“I did,” he said, hoping Steve would drop it—but knowing Meyer wouldn’t.

Meyer said, “Tell me.”

Josh scratched his neck, looking up to the underside of the umbrella. “It was just me being stupid,” he sighed.

Steve laughed, said, “You should have seen your face, you idiot, I was trying not to burst out laughing.”

“You already knew, huh?”

“Kimmy called me this morning, wanted me to get word around.”

Meyer said, “Oh, I think I know where this is going.”

Steve jabbed a thumb at Josh, leaning to Meyer and saying, “He fucking takes me out to lunch to talk.”

Meyer leaned closer so he couldn’t be overheard, nodding his chin to the end of the table where Kimmy sat close with Karina. “About . . .”

“Yeah. And I agreed with him.”

Meyer laughed. “What was he saying?”

“I wasn’t saying anything,” Josh said, trying to get in between them, reaching for his plastic-pebbled pint glass and taking a long sip.

“He starts in,” Steve said, hushed, his voice switching to an imitation of Josh’s, “you know, like, man, I really don’t know, like . . .”

Meyer said, “Like phone-tracking her?”

Steve’s eyes flitted toward Kimmy, making sure he wouldn’t get caught talking about her. “He’s just, you know, saying how worried he is, and making up stuff to worry about, you know . . .” Steve broke up, and Meyer joined him, both of them laughing at his expense. At the other end of the table he watched his wonderful wife, smiling, nodding, tossing her hair occasionally while she talked with her good friend all the way back from high school. Watched her beautiful narrow eyes, watched the high dimples on her cheeks when she laughed, the grace of her long neck, and fine hands as she enjoyed a glass of sparkling water. He’d let Devlin get between them. Just like in high school, he’d done the majority of the heavy lifting, making his bully’s work easy. Devlin had probably thought about Josh for about two minutes a day back then. But fear of Devlin consumed him. Worry over interaction, worry about getting beat up or humiliated . . . and fantasies of getting even that would never come to fruition. How many minutes a day had he worried about Devlin back then? A tiny fraction of what Devlin thought of him. And for what? The majority of the things which he worried about never happened. But they could have . . .

It was all so long ago. Why would he let this poison in his system?

He would start being more honest with Kimmy. She deserved that. He wasn’t giving her all of him. Wasn’t she his life sidekick? Then why hadn’t he been honest from the very beginning? Why hadn’t he told her about the texts on the phone saying Devlin’d visited the apartment? He kept too much to himself. Maybe she could handle a little of his mental twists. His fears. Maybe even a little of the kink he felt when he worried about her spending time with Devlin. Hadn’t the dirty talk last night been kind of amazing? . . .

*What if you trusted her to indulge you a little? I mean, she encouraged it. And why did you never tell her the rest of the story about the jacket? Why did you clip it short? It was all about saving face. Not being embarrassed in front of Kimmy. But in effect it had walled off a portion of yourself from her. Couldn’t she handle it? Wouldn’t she want to?*

Steve grabbed his neck roughly and shook him, brought him closer to the table again, pointing toward Kimmy. He said, “That woman loves you, and you don’t know how lucky you are. Look at her. She’s amazing. Super-smart, funny, she makes bank. And she spends her hard earned money on your dumb ass, trying to make you happy.”

Meyer added: “She took Sophie for me today to make this happen tonight, brought her over to Hyun’s before work so Hyun could watch her.”

“Really?”

Meyer said, “Yeah. You might want to wind it in. It’s starting to get annoying.”

“Annoying? Wait, what’s annoying?”

“You’ve got a five-star wife and you’re still trying to find ways to woe-is-me, while Steve and I would give our left nut for a woman like Kimmy. Any guy would.”

Steve said, “Maybe my right nut, too. Seriously, look at her . . .”

All three dudes watched his beautiful wife who’d planned for him this amazing and impromptu surprise. What was it in him that even now liked to wonder why, liked to think this was the act of a guilty woman? If he wouldn’t leave wounds alone, they’d never heal. If he kept playing at them, they’d fester. He swiped open his phone and showed his cousin an important gesture. He opened Find My Phone, showed Meyer, then disconnected Kimmy’s phone from his, then showed Meyer again. A symbolic gesture, one he’d probably not stick to, but it sent Meyer a confirmation that he knew just how lucky he was.

Meyer bumped his arm with his fist, and winked for a job well done. Mid-table, Quinn rose from her chair and squeezed past Gabrielle and the railing, then headed inside to the tavern.

“Now,” Meyer said, eyes tracking this young nurse he was interested in, “speaking of my nuts, I gotta go chat up Quinn.” He pushed his chair back,

then leaned close to Josh's ear, saying, "Kimmy invited her for my sake. My sake. Yeah, Kimmy's a real bad egg, cuz." He clapped his shoulder twice, then stuck his finger in Josh's ear before going around behind Steve, hot on Quinn's trail.



It was during a warm shared moment with Josh the text from Devlin came in.

Devlin: are you kidding me?

It had been one of those movie-like moments that traveled across a busy table. Two people connecting without using words, only their eyes linking one another. Josh with a beer-warm glow of ardor, and her beaming back at him. Both of them full of smiles, her head cocking, playing with her hair and batting her eyes at him. And Josh, red-cheeked, grinning from ear to ear, sipping his beer, putting it down, holding it between two hands and rotating it around in a circle. Bashful. The party she'd thrown for her husband had definitely put them back in place.

But with the text like a beacon on her upturned phone, now her attention was drawn there. She waited for this loving moment with Josh to evaporate, enjoying it's golden feeling for a few moments longer until Steve nudged Josh's arm to include him in on something he wanted to say up close. The tendrils that connected her with Josh finally were broken, Josh and her smiling one second more, then their eyes disconnected as he leaned close to hear what Steve had to say.

Then she was thumbing her phone closer, lifting it up. She texted in return.

Kimmy: are you impressed?

Devlin: can you take a call?

Kimmy: give me a minute. I'll call you

Karina was inside the tavern visiting the girls' room, now she pushed back her chair, slipped her phone in her pocket so Josh wouldn't see what it was she was leaving the table for—let him believe it was to go into the bathroom. But as she turned to the tavern, she could see Karina inside making her way to return to the table, so now she trotted down the three steps from the patio to the laneway that led up to the brick arch and the street beyond. This time, instead of heading to the street, she turned left, heading toward where the garden courtyard sat in the ring of shops. When she got around behind the table, Josh above and with his back to her now, she removed the phone and pretended to window shop. She dialed Devlin.

Devlin answered saying, “Chang, you make me very happy.” She could tell he was driving.

“I’m sure I do,” she replied, adjusting her hair in the reflection of a shop window.

“Where are you?”

“I’m out with some friends,” she told him.

“Are you in Ajax?”

“Yeah, actually a place you know . . .”

“Parked outside your gym?”

She laughed. “Close,” she said.

“I’m on the 401,” he said, “I’m going to come by.”

“No, don’t do that. I’m here with Josh.”

“That’s all right, sneak out and see me. I won’t take more than a minute.”

“What for?”

“I’ve got something for you . . . Actually, bring Josh.”

She chuckled, checked her reflection again. “I’m not bringing Josh, Devlin.”

“Serious, what I have is for him, too.”

“What do you have?”

“Bring him out and see.”

“No. It’s a terrible idea.”

He laughed, said, “Just you then.”

“Why?”

“Where are you? That tavern where we had the whisky?”

“Yeah,” she said. “But I don’t think you should come . . .”

“It’s meant to be, Kimmy. I’m on the 401, I’m passing Pickering. I’ll be there in a couple minutes . . .”



When Kimmy returned to the table, he could see a change in her eyes. Wasn't too hard to guess what it was that inspired the change. She'd gone out for a phone call. Probably talking to Devlin. But, come on, that was just talking to her boss, right? This was an opportunity. All through his shoulders and down his back he felt a deep feeling of relaxation he hadn't had in a long time. He rose, strode behind Steve, coming to join his wife and Karina, dragging an empty chair from an abandoned table behind theirs to sit between the two women.

"Look at this happy face," Karina said, and patted his cheek. He eyed her briefly, but settled his gaze on Kimmy.

Kimmy said, "It's such a nice face," and then patted the other cheek.

He took her hand and held it against him. He kissed her thumb. "Thank you," he said.

She accepted the thanks, her eyes on his. A beat later, she said, "You're very welcome."

Karina made a soft cooing sound.

He said to Kimmy, "Something up?" Knowing there was, suspecting what it might be, and looking to prove something.

Kimmy's eyes registered a small measure of alarm, but her expression didn't otherwise change.

He said, "Whatever it is . . ."

Kimmy's expression changed to that cold-lawyer look of contemplation, her eyes on his as she assessed his demeanor. She said to him, "Something



happened at work today,” then looked past him to Karina. “I was just telling Karina . . .”

Karina said, “Kimmy’s a superstar.”

He said, “I know she is.”

To Karina, Kimmy said, “I don’t like to tell Josh too much . . .”

Josh said, “My wife doesn’t like to brag . . .” But the truth was he’d told her he didn’t want to hear about it.

Karina chuckled.

Her hand he held to his face gripped his chin now, and Kimmy guided him to look at her. She said, “I saved Devlin a lot of money today.”

And this was a test. The name “Devlin” uttered to him—right in front of Karina—set his stomach tingling and rolling over. His smile faltered, but he raised his chin and kept his eyes on Kimmy’s. He said, “That guy doesn’t deserve you.”

“He sure doesn’t,” Kimmy said, matching the narrowness of his eyes.

“I hope he appreciates how lucky he is.”

“I don’t treat him half as good as you,” she said.

Platitudes and bromides. Both of them exchanging clichéd responses to one another. But somehow Kimmy’s playful banter was arousing him. She didn’t treat Devlin as well as her husband. But still treated him well? . . .

But instead of rotten Devlin-poison in his system now, with great focus his mind turned turpentine into sweet ice wine. Love for Kimmy. It was that weird hurt-slash-pleasure he could sometimes taste when he thought of her and his high school bully. Now he chuckled, and she chuckled too.

She said, “I hope it’s okay, I might have to go out and meet him.”

With tranquil calm, he said, “In the middle of my party?”

She smiled to one side, studying him.

With great Jedi mind force, he pushed the hurt away from him. And the fact that it wasn't slicing through him like it normally would made him feel strangely powerful. In control. And all this right in front of the girl who'd seen Devlin's goon drop him into a dirty laundry heap with one punch. With his eyes on Kimmy's, he focused and sent to her energy representing what he would do to her tonight when he got her home. Even grew slightly plump thinking of her words last night in bed where he'd coaxed her to say she thought of Devlin's big cock, and she consented without being freaked at him. Had she thought of Devlin's big cock today when she saved him a lot of money? . . .

He swallowed. Licked his lips and smiled. Their eyes were still connected. He said, “Invite him in.”

She turned up her nose, said, “I don't want him here.”

He said, “He's welcome.”

Karina said, “Mm, not really,” and all three of them chuckled.

Those glowing coals in his heart rose to wonderful flames. He said, “Seriously, Kimmy, you can invite him in for a drink.”

“I think he's just going to pull up out front . . . He says he has something for me.”

*His huge cock.*

“Well, go out and get it. But tell him he can come in for a drink. I don't mind at all. I haven't talked to him in a long time. And now he's your boss, so . . .”

Kimmy looked perturbed, said, “No, I'll go out to talk to him—I'll only be a few minutes . . .”



---

## Spectators

From the other end of the table now, he spied Kimmy, his wife back in conversation with Karina. And he wondered what it was they talked about. Would Kimmy be confiding to Karina about what it was like to work with Devlin? Probably not. Karina was not a fan of Devlin. Then again, he'd thought, neither was Kimmy . . .

At his end of the table, he was resumed at the head, the king of the evening, sitting now in counsel with Steve and Meyer, his cousin trying to surreptitiously talk about his exchange with Quinn the nurse. But, unfortunately, Josh was hardly paying attention, sitting and waiting for Kimmy to check her phone. That's how it would happen most likely. A text from Devlin. I'm here now. And then Kimmy would dart from the table, quick-stepping to join him . . .

Steve was talking close, both elbows on the table, his hand blocking his mouth. "What's she like?"

Meyer said, "Dude, I'm not kidding, I think she's like . . . down . . ."

Steve asked, "What do you mean down?"

"You know what I mean, like down."

"A hookup?"

"I think so," Meyer said disbelievingly.

Josh, in a low, barely-there grumble, said, "But that's not what you want . . ."

Meyer laughed. “It’s not?”

Kimmy checked her phone. His heart jumped. But she didn’t rise or leave the table. It wasn’t a text from Devlin. She was just checking her phone. Anxious for her boss’s arrival . . .

Steve said, “If you want a hookup, I’m not kidding, just go on POF . . .”

“Yeah, no, Josh is right . . . That’s not what I’m looking for . . .”

“I hope she’s not that kind of girl,” Josh said, eyes glued to Kimmy. Her eyes were turned down looking at her phone. Devlin hadn’t texted her yet, but his wife couldn’t wait to get a message from him.

Steve said, “I don’t know . . . You gotta start somewhere. The hookup could become something else . . .”

Steve said, “Girls just hook up now anyway, Josh. It’s not a big deal . . .”

“It is a big deal,” he said, then, shaking his head, he looked to Meyer who was definitely riled by his interaction with Quinn. It was unfair of Josh to be dismissive. Meyer really had gone through it with Hyun. Like got his heart broken. “Hey, man, no. It’s cool. Maybe she even thinks that that’s what you want from her. She might just be playing along, thinking she’s catching your vibe and giving you what you want to hear.”

“Yeah,” Meyer said, hollowing his cheeks and stroking his chin.

“It is what it is. Pursue it. You’re really interested in her . . .”

“She is super-cute,” Meyer said now, interlocking his fingers and stretching his arms, using it as a ploy to sneak a look mid-table and catch a glimpse of Quinn where she was in a close talk with Samara.

Kimmy was standing.

Shit. He pushed back his chair, and the legs scraped on the deck. He licked his lower lip, and even though he was trying to be sneaky, both Steve and

Meyer saw his reaction, saw the instant change in him and wondered what was up.

Steve looked to the table's end to see Kimmy standing. He said, "Is there going to be cake?"

Josh said, "No, not cake . . ."

Kimmy pushed back her chair, then her eyes flitted up to meet his—but she showed him no expression. She turned then, adjusted her suit jacket and buttoned it, smoothed a hand along her flat stomach and trotted down the steps. As she walked the alley toward the street front, her hands were up at her head, tying her hair back. He watched her impromptu ponytail sway and bounce as she strutted streetside to meet Devlin Stone.

"What is it?" Meyer poked his arm. "What's going on?"

"She has to meet her boss."

Like he was shocked, Steve hissed: "Now?"

"I know," Josh said, feeling his spirits getting kicked up. Feeling angry. How dare she . . . But when he looked to Steve, he saw that Steve was kidding again, pulling his leg like he'd done at lunch.

Josh said, "She did something at work today, something good. The guy wants to give her something . . ."

Meyer nodded, still looking at where Kimmy had disappeared. And Josh was left finishing that sentence in his own head: His big hard cock. And he hated having that thought hang in the air, like if it lingered too long one of them would detect it and know his terrible thinking. He said, "She saved him a lot of money. I think he's going to give her a bonus or something . . ."

"Meyer," Steve said, "we talk about going on POF and looking for a hookup . . . My man Josh has the world by the tail. Got it all. I mean, Kimmy is about as amazing as a woman could get."

"I know she is," he said, rolling his eyes. "Yes, she's amazing, I know . . ."

But Meyer seemed troubled, his gaze finally pulling from where Kimmy had disappeared and returning to Josh. “So that guy’s here?”

“Yeah, she’s just going to meet him. She said she was just going to be a minute . . .”

Meyer was the first one to rise. And Josh threw up no objection, instantly rising as well. And after he did, so did Steve. All three guys standing up now, not sure what they were going to do, but pretty sure it involved spying on what Kimmy was doing.

He hefted his pint glass, walked around toward the tavern, Meyer going on the other side of the table, Steve joining him on his side. They strolled aimlessly, but managed not to pick up too much attention from the women remaining at the table. When he passed Karina he didn’t say anything, looking in the windows of the tavern like that’s what had his attention. When he was past her, he stopped at the top step, peering down the alley but not seeing the streetside. Karina was right there behind them. “What are you guys doing?”

“Nothing,” he said, “just stretching our legs.”

“Step down, I want to see,” Karina said.

But when he set a foot down on the second step from the top of the patio, a waitress came out of the tavern headed to a table armed with a tray of cocktails. She said, “Oh, sorry . . . you can’t take your beer off the patio.”

“No, I know, of course not,” he said, feeling his cheeks blushing now.

He remained on the middle step and handed his beer to Karina who leaned back and put it on the table in Kimmy’s spot. He stepped down to the brick pavers, hands in his pockets, peering down the alleyway. Meyer came to join him, Steve did as well, staying on the first step and leaning over both of their heads. Karina closed in the group, coming down on Meyer’s other side and peering around Meyer’s shoulder. Four people now (attracting a ton of attention from the patio) looking down to see what Kimmy was doing.

And there at the streetside was his wife standing next to his high school bully, Devlin Stone. Devlin Stone standing tall, like a head taller than his wife. Both of them looking like they were cut from the same cloth—like they worked in the same place. Which they did. Both of them very professional, black suits, stark shirts . . . Devlin leaned casually with a hand—a large masculine hand—flat on the black roof of his low and sexy car.

Why had he enjoined all these people? All of them—Karina, Steve and Meyer—witnessing this . . . Seeing his wife standing and batting her eyes at her boss. This tall hunk of a guy who looked like the villain in a legal thriller. Black hair slicked back, handsome profile, sharp hawk-like nose and black eyes boring into Kimmy. Broad shoulders, hand on hip with his suit jacket pulled back showing his snappy belt and his expensive tie. Nice shoes, too . . .

Was that what they were all thinking as well?—look how well this guy dresses . . . look how tall he is . . . what a good build, he looks like an athlete . . .

And was Steve thinking, “Now I see why Josh would be so afraid . . .”



Despite what a terrible idea it was to allow the man you’d cheated with to come to your husband’s party, she was unable to deny Devlin. Last night she’d spent hours fucking this man. And now he was plunged into her home life reality. Devlin at work was one thing. Compartmentalized, just the way she wanted it. There was Kimmy at work and there was Kimmy at home. Two different people, two faces of the same coin. Bringing Devlin to where Josh was was like turning a coin inside out. It would destroy it. Ruin its value. At least, that was the worry. But perhaps there was another way to look at it. This thing with Devlin that had come full circle last night had been a long time coming. Now it was done. Perhaps Devlin and Josh weren’t polar opposites. It had certainly seemed like it, the two of them



when near pushing against each other. But how could this go on if that were the case? If she were to work for Devlin for the next two years, three years, maybe even four or five . . . How could her husband not be a part of work-Kimmy? How separate should they be? Completely separate, moderately separate, or what . . .? Maybe this would be the best way to find out . . .

She walked the brick pavers to join Devlin, who had somehow managed to get a parking spot right up front, even though the streetside parking had been packed when she arrived, and Samara had said she'd driven around the block twice. Lucky Devlin pulls up right at the mouth of the archway that led to the Dragon's patio and finds a spot. Fate? Possibly . . . Decisions were being made for her that she had no say in. She was the one who allowed the carnal act with Devlin to occur last night. She'd shored up all her defenses the best she could, but there were always the unknowns, the intangibles lurking around every corner. You had to be fast on your feet. Like now . . . Had Devlin got a spot four or five businesses down, she could've slipped out of sight, gone on to find out how happy she'd made her boss without worry of spectatorship.

In the last twenty-four hours she'd made Devlin very happy—probably netted him more than her annual salary in lost revenue, sucked his cock and fucked him. Now with Josh not far away, she would find out with what Devlin would reward her. Figured he would buffet her up front with proposed bawdy rewards, and it would take a few minutes to get to the truth . . .

The closer she got, the more the nerves worked through her. Not fear of some sort of discovery, some revelation of last night's transgression, but now her appearance. How did she look to Devlin? Yes, she was in some way the triumphant victor here, maybe it would look all right if she showed signs of battle. Since coming to the bar, she'd let her hair down, the crispness of her clothes had been billowed by the long day . . . Picking up Sophie, visiting Hyun, Hyun's hairdo, the meeting downtown, back to the office, another meeting, back to the office again, rushing around making phone calls to make sure Josh's party was turning out all right, then blasting out here, leaving at 4:30 with her foot to the floor of her eco-conscious car,

praying she beat Josh to his own party . . . She'd tied back her hair, tucked in her shirt, but couldn't help feeling less than a hundred percent.

How the hell did Devlin look a hundred-percent? Didn't he ever work?

"Chang," Devlin said proudly, leaned back with an elbow on the top of his Mercedes roadster. Just about parked in the spot where he'd kissed her the night he'd offered her the job she ended up taking. His suit jacket was open, his tailored dress shirt hugging tight to his lean and hard body like it was painted on. And she knew what he looked like with it off. Knew what her hands would feel if she ran them up his hips over his ribs and circled his muscular chest . . .

"You're ruining my party," she said, smiling.

Devlin sneered, said, "I won't keep you long, tell Josh not to worry. It's not nighttime . . ."

That had her glancing over her shoulder, an immediate stinging awareness of what that might sound like if overheard by her husband. "Don't be a shithead," she said, coming to stand next to him, folding her arms and turning her face up to his.

"You look fucking beautiful."

She reminded him that it wasn't nighttime.

"You're beautiful all day long, all night long, I bet. I'd love to see what you look like when you're sleeping, when you're waking in the morning . . ."

His hand moved from his hip, and she flinched. A comment like that coming from him would be perfectly complemented by stroking her face. But he only moved to scratch his own chin. Her flinching however amused him. "Don't be so tetchy," he said.

"I'm not. I just never know what you're going to do . . ."

"Same to you. That's why I'm here . . ."

“You heard from Border Services?”

“No, from Masterson.”

The client. Must be ecstatic.

Devlin said, “So how did you do it?”

“Right, so you can bring back Mel, offer him half my salary, knowing all my secrets.”

“Believe me, if I thought Mel could do what you did . . .”

“You wouldn’t want me around?”

“I’d have you at my side some way.”

“No, you wouldn’t. Don’t forget I’m just a lawyer . . .”

“Just a lawyer,” he said, “just a lawyer, she says . . .” He looked to the side as if he were saying it to a group of passing pedestrians, wondering if they could believe how humble she was.

She uncrossed her arms.

He said, “I could tell Mel all day how you did something, I can guarantee you he couldn’t pull it off. He doesn’t have your . . .”

“Are you going to say legs?”

“Well,” he said, slyly examining her from the waist down, “he definitely doesn’t—but that’s not what I was going to say . . .”

“You were going to say charm.”

“I suppose I was.” he smiled devilishly, cocking his head and looking in her eyes.

“My party’s waiting,” she said, breaking eye contact.

“When did you plan it?”

“Plan what—the party?”

“Did you plan it before we fucked or after?—Is Kimmy feeling guilty?”

Heat raced the nape of her neck, but she wouldn't show him anger. She said, “I think you're badgering the witness.”

He chuckled, eyed her up and down again, strumming a big hand on his midsection, his knuckles rubbing up and down the bulges of his stomach muscles which she could practically see right through his tight dress shirt.

She said, “I'm not feeling guilty.”

“You should. God, if Josh could see the way you come . . .”

“Don't be an asshole,” she said with venom, “Josh's seen me come.”

There was a look of satisfaction on his face. Like he hadn't meant to challenge Josh's ability more than he tried to engage her in dirty repartee. And he'd succeeded. She'd just talked about an orgasm . . .

“What happened last night is done, Devlin. What you see before you now is your star employee. Employee of the month, I daresay. I certainly would like to see my photograph on a plaque in our lobby. And from last night onward that's all I'm going to be. Star employee . . .”

Devlin showed her an aloof, easy expression. He didn't believe her. He looked around again at passing pedestrians, lounging against his expensive car. He said, “Best sex of your life should probably only happen once. You're right. I'm crazy to think we should do that once a week. Or more . . .”

He chanced a sly look her way, and even though she was ready for it, and a little perturbed with him now, it did its magic, tightening her stomach and working through her central nervous system. More sex with Devlin was momentarily considered. Only a fraction of a second. She said, “It's done. And what's done is done. I need to move on . . . You need to move on . . .”

“I can move on if you want, Kimmy. I was hoping I could show you a lot more . . .”

“I’m happy with the way it turned out, Devlin. But I’m done.”

He nodded once, changing the subject, saying, “How was that IV?”

She smiled.

“Right? The fucking bomb. I mean, didn’t you feel like brand-new?”

“I definitely appreciate it.”

“Sent you home all riled up, didn’t it? Getting Josh to do that thing . . .”

She averted her eyes. “I don’t want to talk about it . . .”

“You did last night,” he said.

“It’s daytime now. A new day, Devlin. I just called you last night to wrap the events up with a nice epilogue.”

He smiled again. “I think the epilogue was my favorite part.”

“I’m not even going to touch that,” she said. “Why don’t you just tell me why you dragged me out of my party?”

He leaned away, exposing his center to her, neck craned, looking down the alleyway from where she came. She took the moment to admire his body the way it was exposed and pressed up against the fine fabric of his dress shirt. His silk tie askew. Even letting her eyes dip a little lower, see if she could detect his bulge in the crotch of his suit pants. It wasn’t there, and she wondered what he did to hide that thing during the day . . .

He said, “Looks like Josh and his little buddies are checking up on us.”

Her skin prickled, seeing where he was looking. Was Josh coming?

She whispered, “Is he coming over?”

Devlin smiled, his eyes still down the alleyway. “No, but he’s watching. Thinks we can’t see him. He’s got his fan club with him . . .”

“Is Karina there?”

Devlin’s humored face melted to concern. “Shit, is that Karina?”

“Karina’s here . . .”

“Why would you invite her?”

“She’s my friend, Devlin.”

He chuckled. “She’s gonna rat you out, you know . . .”

“She wouldn’t.” She might.

“I bet you she’s looking right now and knows we fucked last night.”

Now he was getting to her. She’d come in with her hands up, elbows tucked in, but he’d sneaked past her guard and was softening her defenses.

“She won’t know.”

Devlin cocked his head at her. “A woman can tell. A woman can tell when her friend’s been fucked right . . .”

“Josh fucks me right.”

“No offense, Chang, but if Josh fucked you right, I wouldn’t have got you laid out in that suite last night begging to have it deeper.”

The urge came now to lash out at him. To quit his job, to tell him to fuck off, even to put her hands on him. Just like at Tiffany’s party—how this whole thing began . . .

She composed herself. “How many are looking?”

“Josh, a blonde girl, I guess that’s Karina—”

“Do you need glasses?”

“I see just fine. Two others.”

*Steve and Meyer.*

Devlin said, “If they’re looking, maybe we should put on a show . . .”

“Don’t you dare. The show’s over. Don’t make this hard for me. You came here to reward me, the biggest reward right now is for you to leave me alone . . .”

“No,” he said, “I don’t think I will,” and now he raised up a hand, gesturing down the alleyway, wagging his fingers to Josh in a come-hither motion . . .





---

## Gift

The walk along the shaded alley was dreadful. Every doubt and weakness throbbed within him. He was exposed, two sets of eyes watching him. One his bully, the other his beautiful wife. Both of them looking well-suited together. How were his clothes? Was he walking too fast? Was that too eager? Was he walking too slow? Did that show fear? What about what he was wearing? Were they laughing at his clothes? His hair? This was like high school hallway all over again. Transported in time back ten years ago. But that was all supposed to be left behind. How ingrained was it that he could feel it now? That woman watching him wasn't some high school bitch-queen whom he fantasized about. No, that was Kimmy Chang. Shit, no—more precisely: Kimmy Waters . . .

*The woman you married. In high school, she was just like you. In high school she was one of the good ones. Sweet and kind and studious. Compassionate. Don't equate her with Devlin . . .*

And now, even if it looked stupider, he walked more erect, more upright. Thrusting out his chest. That worry was all ten years ago. That woman with Devlin was his wife. Devlin couldn't be so lucky . . .

As he drew nearer, merging into the sunlight beyond the brick archway and onto the sidewalk, Devlin hauled himself off his roadster, extended a hand to shake. "Josh Waters," he said, "wow, it's been a long time . . ."

"Hey, Devlin," he said, avoiding too-long eye contact and shaking Devlin's hand—Jesus, how big was his hand?—averting his eyes, not because he was afraid to lock them with Devlin's but because he wanted them connected with Kimmy's. And when his gaze met hers, she smiled, cocked

her head, and they communicated between them what had been said at the table. Invite him in. I want that. He was the bigger man here. Well, not literally bigger.

“Josh, I haven’t seen you in so long,” Devlin said.

“We were both at Tiffany’s.”

“Right,” Devlin said, acting like it hadn’t registered.

Josh said, “Didn’t we talk there?”

Devlin thought about it then shook his head no, saying, “I don’t think so . . .”

“Well, whatever . . . how’ve you been doing?”

“How’ve I been doing? I’m more impressed by how you’re doing . . .” His grin was sly, his dark eyes narrow.

This was all bullshit. They’d talked at the party at Tiffany’s and why the hell would he not admit it? For Kimmy’s sake?—what lies was he telling Kimmy? . . . Then again: it was Dream-Devlin who’d told him they’d talked, and Dream-Devlin may never have existed at all . . . He stayed magnanimous, a good beer buzz giving him confidence in the awkward moment, and a little kick out of standing face-to-face with this guy who’d dominated his thoughts when they were younger and not crumpling. Adult Josh doing what Young Josh was unable, despite the current fears that had taken hold of him. He said, “Why’s that?”

“You married Kimmy—my star lawyer,” he said, thumbing towards Kimmy, whose expression now transformed. The warmth went taut. Anxiousness. Or fear . . .

“Or you hired my star wife,” he said with a smile. “But, yeah, I know how lucky I am.”

Devlin was trying to hold his gaze but he wouldn’t let him. Devlin said, “Hey, sorry I busted up your party—I didn’t mean to . . .”

“That’s all right,” he said, “did you want to come in for a beer?”

“Nah,” Devlin said, “I don’t want to intrude. I’m just passing through, anyway, heading back to Kingston . . .”

“You’re welcome to join us. I’d like to have you . . .”

“Thanks, Josh. But I just came for your wife.”

Devlin’s features had hardly changed, but he swore there was a sneer there. That was a direct statement. I came for your wife. Dream-Devlin’s words echoing in his mind right now: Just like you asked me to. Devlin telling him point-blank Oh, yeah, we definitely talked at the party, Joshy. His stomach slithered, and a sliver of anger sliced through him.

He steadied himself, his mind wrestling with those dark thoughts, not wanting to be consumed by them. Defeated by them. Don’t do his work for him, Josh. Don’t make it easy. Kimmy won’t fall for his bullshit. She’s way too smart. He smiled, nodded, looked to his wife. “What did she do?”

“She didn’t tell you?”

*I won’t let her tell me because I let you get between us even when you’re not between us. I let your black magic work through me without you ever breaking a sweat casting the spell . . . “She told me a little. We’ve been busy.”*

Kimmy smiled and he soaked up strength from it.

Devlin said, “Kimmy did in five business days what was going to take ABM to do in probably twelve. And every day that it went without being resolved was costing a client money.”

“Who’s ABM?”

“Outside legal,” Devlin said, waving it away like it wasn’t interesting. “I definitely did the right thing hiring her.” Devlin looked Kimmy’s way, and Kimmy’s smile turned to Devlin. It was torture.

He cleared his throat, said, “Did you doubt it?”

“Nah, I don’t make mistakes—not like that, at least. Once I talked to her at Tiff’s, she was all I could think of.”

His hamstrings lost tension, his belly gave birth to a freezing cold stone. It was a message . . .

But it wasn’t. It was all in his own head.

He fumbled for a response, and Kimmy’s face had tightened to a mask of fear; eyes wide, pouting lips pinched to a purse.

Devlin continued: “You remember her in high school, I don’t have to tell you. Perfect marks, so . . . dedicated. Tells me she’s a lawyer now, and I’m always looking for talent.”

Kimmy licked her lower lip, giving Devlin all the attention now, burning her gaze on his. His heart thudded at the awful sight.

Still looking at Kimmy, Devlin said, “Now I know what she’s got . . . She sure showed me . . .”

Kimmy corrected her look, resumed the blankness she used to hide her emotion, said, “It wasn’t a big deal. Just a few meetings.”

“I haven’t seen anyone turn Border Services around like that.”

Kimmy steel-eyed him, nodding.

Josh cleared his throat, said, “I’ll let you talk to her. I don’t want to intrude. Once you guys are done, seriously, Devlin, you should come back to the patio for a beer . . .” The way his heart hammered right now, it took everything he had to manufacture the unperturbed look on his face. And like Young Josh of old, he was looking to bail . . .

“Thanks, Josh,” Devlin said, “Hey, though, don’t go . . .”

“Oh yeah?” Now all he wanted to do was go. He’d done the brave thing, coming out here, getting a close-up look at his wife standing with Devlin. Got a sense that they had a certain camaraderie together, Kimmy and Devlin. Met face-to-face with Devlin. And now a new reality was starting to sink in that he didn’t like. Kimmy had done a good job for Devlin. Devlin was glad he hired her. Things were going well. How much farther would they go . . .?—even if the dark thoughts he had were untrue . . .

Devlin said, “What I have for Kimmy is for both of you. You’ll both enjoy it . . .” Now from an interior suit pocket, Devlin produced a cream-colored envelope, held it aloft so they both could see it. Kimmy reached for it, and Devlin moved it from her grasp.

Kimmy looked anxious again. She said, “Can I just have it, please?”

“Yeah, you can have it—but it’s for both of you,” and now Devlin moved it nearer to Josh.

Josh reached for it, then paused. Devlin said, “Take it,” and jabbed it toward him. “You do the honors, Josh.”

Kimmy said, “Josh, can I have it?”

“Let her take it,” he said, but Devlin persisted.

“Josh, take it. You open it and see what’s inside . . .”

And Kimmy persisted, saying, “No, Josh, let me take it . . .”

“Why?” he said, feeling anxious now, the crazy throbbing vibes coming off his wife beginning to work simpatico on his own system. “What’s in it?”

“Open it,” Devlin encouraged, and now Kimmy’s hand retracted, surrendering to the moment, and Josh had the distinct realization that Kimmy feared what was in the envelope. What would be in it that she would be afraid of? What could be in their that would alarm her? A note from Devlin? I fucked her at Tiffany’s party. She was so tight. What else? A photograph? Now his heart pounded. A photograph of Kimmy laid out on

her back, her legs open, the picture taken down a muscular body, and from between its legs sprouted an enormous tree branch of a cock. And that tree branch of a cock disappeared inside Kimmy's tight pussy. The muscular body and huge cock unidentified, but the fact the picture was delivered by Devlin would tell just who it belonged to and who it was entering . . .

When he took the envelope from Devlin, his hand was shaking. "What's in it?"

"Your reward," Devlin said. "Open it, and find out . . ."



An inventory of salacious items raced through her mind. What would fit in that envelope? He'd taken her panties inside the cargo container. There couldn't be panties in the envelope . . . What about a picture? Remember when you spread your legs on that pallet of fertilizer and Devlin took a picture? That picture existed. Did he print it out and put it in an envelope to torture you and ruin your marriage? But why would he do that? You're a good employee. Just made him money today. You're a new hire. If he did that, couldn't you make an ethics complaint? But still . . . What about last night? Maybe the bill for the suite. Something like that? Maybe after he'd fucked you into oblivion he snapped a picture of you unconscious on Royal York linen . . . What if it was just something unintentionally devastating? Something that contradicted one of her many lies told directly to Josh's face . . . Her heart thudded, her temples pounded with her pulse.

"Hey, Josh, here let me," she said. If she couldn't get the envelope from Devlin, she could definitely get it from Josh.

But Josh wasn't hearing, and she wasn't forceful enough. Josh's hands were trembling. What was he anxious about? He suspected her. He didn't trust her. Knew this was going to be bad . . .

“Hey, Josh,” she said again, “let me,” moving toward him. And Josh took a half-step backward, pulling now from the open envelope a sheaf of folded paper. Unfolding it now and reading. She crossed her arms, tightened them against her body. That trembling she saw in Josh’s hands transferring now to her knees. Josh read what was on the sheet, brow lowering as he struggled to comprehend.

*I fucked her last night, Josh. I fucked your wife. She went down on me, I made her come. She told me no one makes her come like I do . . .*

When Devlin touched her arm she jumped, swiveled at the hips to pull her elbow from his grasp. It only made him smile.

She said, “What does it say?”

Josh said, “I don’t get it . . .”

“Sorry,” Devlin said, “not much of a reward, I guess . . . I need Kimmy to work this weekend.”

Josh showed real disappointment. “This weekend?”

“Tell her what it says . . .”

Josh said, “It’s an itinerary,” looking to her now.

She said, “An itinerary for what?”

“I don’t know . . . like a conference, or . . . There’re mealtimes, and you have to meet with Mr. Rathburn . . .”

Devlin said, “He’s a lawyer. And an advisor . . .”

She looked to Devlin, puzzled. “What for?”

“Sorry—it’s a real shame it’s going to take up most of the weekend since it’s really just a brief meeting. But that’s the way these things go . . .”

Josh was still reading, and he said now, “The Cayman Islands?”

Devlin smiled, looked her way. “Sorry, Kimmy, I need you to work this weekend. Hope that’s cool . . .”

“I don’t want to work this weekend,” she said.

He said, “It’s just a meeting . . .”

“Why? Cayman . . .?”

Devlin said, “You don’t want a bunch of bonuses, trust me. You lose it all in fucking taxes. I need you to take Friday off, head to Cayman, I want you to talk to my advisor. I want you to listen to what he says, tell me if you think he’s treating me fairly . . .”

“Is he Chinese?”

“Asian?—no. He’s black. I think he’s from Trinidad.”

“What do I have to talk to him for?”

“Kimmy—that’s the reward. We use a villa out there. Three days in Cayman, two seats on a private jet. Go out there Friday morning, do whatever, Saturday morning you meet with Rathburn. Come back Sunday . . .”

She grimaced, stomach twisting. “Like a vacation?”

“Totally a vacation. All expenses paid. Business expense. No taxes . . .”

“Oh,” she said, the shaking returning. How would she soothe this with Josh? How was she going to explain going away with Devlin for three days on a private jet to a Caribbean villa . . .?

Josh flipped over the paper, saw there was nothing on the other side, then shrugged. “So what’s this got to do with me?”

“It’s for spouses, too. I mean if Kimmy wants to take you . . .”

“Oh,” she said laughing, palming her forehead, relieved.



“What’s up with you two?” Devlin said, eyeing both of them. “I mean, I thought you guys were savvy. Do you not get what I’m saying?”

Josh said, “No, I mean, yeah, I think I . . . do.”

“Jesus, you two . . . I just gave you a vacation. Three days, all expenses. Food, drink, spa . . . whatever else you want to do when you’re there, put it on the company card, Kimmy. Three days in the Caymans, most people would shit their pants, maybe even hug me a little. Not a penny out of your pocket, and no extra taxes . . .”

Josh slowly began to smile, and seeing that change in his expression brought her intense feelings of relaxation and happiness. Relief. Her knees sagged, and she felt a burden off her shoulders. Of course she’d be going with Josh . . .

Devlin said, “Josh, if you don’t want to go, I’ll be glad to take her . . .”

Josh’s eyes snapped toward Devlin. There was a brief flash of anger, and she worried what would happen in the next second. But then the anger widened, was replaced by something that she thought might be fear. Poor Josh. Josh had always been put under by this man. And now he was doing it again. She said, “I’m taking Josh with me. Josh, right?—we’re going to go . . .”

“Of course,” he said, practically stammering.

Now she knew what he was thinking. He’d also been thinking she would be going with Devlin. She thought of what he’d said to her in bed last night. How he’d said Tell me you were thinking of his cock, and now how could she not think about that big cock. Josh had put it in her head. It was already there, but Josh would think he’d put it in her head. Josh was now regretting ever mentioning Devlin’s cock to her. It was all too late, anyway . . .

She moved to Josh, slunk her arm around his middle and side-hugged him. Both of them faced Devlin who stood superior over them. She said, “Thank you, Devlin. Thank you—I get it now. It’s very kind . . .”

“Do you not like Cayman?”

“No,” she said, chuckling, resisting the urge to bat at Devlin in front of Josh. “We’ve never been. I want to go. We want to go. We definitely want to go,” she said, tugging on Josh’s waist and getting him to turn to her. His eyes slowly traveled to hers and she looked in his dumbfounded eyes. “Right? Three days in the Cayman Islands. Can you get Friday off?”

“Of course he can get Friday off,” Devlin said to Josh, “You’re at Swanson, right?” Josh said he was, and Devlin said, “Swanson’s great—I know a guy who used to work there.”

“Oh yeah—who?”

“He was a VP. Daniels . . .”

And then Josh said: “Is he a friend of your dad’s?”

There was a coldness in his voice. Completely incongruous with the moment. Josh was mad. Josh was lashing back. Bringing up Devlin’s dad. And Devlin sensed it too. Sensed it and didn’t like it. Some of the command he had of the situation faltered, a ripple in his force field. His confident expression faltered, the tug of his one-sided smile softening for a moment as his eyes pored over Josh, figuring what he would do next. The smile returned, he said, “No. Yeah, he was older. Daniels was a mentor back in biz school.”

“Yeah,” Josh said, “I remember Daniels. He wasn’t in Ajax, he was downtown.”

Devlin studied Josh still, looking bemused. “So can you get Friday off?”

Josh said, “I don’t need help to get Friday off.”

“I wasn’t saying that I’d help.”

She dug her fingertips into Josh’s hip. All the concern she’d had in the moment revolved around her transgression with Devlin. A very selfish and self-centered thought. Now she had to recover. If she was a woman who’d

never slept with Devlin, then she would need her husband to smarten up right now. Digging her fingertips into Josh's waist was the most silent way of hissing his name in his ear and saying Stop it.

Josh nodded, said, "I've never been to Cayman. I'll get the time off . . ."

She squeezed his side. "We'll go?"

Josh licked his lips, and his eyes showed concern. Concern maybe only she recognized. He was jealous and hurt and trying not to show it. What was he thinking about? Was he thinking about Devlin taking her instead if he couldn't get Friday off? Worrying about that? Devlin would offer again if Josh couldn't. Was he worrying about the dirty things he'd asked for last night and how now he was confronted with it during the day? The man from his dirty thoughts with the incredibly big penis standing right in front of him and giving his wife a gift . . .

Completely unexpected now: A distinct provocative arousal. She tightened her thighs, sucked in her stomach and held her breath, trying to keep awful thoughts at bay. "Okay," she said, voice tight, "Josh, right?—we're going to go to Cayman . . ."

Devlin steamrolled ahead: "You guys are going to have a good time. That's a Michelin star on the itinerary there, and when you go to the spa, Josh, ask for Jenny . . ."

She shot Devlin a baleful look. Devlin showed his palms, laughing. "No, not like that. It's not like that—I don't mean, you know, a happy ending . . ."

Josh turned up his nose, not liking Devlin talking about sexual things in front of her.

"Anyway," Devlin said, unharmed, "both of you pick Jenny and take turns. There's a Jenny and a Jeremy, if you guys want to stay same-sex that's on you, everybody's got their own rules." Devlin's smug smiling face stayed on Josh, looking to weigh him down.

Devlin said no more, and though the moment wasn't that long, it felt thin and tight and dreadful. Both Josh and Devlin willing to exist in a moment of tension looking at each other. She sought quickly to extinguish it, saying, "Okay, Josh, we're going to Cayman this weekend."

"We are," Josh said.

Then to Devlin, she said, "Thank you, Devlin. That's an amazing gift. We'll both be very happy to go, and I'm sure we'll have a great time."

"It'd be hard not to have a good time," he said. "Look, if you keep hitting home runs like that, and I have a feeling you will, Kimmy, I can't just keep throwing down money at your feet. It won't help you. The government'll take it. There are other things, other benefits I offer . . ."

Her ribs tightened their grip around her heart, sensing a possible direction for Devlin's train of thought. Not that he would blurt out something lewd, but that he would insinuate something and crafty and sensitive Josh would pick up on it. So she said to Josh, "Okay, Devlin has to go, Josh, can you give me a minute alone with him before he does?" And regretted it momentarily, seeing a look of hurt in her husband's eyes. She added softly: "I'll just be a minute . . ."

Josh found strength, said, "Yup, okay," raising his chin, narrowing his eyes at her making her feel better. Then to Devlin, Josh said, "Devlin, good to see you," gave a halfhearted wave at waist level before turning out of her hugging arm and heading down the alley.

Devlin stopped him. "Hey, Josh . . ."

And she wanted to interject again, prepared herself to sever any conversation Devlin might try to pursue.

Josh turned back, and Devlin said, "What's your number?"

"My phone number?"

Devlin said, "Yeah. We should talk sometime."

“We should?”

“For sure,” Devlin said earnestly. “Let me buy you lunch or something, go out for a coffee . . . We should probably talk, right?”

The color had drained from Josh’s cheeks. “About what?”

“Do you have a card on you?”

Josh shook his head no.

Devlin said, “We’re both grown up now. We should talk. Wipe the slate. You now . . .”

Josh said, “We should . . .”

Devlin had his phone out now, saying, “What’s your number?” Josh told him, Devlin entered it into his contacts, then from a jacket pocket offered a business card. Josh took it, read it, put it in his pants pocket.

Devlin offered his hand again, and Josh was timid but put his out as well. They shook again. Devlin said, “I’ll be in touch.”

Josh nodded, and she said, “I’ll just be a minute, okay, Josh?”

Josh was speechless and she tightened inside seeing him suffering this way—but at least he was dealing with it. He nodded a good-bye, heeled and looked both ways before crossing the sidewalk.

She watched him return down the alleyway headed to the Dragon’s patio, sunlight falling on his back until he was under the arch. Devlin watched with her, then when Josh was halfway to the patio, Devlin said, “I think that went pretty well.”

She said, “You’re an asshole, you know?”

He laughed, faced her, showed a little-boy-in-trouble face, saying, “What the hell did I do? I thought I was pretty good . . .”

“Why would you invite Josh over for that?”

“Because he’s going to go to Cayman with you . . . Oh shit, Kimmy, did I wreck it for you? If I didn’t call him over, were you going to go with me?”

“Not a chance,” she said.

“You sure? I mean, it is a business trip . . . And I love Cayman . . . And believe me, I know how to have fun when I’m there. You’d definitely have a way better time with me.”

“This is what I’m talking about . . .”

“What? Why’re you mad at me?”

“I’m not mad at you. You just stressed me out.”

He sucked his teeth and made a sound like she was overreacting. “If I slobbered all over Josh’s little knob in front of you, he’s going to think I’m up to something.”

“So you displayed your normal arrogant self.”

Devlin loved it, smiling. “That was for your benefit.”

She stared at his handsome face now aimed toward her, eyes lightly squinted against the brightness of the sun. He smiled, kept his confident gaze on hers.

“You have a point,” she said.

Devlin nodded. “Kimmy’s going to have it all. She must be excited. Good husband, decent guy who worships her, killer job, big pay, trips to Cayman, and other perks . . . oh, and absolute mattress-melting sex with her boss. Oh my God, think how good her life is.”

She shook her head at him, stifling a smile, unable to ignore the ghostly stretch his large size had left her with, like her opening was slowly microscopically stitching itself back together after the pounding that cock

had given her. Smug and arrogant as he was, there was a charm there, a dominance and confidence.

“Josh is a good guy, Kimmy—I see why you married him. That guy is going to be faithful, devoted . . .”

“He is. Why do you want to meet with him?”

“It’s not good to meet with him?”

“Why did you take his phone number?”

“Oh, that reminds me,” Devlin said, leaning on his roadster again. “I was thinking about something . . .”

“About what?”

“What you said at the Clockwork yesterday. About me texting Josh or whatever. And how I said I didn’t do it . . . I don’t know if you believe me or not . . .”

“I don’t know who to believe.”

“Wow, that hurts. It occurred to me later—just this morning—I think I told Amy I put my card in your drawer . . .”





---

## Horse

First thing she thought was it was a lie and Devlin was up to something. She hid the puzzlement from her face, saying, “What does Amy know about it?”

“About what?”

“You told her you were thinking of hiring me?”

He shrugged.

“So what are you saying?”

Devlin narrowed his eyes like it was her not keeping up. “You’re saying that nobody else would know where the card was. So it had to be me texting Josh. I’m just saying I’m not the only one who knew the card was there.”

“Amy wouldn’t text him.”

He shrugged again and chuckled. “Amy’s a psycho.”

“No she’s not.”

“Amy’s all polite smiles, but look in her eyes. She’s got that killer instinct inside her like you do, but she likes letting hers off the leash.”

She ran her tooth up and down her lip watching Josh disappear now up onto the patio and wondered what he would say to Steve and Meyer and Karina. Trying at the same time to run herself through the pinball machine of Josh’s

claim of taunting texts. How would it work that Amy had texted him? Why would Amy do that?

Devlin said, “So I guess you won’t be coming to work on Friday.”

She brightened, smiling now. “I’m flying to Cayman.”

“Josh backs out, you let me know. I’d love to show you around.”

“Josh will go,” she said.

Devlin nudged her elbow with his, getting her to look his way. “But if he doesn’t . . .”

She laughed. “Yeah, I’ll let you know.”

“It is a business trip, after all.”

“It is,” she said quietly as her mind levitated for a moment, toes coming off the earth, shown flickered images of being in Cayman with Devlin Stone. Being seen with him in restaurants, having him swimming with you, on the beach, Devlin with his shirt off, and at night . . .? Being in bed with him, doing the things they’d done last night while the ocean roared beyond their villa window . . .

She said, “You better go.”

“Think about it,” he said.

“I’m going with Josh.”

“Maybe some other time . . .”

As her mind was off in Cayman with a six-foot-two man with black devil eyes and a handsome face, rock hard body, and a huge confident cock, she met Devlin’s gaze, no clever comebacks unfurling from her tongue. Instead, she smiled, and the smile slowly became a breathy chuckle.

“We’re going to have a lot of fun together, Chang. I know you’re in love with your husband. All I’m saying’s I want to spend some time with you. Off the books, on the books, Toronto, Cayman, hotels, my house, your apartment . . . no rush, no pressure. Anytime you want to roll, I’m so down to get my hands on that fucking body of yours. What we did last night was just the tip of the iceberg—the things I want to do with you, I know you’d beg for more. Let me know when you’re ready again.”

People passed by on the sidewalk, smiling, out-of-shape, old, generally incongruous, oblivious to the dirty talk happening feet away from them. She looked in his eyes, shaking her head at his brusqueness. “You thought about it more, what we did?”

He smiled with satisfaction, knowing he’d drawn her into the kind of talk she’d sworn she wouldn’t engage in at her husband’s party. “I think of weird little things . . .”

“Yeah—like what?”

His eyes scanned her body, then: “I think of the sexy knobs of your hipbones, how they jut out cause your stomach is so flat. Think of your tight navel, think how I could see my cock move under your belly . . .”

Unexpectedly breathy: “You could see that?”

He snickered. “You’re a tight tunnel, a perfect glove on my cock, and no woman’s moved better on it.”

His black eyes locked hers, and she felt that heavy feeling again, a saturation in her core, wet with sudden need.

His eyes shifted leftward, down the alley. Hers followed suit, saw no spies aiming their attention toward them. Devlin touched her hand, just over the curve of her wrist, his thumb stroking her skin. She didn’t pull away, enjoyed his touch against her. “Tell me when,” he said.

She whispered, “You tell me . . .”



Karina and Meyer met him around the corner on the patio steps, Steve looming above them. Quinn, too, being nosy. Karina recognized the disgruntled look on his face seeing everybody watching and waiting. She put her hands on him, both hands on his collar, slowing him down and saying, “What’s going on?”

“Nothing,” he said, avoiding her gaze, looking at the others. Was everybody watching him and Kimmy and Devlin? “Nothing,” he said again, “he just came by because Kimmy saved him a lot of money. I don’t really know what it’s about . . .”

“Hey,” Karina said, still with her hands on his shoulders, “you okay?”

He stopped, realized despite the chagrin he felt twisting up his insides, he had to put on a braver face for everyone. He laughed, said, “Sorry, yeah, no, I’m okay.” Then: “Looks like I’m spending the weekend in the Caribbean.”

Meyer took a step down, peeked around the corner down the alleyway at Kimmy and Devlin again, saying, “What do you mean?”

“The company’s sending Kimmy to Cayman for the weekend. Like a business-slash-pleasure trip, and I’m going with her.”

Steve’s eyebrows raised so high the small space between them and his hairline furrowed into a half-dozen lines. “The Caribbean? Holy shit, Josh . . .”

“I know,” he said, running a hand through his hair, trying to parse the situation. Was he embarrassed? Why did he feel embarrassed? Was it because his company didn’t provide them with a vacation to the Caribbean? Or was it that it was Stone himself sending him and Kimmy somewhere exotic and expensive? It was all those things at once, and now put in tight

proximity with his friends, he was unable to express to them anything truthful, saying, “I’m going to have to buy some suntan lotion . . .”

Meyer supported him, offering up the downside: “It’s sunny here now. He should send you guys when it’s winter . . .”

“Right?” Like it made any sense to complain about such a wonderful weekend gift.

Steve said, “I’ll go if you don’t want to.”

They all laughed, and it broke some of the spell he’d been under. Quinn had heard enough and now returned to the table. He wondered what she would whisper to her friend Samara. Kimmy’s definitely fucking her boss, or, Fucking Josh gets a trip to the Caribbean and isn’t even grateful. What a misogynist. So what if his wife has a better job than him . . .

He said to Steve: “What, you and Kimmy? What about me?” Lane, but it kept the laughter rolling a moment as he regained his composure.

Steve threw up his hands like, Hate to do it to you, but whatever way I can get it I would go . . . And seeing Steve’s natural response to a Caribbean trip juxtaposed with accompanying Kimmy reminded Josh of Devlin’s offer to take Kimmy instead of him. What a fucking asshole. Who would say something like that to a woman’s husband? Oh, I’ll take your fucking wife for you. Devlin was such a piece of shit. It was barely funny when Steve implied it, and Steve was a good friend. Devlin was nothing to him . . .

Now he was shaking his head, and Karina finally let him go, finding some amusement in his irritation. She peeked around the corner as well, watching for Kimmy. She said, “It doesn’t sound too bad, Josh.”

With reluctance, he said, “No, the . . . fucking guy made it sound like it’s something we should get used to, too.”

“Going to the Caribbean?”

“No, well, yes, I guess, but bonuses in general. He doesn’t want to pay her more, because of taxes . . .”

“Jesus Christ,” Steve groaned. “How much is he fucking paying her?” Then he looked away, embarrassed when everybody side-glanced him, realizing that was a question you didn’t ask, even though Josh was sure Steve hadn’t mean it to be answered.

“Well, good for Kimmy,” Meyer said, nodding, his mouth turned down in an affirmative U-shape.

He agreed. “Yeah, good for her.”

Steve turned and set his beer glass down on the table next to his where Kimmy would be sitting, came back reached down to pull Josh up to the patio. “Get up here,” he said, “hey, come on . . .”

Josh trudged to join him on the patio.

Steve said, “Dude, a guy who’s going to the Caribbean for the weekend should have a much happier face. All expenses paid?”

“Yeah.”

“Come on, Josh—how is it I’m happier about it than you are?”

“Private plane, too,” he said now, smirking.

“The guy has his own plane?”

Karina scoffed. “I doubt it.”

“No, “ Meyer said, probably like still a charter or something, I don’t know how it works.”

Steve was still impressed. “Either way . . . Josh, you have to appreciate how lucky you are . . .”

Meyer laughed and interjected, putting a hand on Steve's arm and saying, "He's good," laughing still, "Josh's good, man . . ."

Josh agreed, too. "I'm good," he said, trying to show a brighter face. His chagrin was becoming the point of focus, and everybody else from Swanson sitting at the table was looking his way now, trying to decipher what it was that was happening. A real live soap opera playing out before their eyes. So he laughed, punched Steve's arm good-naturedly in a theatrical way, a performance for his audience. Meyer moved away, heading to return to his seat, stopping mid-table to lean close to Quinn and talk. Josh shooed Steve away saying, "It's nothing, you're totally right. I don't know how to accept good things . . ."

"You totally don't, man," Steve said, wagging a finger at him but then returning to the table. Josh put his hands in his pockets and pivoted, intending to linger at the stairway to wait for Kimmy's return. Karina was smirking at him.

She said, "Very impressive, Josh."

He smirked too. "You think so?"

"I'm happy for you."

"Thanks," he said.

Now she got closer like she had something else to say, something more private. When she was at his side, she said, "Kimmy says—I'm probably talking out of school, but I don't care—Kimmy says you guys have never been better."

"She said that?"

"She did. Don't you think so?"

"I don't think we were ever bad," he said, frowning, looking away.

Karina said, "No, but after Tiffany's . . ."

“What about after Tiffany’s?”

Karina’s brow lowered with the weight of concern. “She told you . . .”

He winced, grumbled. Kimmy’d talked to her and Karina knew—but of course, she’d been there to see it happen . . . He said, “About . . . Devlin?”

“Yeah . . .”

He sighed, looked aside where Kimmy might appear, feeling uncomfortable. “Yeah, we talked about it,” he said. “So Kimmy said to you we’ve never been better?”

“Shoot, Josh, I didn’t mean for this to be worrying. I shouldn’t have said anything. I was trying to be positive . . .”

“No, Karina, it is positive,” he said, “it’s just that . . . Yeah, we are doing really good right now. But I don’t know if I would say we’re . . . Like, better than ever. That would mean she thought we weren’t good before . . .? Doesn’t it?”

“No,” she said, “Jesus, Steve is right. You don’t know how to take good things.” She smiled, running her fingers on his upper arm and then squeezing his elbow.

“You think that’s true?”

She pooched out her lips, tucking her chin down and looking in his eyes. “I think you’re prone to worry, old friend.”

“I am,” he said. “I don’t want things to change. I like the way things are . . .”

“Well, Kimmy thinks they were pretty good and now even better. And, if it matters, from an outside set of eyes, you two look like you’re really in love . . .”

“That’s for sure,” he said. “Maybe you’re right. I have never been more excited about loving her than right now . . .”



“You know how valuable she is.”

“I really do.”

She stroked his arm again. “I think she really knows how valuable you are, too. She tells me.”

“She really does?” He couldn’t help smiling.

“Look at that smile on your face, Josh. Yeah, after everything that happened . . .”

“At Tiffany’s?”

“She regrets it, you know, it was awful. I think she needed a reminder . . .”

“About me?” A cavalcade of concepts were coming at him so fast, like Karina’d taken a deck of cards, bowed them outright until they flashed out of her hands and into his face. What was she saying? And why did he always look for the bad whenever somebody told him something? He said, “You’re right, I need to open my arms to the good for once.”

“That’s very Dr. Phil of you.”

“Is it?”

She laughed. “I don’t know, I don’t watch Dr. Phil. It sounds Dr. Phil.”

“It doesn’t sound like something I’d say,” he said, and now they both laughed. “Very inspirational. I see it written in fancy script on a sunset sky, like on—”

Karina finished it: “Like one of Tiffany’s Facebook posts.”

They both snickered, and she leaned against him. It was funny to think how much she’d meant to him at one point in his life. And how all of that could crumble away with the passing of time.

Then Kimmy was there, trotting quick in her high heels, coming from the alley up the steps, stopping short when she saw them—abruptly, like she was startled. And then she smiled, saying, “What’s so funny?”

“It’s a long story,” he said, putting his hand out to help her up, “but the punchline is: Tiffany’s Facebook posts.”

Kimmy said, “What about them?”

He waved it off like it was too much to explain. “Inspirational quotes and all that . . .”

Kimmy got it, and she laughed too, her eyes flicking from Karina to him then back to Karina.

Karina said to Kimmy, “Devlin fucking Stone,” but the smile stayed on her face.

Kimmy raised her eyebrows, rubbed the back of her neck, looking sheepish. “Devlin fucking Stone,” she repeated in the same low tone.

“Who would’ve thought,” Karina said.

He said, “Never in a million years.”

Karina chuckled with them, then rolled away and left them alone, returning to her spot at the table.

He looked to Kimmy, put his hands out waist-high and she slunk against him, his hands going around to the small of her back. “What an ordeal,” he said.

“You did so amazing,” she said.

“You think so?”

“I really think so,” she said, and now she smoothed her hand on his chest, turned her face to his, eyes narrow and sultry looking, dark pupils quivering over his. “You were a little rude, but I understand.”

“Rude? Me?” He smiled ruefully.

“It wasn’t too bad. Are you good?”

“Uh-huh.” He nodded, swaying with her. Fucking getting hard for some reason. Right with a whole table full of their friends a few feet behind him.

She said, “We get a free trip out of it.”

“The Caribbean, huh?”

“You up for it?” she asked, melting further against him, her hands going to his waist now, rubbing up his sides from hipbone to ribs, the flat between her own hipbones rested against the belly of his hardness. She felt it—her eyebrows rose and she snickered.

“I’m a little excited.”

“I didn’t know you liked the Caribbean so much.”

Now they both snickered.

“Kiss me,” she said, and as he did, her hand slipped between them and his dirty wife pinched the head of his cock between thumb and two fingers.

He held her, let their kiss part, looking in her eyes as she now traced the edges of his bulge. He wondered what she thought. Wondered what went on behind those narrow and sometimes dark eyes. Had he put it in her head that Devlin had a large bulge in his pants? Was that something she thought of now? Was she thinking of it now?—comparing his bulge in his suit pants to the one in Devlin’s? Now she knew it turned her husband on, would she allow herself to think such dirty things?

Now she said, “Can you get off work on Friday?”

“I’m sure I can,” he said.

“I hope so,” she said, knuckles stroking his cock’s belly.

The simultaneous pleasure of her hand touching his arousal, the mystery of her words—that dark wonder of his considering if he couldn't go Devlin would take his place—plus the proximity of the public witnessing his wife's strange lubriciousness all together had his knees wobbling. Since working for Devlin, Kimmy had never been more sexual. God, more kinky . . .



---

## Gems

Half an hour later, the sun had gone down below the height of the circle of Tudor buildings around the Dragon's patio, casting the space in shade. The patio lanterns were turned on, and fairy lights twinkled where they were strung through the patio's railing. Only one more table had occupants, not many in old Ajax wanting to party it up on a Tuesday night.

The cake arrived for Josh. Vanilla cake sandwiched over orange cream, the whole thing covered in dark chocolate. Not from the restaurant, but from the bakery here in Ajax. Karina had picked it up, dropped it off to the Dragon's kitchen to be kept in their fridge. The Dragon was more than happy considering how much she paid up front. This flavor combo was Josh's favorite, and the bakery here in Ajax, Josh said, made it almost as good as Pop's girlfriend-he-wouldn't-admit-was-a-girlfriend, Susan.

Josh's eyebrows rose with elation seeing the cake coming with its tiny sparklers, but his eyelids barely moved. He was bleary, and she wondered how many pitchers of beer Steve and Meyer and him had split. It got her giggling, her elbows on the table, her hands together against her cheek, slumping toward Karina as the waitress made her way to the table. Feeling good. Josh's pleasure making her feel very good. And though a deep interior voice would say it's just because you're guilty, there was an undeniable honest truth to her pleasure derived. To thrust upon someone you loved so much a generous helping of showy appreciation felt incredibly wholesome. Her fingers practically tingled with delight. What was less honest, perhaps, was the way she played it up to Karina. Putting on the innocent puppy dog act for her friend. When she returned from her meeting with Devlin, she found Josh and Karina together. She'd intended to keep them apart tonight, but had failed in her mission. Devlin had interfered. It

didn't seem like Karina had given anything away to Josh—if she had, her poor Josh would never be able to hide it. But what if a seed was planted?

“Is that for me?” Josh spoke in an obviously slurred drawl.

Four pitchers? Five? But that would mean he had more than a whole pitcher of beer to himself . . .

She batted at Karina with the back of her hand, beaming, nodding her chin to make sure Karina was watching her husband.

The waitress set the cake down at Josh's end of the table, Meyer standing up and moving away glasses and the pitcher to make room. Another waitress came with plates and a serving knife. Josh cut the cake, and they aided in its serving. She waved off the slice, not wanting a piece for herself, too late for so much sugar, watched everyone else enjoy their cake.

After cake, she convinced Karina to join her in a stiff drink, the two of them having a whiskey together. The same one she'd enjoyed when Devlin had presented his offer. They clinked glasses, and took their time with it, rolling it around and talking about how she would definitely get back to the gym, how they would meet up maybe on Friday nights or Thursday nights for a nighttime yoga class. And she would. She wanted that. But then it was late, and Karina was ready to go home, the first of the group to disperse. That had some of the other Swanson girls checking their watches too, but they stayed put. When Karina went to the tavern's bathroom to clear her bladder before the short drive home, she got a text from Devlin.

Devlin: you still there?

Kimmy: we are

Now her eyes moved up and traveled the faces at the table, everyone happy and oblivious. Jesus, Josh laughing so hard right now he couldn't breathe, and Steve leaning in close pumping the accelerator and giving his joke a little more gas, Josh's face going red like it would burst. And look at this: Quinn had moved down, changed spots with Gabrielle and sat right next to Meyer. The two of them very close, elbows practically touching. Was this something?

Devlin: got another surprise for you

She looked over her shoulder to make sure Karina wasn't returning. She texted Devlin back.

Kimmy: Tell me about it

Devlin: have to show you in person

Kimmy: lunch tomorrow?

Devlin: don't think this can wait to lunch

You didn't have to know Devlin well to know what he was getting at. He had something else for her. The thing between his legs. He might wear a five-thousand dollar suit and drive around in a high end Mercedes, but he



was still a boy who did most of his thinking with his dick. She nibbled on her lower lip, contemplating. She texted in return.

Kimmy: how bad do I want this?

Devlin: I know you want it bad

Kimmy: another trip somewhere?

It took a while for him to come up with a return, but soon he did.

Devlin: you're going to want to take a ride on it

Not bad. And it got her smiling. She nudged her phone away, took another sip of her whiskey, thinking now she would order another if she saw the waitress. Things would wrap up soon, probably some of the Swanson girls going home, they had kids and some of them had husbands, but Josh would want to hang a little longer with Steve and Meyer. Especially given the mood he was in right now. She chanced another look over her shoulder, saw no Karina.

Kimmy: you don't take no for an answer

Devlin: you don't either

Now she worked her head around on her neck, thinking to get her mind out of the gutter. You could make fun of Devlin, say that he was always thinking with his dick, and at the same time never notice the same behavior in yourself. Take a ride on it. Did he lease her a vehicle? Was he leading you down a trap, trying to get you to admit you were thinking about sex again, only to have the rug pulled out from under your feet. Trick you into admitting maybe it would happen again, under the right circumstances, only for him to chastise you and say you were full of dirty thoughts, Chang, I only meant I'd got you a company car . . .

Devlin: can you get away from the table

Kimmy: why?

Devlin: come and get your gift

Kimmy: when? Now?

Devlin: timing is everything

Kimmy: where are you?

The tavern door opened behind her, and she flipped over her phone, hugged her own arms, smiling at Karina who returned to the table.

“I’ve never seen such clean washrooms,” she said.

“I know,” she agreed. “It’s a real treat.”

Karina said, “Hey, thank you for inviting me. I missed you . . .”

“I really missed you too,” she said.

Both of them looked at each other with awkward smiles for a moment, then Karina liberated her purse from the back of the chair, slinging the strap over her shoulder. “Okay, I’m going to head. You call me, I’m going to hold you to yoga on Friday.”

“Not this Friday,” she said.

“Oh shoot,” Karina said, her head falling back and rolling to the side. “I forgot.”

“Next Friday,” she said, “I promise.”

“Okay, let me say bye to Josh.”

Karina headed to the far end of the table, coming to hug her seated husband, smiling, patting his back, Josh beaming drunkenly, holding Karina’s wrist. She flipped over her phone.

Devlin: had dinner at this Italian place here in Ajax. Can’t stop thinking about you

Devlin: meet me

Devlin: don't come out to the street side, go out past that garden place, the courtyard in the middle, down through the shopping and out the other side

She stared at the words on her phone's screen. Frowning, thinking. At once being mad, mad that Devlin would hang around, try to ruin the party she was throwing for Josh when she warned him not to. And then, a bolder part of her feeling aroused by his interest. He didn't even go home. He stopped to give you a trip to Cayman. Could've done that tomorrow. Had to come by and see you. And now, he couldn't get away from you. Stayed nearby, went to eat, and you were on his mind. The thing they'd done last night—what if it was as good for him as it was for her? He seemed to have it worse than she did.

Karina was returning now, Josh saying bye, waving to Karina's back. Kimmy tucked her phone into the pocket of her suit coat. To Karina, she said, "Let me walk you out to your car . . ."

---

Karina drove off in her Civic, indicator flashing, pulling out onto the almost empty street. About the only cars remaining were from the Swanson crew, and her Leaf was parked way far down where Josh wouldn't spot it when he'd arrived with Steve after work. She stayed waving until Karina's Civic turned left onto Main Street, then she stood breathing cool nighttime summer air, traces of greasy tavern food and late-summer flowers hanging in baskets from the street-lamps. Her hands were in her pockets, her right hand on her phone. She ran her thumb on its rounded edges, brought it out to check the screen. No new messages from Devlin. Only the last one. He was here. What an asshole to put her in this predicament. Talk about sexual harassment at work. She was obliged to go see him, practically. This was the reason they forbade office relationships. But didn't she want to go see him? Yes, even though it was Josh's party.

*Just slip away from your party, Devlin wanted, go around the circular garden, go out the back between the shops . . .*

But she couldn't walk past the patio again. She should just return to the table. It was almost time to get going home anyway . . .

Hands still in her pockets, now she strolled the sidewalk, high heels clicking, walking away from the archway, down past the other Tudor storefronts, to a wide parking lot, also empty, it's asphalt space lit up in pale sodium halide. She turned left, walking the sidewalk edges of the parking lot, past closed lawyers offices, and accountants . . . Around the perimeter, now slowing her step, trying to keep her heels quiet. She'd circled the conglomeration of Tudor buildings, all part of the same development. Deep around the back, she saw in the parking lot a lone vehicle: a Mercedes roadster. Even in an empty parking lot, pulled in on an angle across two parking spots.

From beyond old Ajax, beyond a line of homes and woodland, she could hear the sounds of hissing traffic, but it was quiet here in the old village, enough that the loudest volume came from chirping crickets. Past a garden and hedgerows marking off the front space of the accountant's office there was a stretch of grass, and she stepped onto that now, walking mostly on her toes so her heels wouldn't dig into the soft earth. The grass quieted her footsteps. She continued around the edges of the building, finally seeing the spot where there was a matching archway like the one street-side. This was the alley that would lead from the Dragon's patio and the circular garden out to this parking lot. There, in the shadows, a man in a suit leaned casually against a wall with his back to her. Waiting for her. The act of spying on him made her want to laugh, and trying to stop the laugh had her almost snorting. She covered her mouth, watched him. He was doing something. His elbow was moving, and she could tell now his hand was between his legs.

Her upper canine rolled over the plumpness of her lower lip, eyes narrowing and watching Devlin. Devlin Stone waiting for her. Grabbing his dick in anticipation. Why was that so appealing? Probably because he was the hottest guy in high school. Biggest asshole, yeah, but the guy all the girls wanted. And now, ten years later, that same guy wanted Kimmy Chang. And, truthfully, he was a magnitude hotter than he was in high school.

She continued along the grass, expecting to be discovered, but soon closing the distance until they were only two dozen feet apart. His elbow still dabbed up and down, her boss stroking his big dick while he was waiting for her. Wanting to get it hard, wanting his gift to her to be at its most impressive when he presented it. So piggish. And yet, here she was, continuing to close the distance between them.

When the grass ended there was still about ten feet of sidewalk space to cover, and she went on her toes, only taking a few steps knowing she couldn't make it to him without being heard, so saying aloud, "That gift for me or for you?"

She saw his posture slump, his hands dropped to his side, and he rolled around, languid, shoulders resting against the brick wall at the edge of the archway where he been spying around the corner anticipating her arrival. A lone yellow-light lantern hung a few feet above his head casting the light downward, making his cheeks look chiseled and his handsome brow casting black over his eyes. He tilted up his head and smiled, his eyes narrow lines. He chuckled in his throat, groaned, "The player gets played."

"That gift's going to be worn-out and second-hand by the time you give it to me." She strolled, letting him hear her heels now, attempting a quite-good sexy walk, the higher heels she wore these days becoming more familiar to her, weaving her steps in an undulating line. His eyes dashed up and down her body appreciatively. He moved his hand between his legs, cupped his grip over his cock hanging down his thigh.

She came close. "Do you ever wear underwear?"

"Does it bother you I don't?"

"I don't think about it," she said without smiling.

"You told Josh you think about it. Or was that just because your dirty husband asked you?"

She chuckled. "I think about it."

“I know you do.”

“Oh, you do? You’re so fucking confident.”

He said, “I love when a woman like you gets caught checking for it.”

“Checking for your bulge?”

He smiled devilishly. “I’ve seen you check.”

“Maybe I do.”

He breathed deep, a low groan in his breath. He still lounged against the wall, palming his cock. “Tell Josh you do.”

“Maybe I will,” she said, stomach tightening at the thought, knowing she could tell him the truth and he’d be aroused by it.

“If we’re talking maybes, maybe I’ll show up in Cayman, we can have some drinks, all three of us, have a good time, then later Josh can watch me take my time sinking it inside you . . .” He let go his cock, the hand now pulling back the flap of his suit jacket. The light fell from above onto his bulge, the long humped shape casting a shadow on his thigh. His cock was enormous, stretching his suit material halfway down one pant leg. The sight of it weakened her knees suddenly and warmed her belly.

“You can’t be here,” she said.

“I am here.”

“Show it to me and I’ll go. Everyone’s still at the table.”

“Fuck, Chang, what did you do to me? Why am I here?”

“I’m asking myself the same question.”

“I want to fuck so bad right now. Get Josh drunk and I’ll come back to your apartment, we can fuck on the bed while he’s out cold.”

The thought chilled her, and she made an exhilarated exhalation that gave herself away.

He liked it, smiling, biting his lower lip, eyes darting around to make sure they were alone and no one was watching. “Come closer,” he said.

Now she was looking around too, back to his lonely angled roadster, the tree-line beyond the parking lot, back from where she’d come, off to her right . . . As she stepped closer, she leaned aside to peek down the arched alleyway, saw the garden and the Dragon’s fairy lights and patio lanterns.

“You have to go,” she said quietly.

His eyes locked on hers as he drew down his zipper, his smile tugging to one side.

“What are you doing?”

“You know you want it.”

“Even if I do, we can’t do it here . . .”

“You said show it to you.”

“I know,” she complained, voice thin and whiny as she closed the gap so they almost touched.

“Take it out, Kimmy.”

She glanced around again, and if anyone watched, they were so close together it would be hard to decipher what they did. Her hand went inside the gap of his fly, and her fingers clawed over the hot and hard column of his arousal. “God,” she sighed, “you are so big . . .”

“Let’s go to your place.”

“What about Josh?”



“Send him to one of his buddies and they can stay up all night playing Magic Cards.”

Her hand fondled him, felt the veins pressed out on his shaft, felt how urgent his arousal was. “He’s getting drunk . . .”

“Yeah?—I can fuck you doggy over him while he sleeps . . .”

Now she wetted between her legs. Could feel a sticky flux in her panties. She moaned and chuckled at the awfulness. “You are so evil,” she said, tugging his cock, trying to withdraw it from his fly. It wouldn’t emerge and Devlin had to help, dipping his knees and tugging his fly to one side, his finger fish-hooked under the fabric. When his cock was yanked free it slung a long silvery strand of his lubrication. She thumb-swiped it, ran a circle over his urethra, marveling at the size of his fully engorged cock head. The urge to feel it slide inside her got her mind fading, her consciousness dragging down to the shadow realm of terrible desire. She moved his cock upright, going around like the hand of a clock, his long penis coming up to her sternum. She leaned against him, pressed it between their bodies and watched a gem of pre-come swell in the cup of his urethra. “Fuck,” she groaned. How deep it would go . . .

“Or I can fuck you right here while your husband’s around the corner . . .”

“I can’t, Devlin, even if I wanted to, I—”

“You know you want to,” he said, his large hands on the narrow of her waist and holding her against him, their faces so close.

“I want to, but . . .” It would hurt . . .

Now he wheeled her around so it was her back against the wall. He loomed over her, his cock on her stomach, probably oozing out his natural lubrication all over the fine fabric, and he took her lips with his own. She let him, melted under him, slinking against the brick wall and giving him her tongue. Soon both her hands circled his huge cock and began to pleasure it, squeezing stroking . . . his hands roamed her body, his right hand going low, tugging up on her skirt.

“Oh, not here . . .” she gasped, kiss smacking away wetly and her looking around. She let his cock go and it tapped against her.

Eyes on hers, his hand went up her skirt, fingers stroking her thigh, curling up and over the waist of her panties now and guiding them downward . . .



---

## Messes

Skirt pulled to her waist, panties circling her thighs, she rolled a look around the edge of the archway to peer into the alley toward the Dragon's patio. She and Devlin were still alone.

Devlin palmed her bare ass cheeks, his thumb stroked the wet folds of her pussy while her mind frantically searched for a way out of this despite how much she wanted it. Wished, in a way, to have seen movement, someone coming, some definitive reason they must stop . . . A reason Devlin must put his cock back in his pants, must pull up her panties and let her skirt drop. But there wasn't . . .

Devlin stooped, ran his tongue from her clit to her asshole and she almost fell to the concrete with the sudden electric thrill. She hissed, gasped, rolled back so her shoulders pressed the brick, looking down at Devlin, his sneering face at her naked crotch.

Then he was rising, his movements driven by undisguised lust. And she responded to him, her eyes locked on his as he rose to full height above her. His huge cock was pushed in her hand, he kissed her, and she began to stroke him up and down using both hands, squeezing him tight and feeling the turgid resilience.

As terrible an idea as this was, her lust was ignited by his. Like a key put in her ignition, the two of them turning over now, a spark rolling over the heavy lecherous engine. While she kissed him, her breaths came heavier and heavier, and soon she was gasping around his kisses, her mind focused on the large masculine implement in her hands, exploring it, pleasuring, stroking but also caressing, treating it with respect. It delivered such joy to

her last night, it was an object to be revered. She jerked him fast, slow, wondering how this would end. Would he come on her shirt? On her neck, or maybe she would get down on her knees and he would do it on her face. No man had ever done that, but a few years ago on a strangely erotic night when she was alone and Josh was away, she had watched porn on her laptop and seen a girl submit to that terrible act. It had haunted her. But not in the way she believed. Because now here she was with a different kind of man. The idea of Josh doing that to her just didn't seem right. But getting on her knees while a man like Devlin did it sparked desire.

Soon she was gasping, letting his cock go, putting her hands on his chest. Meant to push him away, but now ended up touching him. Getting her hands inside his suit jacket so she could feel better the muscle of his chest through the thin cotton of his dress shirt. His body was hard, curved slabs, broad chest but slender middle. She could still feel the weight of his erection resting on her stomach.

Devlin let their kiss go, grabbed her roughly by the back of her neck and stared in her eyes. She held her breath now, watched his black pupils on hers. He gripped his cock, aimed it between her legs and ran it through the slickness of her creases. Her toes curled in her high heel shoes, and her stomach went light as a feather. To feel his masculine steel against her soft wet flower did something crazy to the top of her brain. It was like a patch of grass with sunlight falling across it now.

"We can't," she whispered.

"You want it," he said.

She shook her head no. He smiled.

"You want it so fucking bad. I can read your mind, you liar."

It got her chuckling, her knees softening, back arching, tilting her face up to his. She squeezed his cock between her thighs, reached up to kiss him again. Put both hands on his neck now, his strong neck, touched his ears, held them in the V between thumb and forefinger and pushed her tongue

into his mouth while her mind focused on what his hardness felt like against her softness. She whispered, "I can't two days in a row . . ."

"You're not used to it."

"You're too big."

"You love it." He jabbed the head upright, mashing her labia but not entering her.

She gasped. "I love it," she admitted.

Now his hand slipped between them. He gripped his cock and with his fist applied pressure with the end of it, mashing it hard against her pussy. She fell back against the wall, looked down her own body, her panties around her thighs, his masculine hand holding that mighty weapon where it disappeared between her legs. His shaft glimmered with her own wet. He stroked her with his cock. She enjoyed it. Loved the pleasure it delivered. Her hands went to the wall, her nails scratching on the brick. He pleased her with his cock, teasing her like he'd put it inside her, but only stroking back and forth. Then his hand slipped between her thighs, his cock moving away, running a slippery wet line from her pussy up to her hip. She gripped it and held it, squeezing as he pushed two fingers gently inside her.

"Careful," she reminded him.

"When will you be ready?"

"I don't know."

"Saturday."

"I'm in Cayman on Saturday," she laughed.

Two fingers in her pussy, now he gripped the back of her neck again. Held her like he owned her, turned her face up to his. "Beg me to come to Cayman."

"You can't," she said. "Josh is coming."

“Tell me you want me there.”

“I do want you . . .”

“Who would you rather go with?”

She bit her lower lip, refused to give him the answer he wanted. “Josh,” she said.

“You bitch,” he said smiling, sliding his fingers slightly deeper, the smile widening with each centimeter he penetrated her. Her mouth slowly fell open as she felt her depths being spread. “You’re lying to me.”

“I want to go with Josh.”

“I love it when you lie to me,” he said, cocking his head, studying her expression of ecstasy as he fingered her. Stroking in and out, pulsing against her, mushing the pads of his fingers against her clitoris. Her heels pressed down, and her back flattened against the wall.

“You want me,” he said, sneering, staring.

“I want you.”

“Josh only owns half your pussy.”

“Half of it?”

“The rest of it’s mine. I own the parts he can’t reach . . .”

Her lashes fluttered and her knees unlocked. She fell against the weight of his hand and he held her upright, two fingers probing very deep inside her. She gripped his forearm in both hands now. Felt the hard thick muscle under the expensive suit fabric. Craned her neck up wanting his mouth. He gave it, and she slid her tongue past his lips. He held the back of her neck still, fully supporting her, pressed against the wall, her weight cupped in his hand, two fingers deep inside, her tongue in his mouth. A demon in her life, but a demon who delivered all the world’s best sins.

This time when their kiss came apart, she said, "Come to Cayman with me."

"That's what you want?"

"Meet me in Cayman," she said.

"I'll fuck you there."

"I need you to fuck me so bad."

"You want to come right now?"

She nodded, let her legs apart, locked eyes on his while his fingers explored new pleasure, plunging, his thumb pressing on her clit. She searched for his cock, found it again, her right hand going around its tremendous girth. She squeezed, felt his pre-come dribble over her knuckles, wiped her knuckles on the underside of his cock, and used the slipperiness to stroke him. "We can come together . . ."

---

After a few minutes of touching, stroking, fingering, and pleasuring while they kissed, both of them got close to orgasm. But Devlin growled, pulled his hips back till his cock was out of her grasp. She moaned complaint, frowning. "I was so close . . ."

"Let me put it in you."

"No way," she said.

He fell against her, kissed her neck and her mouth, and she caressed his cheeks. He growled, his elbows braced against the wall on either side of her shoulders. "I'm going to come to Cayman, I'm going to sneak into your suite, fuck you while Josh sleeps off a couple beers and a sunburn."

She chuckled, circled her hands around his back, both palms running circles. "You're so bad."

"You're worse."



She gnawed on her lower lip, drew a deep inhale. Was she?

Now he bit at her neck, and she whispered near his ear: “Don’t leave any marks,” thumbing at his ears, his hand coming between her legs again, two fingers slipping up inside her.

“You’re so fucking wet, Chang, you really can’t take it now?”

“It’ll hurt . . .”

She gasped then, as his pleasure returned at full force, fingers fucking deep and quick. She searched for his cock, but couldn’t find it. He had it, jerking it hard and fast with his other hand.

Now she surrendered to the pleasure. No longer mutual, this was all for her. She pressed her palms against the cool of the brick, bowed her knees out, up on the toes of her high-heeled shoes while he fingered her. He’d done it to her so many times, even the first time knowing what she liked. And now he was only better at it. Feeding off of her reactions, knowing how to make her utter the sounds he liked to hear. Soon she was whispering, “I’m coming . . . I’m coming . . . I’m coming . . .”

Devlin made an appreciative growl, moved back from her body, stroking his big dick, his other hand jostling two fingers embedded in her pussy. Not deep, only where she was used to feeling a penis. It was deeper that she wasn’t ready for. Devlin’s space . . .

At that thought, her trigger was pulled. “I’m mm-coming, ah god, I-I’m coming,” she moaned and gasped, one hand coming up, touching his face, her fingers dragging down, catching on his lower lip, tugging it, making it plop wetly back in place as her hands fell to her stomach, hoisting her skirt up high. She looked between her legs, her panties in a figure-eight just above mid-thigh, her pubic hair glistening and matted, Devlin’s hand shining with her wet. In his other hand he stroked fast on that massive dick. Her eyes narrowed focus on the awful sight, Josh just around the corner—if the crickets weren’t so noisy she could probably hear the laughter coming from their table.

She came. Not a bright sprinkler today, but, oh, it was glorious. She gasped, hitched breath, squirmed against the wall, chin turned up, squinting eyes against the orangey light from the lantern above, seeing the starlight field high in the sky.

“Oh god, oh my, ah,” she gasped, his finger slowly stroking, caressing the last of the pleasure from her. Her thighs shook, her ass muscles quivered like jelly. Devlin still stroked. She watched.

Heart still pounding, she whispered, “You going to come?”

“Mm, fuck,” he grunted, “yeah, squeeze my balls . . .”

“Yeah,” she whispered, snaking a hand between his legs, stuffing it into his fly. She found his scrotum, not tight but hanging, saying, “God, even your balls are huge. I can barely hold onto them . . .”

“Squeeze them . . .”

She complied. Watching his face as he masturbated, his big balls in her hand, gauging from his expression when she squeezed them too hard.

“Harder?”

“Fuck, Kimmy, mm, a little harder . . .”

“Like that? . . .”

Devlin groaned, slapping a hand on the brick wall to support his weight just by her head. He stroked faster, she looked between her legs and his monstrous weapon in his big grip.

“You going to come?”

“Ah, mm, fuck,” he said, “okay,” now reaching with his other hand still with his body weight lurched toward hers, curling an index finger into her panties, pulling them out and upward.

“Oh my god,” she whispered, knowing what he would do.

She let go of his balls, thumbed the waistband of her panties, pulling them upward and holding them in place, watching him squeeze and circle his grip around the neck of his long caulk, his fat cock head choked bright and shining purple. He ejaculated. A short bubbling geyser first that flicked off his knuckle and plopped on her thigh. But then he was squirting, the warm wet tapping into her pubic hair, up her belly. Devlin growled and roared, aimed his cock into the crotch of her pulled-down panties. She watched the pearly semen rope across her flesh, her pubic hair, draining into the panties, pooling in the black satiny crotch. “Oh god,” she sighed, “oh my god,” feeling another tidal roar of orgasm racing toward her shore. “Oh fuck . . .”

“Shit, Kimmy,” he growled, letting his cock go, slapping both hands on either side of her shoulders, head hanging, heaving for breath. His drooling dick hung between her thighs, and she snatched it. Jammed it between her legs, held in one hand, her other prying outward her panties still, she probed his warm plump army helmet against her wetted folds. At the feel of it, her knees went woozy. She sagged; Devlin stared at her, she met his eyes. Their vision stayed locked, laser beams scrambling each other’s organic computers, breaking down defenses, her eyes narrowed, vision dimmed, and with his cock in her hand, she mashed her clit until she shrieked a loud chirping girl sound. Devlin clapped a big hand across her lips, eyes wide, mouth stretching to amusement. She burbled, gagged, and cried into his nice-smelling palm, felt a tinkling down the insides of her thighs. Her knees gave way finally, and she collapsed, butt and back scooting down the wall, ankles folding over, feet coming out of her shoes.

Devlin was quick to support her, getting hands under her arms, holding her up and chuckling. He hoisted her upright, her spaghetti legs dangling from her hips. He set her down out of her shoes, staring into her still, those black demon eyes somewhere between baleful and joy. Loving this bad creature he’d converted to the dark side.

He chuckled in his throat, slowly eased his hands out from under her armpits making sure she wouldn’t fall again. She was in bare feet, cold on the concrete. His smile grew wider, but his eyes moved across her appreciatively. He stepped back, his cock falling out of her clumsy hand and dangling between his legs, a huge flesh club pale against the dark navy

suit. He licked his upper lip as he stepped back, took his penis, tugged outward his fly and, with effort, shoved it back undercover. He zipped, came close to her while she stood there dumbfounded, breathing heavy, wet sliding down the insides of her thighs. He pulled the front of her panties, she looked down. A white semen mess spoiled the inside of the fabric. He circled his fingers through the waistband, straightening out the panties, then gently tugging them back up her thighs. She helped him by swaying her hips, and when he pulled them into place she felt the cool messy wet of his load against her hot velvety pussy. She moaned and closed her eyes. Devlin groaned, too. Then his lips were on hers, and she kissed him. He pulled back, still with that appreciative stare.

He stepped backward, three steps, smiling, putting his hands in his pockets. Then he wheeled, strolled under the lamplight, heading to his car, long Devlin shadows flicking across the asphalt like dials gone haywire.

---

It wouldn't have been a good idea to return to the table via the archway at the opposite end of the courtyard. She walked part way from where she and Devlin had engaged all the way back to the accountant's office in bare feet. Passing through the cool summer grass and feeling its dewey wet between her toes. Then did her best standing on the sidewalk out front of the accountant's office hand braced on its entryway gate-post to balance herself while she dried her feet the best she could with her clean hands before slipping her heels back on. The chill from Devlin's semen had gone, his gloppy mess in the crotch of her panties quickly assuming her body heat. It slipped through her creases, made her feel greasy. It was gross, something one would think was off-putting—like if you'd asked her before the summer—and yet it was representative of something dark and erotic, and whatever it was about that obverse of her good, it made her heart race. There was a small amount of shame, but it was now quashed under the enormous weight of this heavy feeling of creeping lasciviousness.

In her heels, she returned to the almost empty main street, walking with hands in suit pockets, turning right to head under the archway that led to the Dragon's patio. That was where she resumed a more upright posture, tried to push to the back of her head the knowledge that her boss's—Devlin

fucking Stone's—semen squished and squelched between her legs. Even the insides of her thighs were lubricated.

Now trotting up the steps, she was relieved to find everyone still at the table: Gabrielle, Samara, Leah, even Quinn. At the end of the table, Steve and Meyer, and at the throne at its head, her husband. And even with the freshness of her enormity slick between her legs, she beamed seeing Josh so happy with her arrival. He gave a friendly wave, still listening to Steve who was mid-story. Quinn had cozied up next to Meyer, their shoulders touching. That was going really well.

She took a moment to let it all register, everyone oblivious. She'd got away with it. All the kudos and respect and appreciation for an act so kind for her husband, then for herself, a quick lubricious tryst with her hot and hugely hung boss just for herself.

Josh waved her over, and she nodded. As she came around the table, he asked if Karina got away okay.

"Yes," she said, "we were just talking—"

"Hey," he interrupted, "grab that chair," pointing to the empty spot between Steve and Gabrielle. Then he scooted his chair aside, making room at the head for the two of them. "Come and join me," he said.

Holding the chair's back, she dragged the heavy thing around Steve, putting it in the spot next to Josh. Steve Josh and Meyer had drained what had to be their fifth pitcher. All their glasses three quarters empty. Josh was stoned. She said it: "Look at the state of you."

Steve laughed, leaning back so he could look up at her better. "He's full of cake and beer. And normally those two things would never go together . . ."

Meyer said, "We made it work."

Then Josh's hand snaked around her waist, and she resisted him, tightening her muscles against his pull. He was persistent. "Come on, come here," he said, pulling her.

She went with him, let him guide her to sit now in his lap with her back to Meyer. Devlin's pearly mess squished between her legs as she sat in Josh's lap. He looked at her lazily, eyes half-lidded and happy, stinking of beer. Smiling. She smiled back, patted him lightly on the cheek. "Did you have a good time?"

"You're the best."

"You deserve it," she said.

"Isn't she the best?" Josh said to Steve, hugging her now. His arms went around her, and he hugged hard, squeezing till she couldn't breathe. It tightened her muscles, her stomach going to steel, and she could feel the slithering mess in the crotch of her panties, could feel its liquid seeping upward between her pressed-together thighs, probably tangling in her pubic hair.

Steve agreed. "Kimmy's indeed the best," he said, hoisting his big plastic patio tumbler in a second-long toast before tipping it back and draining it dry.

Josh worked his face up her collar, kissed her neck, cuddling with her. Near her ear, he whispered, "I'm going to make you squirt so hard tonight."

"Jo-osh," she said, laughing, slapping lightly at his hand and swaying away from him, looking aside to make sure no one had heard what he'd whispered.

He hugged her back in return, clutched her to him. Big grin on his face, he said, "What?"

"Okay," she said slyly, feeling a new spark of desire.

Meyer asked, "What are you two whispering?"

She looked over her shoulder, saw Quinn and him staring at her—making her feel good at what she'd accomplished today, not just for Josh. "None of

your business,” she teased, then seeing the waitress coming out of the tavern, waved her over, saying to Josh, “One more drink before we go.”

She hugged Josh’s head and he kissed her wrist while she ordered herself the best whisky the Dragon offered.





## Alarm

In the foyer of their apartment, she steadied Josh against the wall so he could heel off his shoes. He'd dozed in her car on the ride back home, but he was awake and talking now, saying, "Yeah, you definitely threw me for a loop."

She said, "I know I did. That was the point."

He chuckled, swaying and watching her warmly. "You know how crazy you made me? canceling coming home so you could stay out late again."

She smiled warmly in return. "I'm very mean."

"You ruined my day."

She laughed, kicking off her own shoes, going to him barefoot and smoothing her hands on his chest. "I hope I made it up to you."

He cocked his head, still full of ardor. "You absolutely did."

"Good."

"I can't tell you how bad I felt all day . . ."

"That wasn't what I wanted, baby."

"It was kind of what you wanted."

"Maybe a little," she said, patting his chest. "That's what made it so much fun."

“It was fun.”

“How surprised were you?”

“On a scale of ten? Like, shit my pants surprised,” he said, laughing.

She kissed his chin. “Did you really shit your pants?”

He blurted out laughing, his lips blowing a raspberry as he hugged her and the sound he made got her laughing too, both of them chuckling and swaying with each other, him with his arms around her, her hands tucked over his collar and thumbing his neck.

He said, “I’ve been a real dick lately.”

“You haven’t. You know you haven’t. We just need to remember each other.”

“I definitely remember you,” he said.

“And I remember you,” she said, playing with his lower lip.

“You did that all today? Meyer said you picked up Sophie.”

“I did,” she said.

“Really?” he said, slurring, his eyes narrowing.

“Sophie and I had a grown-up girls breakfast together.”

He groaned and laughed. “What did she have?”

“French toast.”

“Figures.”

“I dropped her off at Hyun’s so Meyer didn’t have to get a sitter.”

“God,” he said, “what a night,” palming his own forehead now, and wincing.

“Headache?”

“A little . . . damn,” he said, “I have to go to work tomorrow.”

“Maybe I should’ve planned it for the weekend.”

“No,” he said, “it was perfect,” and she stepped back now, patting his chest.

“Let’s get you taken care of then,” she said.

He hunched forward, rubbing his cheeks, saying into his hands, “I don’t think I even drank that much. We paced ourselves.”

“Come on, let’s get you on the couch,” she said, taking his hand and guiding him into the family room. She told him to sit, got him slumped on the sofa. While she was in the kitchen, he turned on the TV, fired up Red Dead Redemption. She got him Tylenol, Aleve, a Coca-Cola, and an ice pack from the freezer, returning to the family room to sit on the couch next to him. The game was awake on the menu, but he wasn’t playing, eyes closed, eyebrows high. She put the soft ice-pack wrapped in a tea towel on the top of his head, and he smiled, taking over for her and putting his hand to hold it in place. She put a pill in his mouth, passed him the Coke. He asked what it was, and she said, “Front-loading some ibuprofen and some anti-inflammatory. You’ll thank me in the morning.”

“I’m always thanking you,” he said, gulping the pill back, taking the others she held in the cup of her palm and swigging them down as well before lurching forward to clunk his empty glass on the coffee table. She took the controller from his lap, turned off the Xbox and the TV.

“Mm, I was going to play,” he mumbled.

“You’re going to thank me,” she said, “for getting you to bed.”

“I know,” he said, “that’s what I was saying, always thanking you.”

She eyed him, her sleepy Josh, eyes in slits, face happy. She said, “Now you have to put your money where your mouth is.”

He open one eye wider and regarded her.

“I think you said you were going to do something tonight . . .”

“Mm, yeah?” he said, lips stuck together.

“You got me horny, Josh,” she said, stroking his forearm, circling his wrist with both hands, standing and helping him out of the couch.

“Okay,” he murmured, hand on her back, her still leading him by the hand, going down the hall to their bedroom. And it was true, being with Devlin tonight had fired her up. It was dirty and awful and illicit. But still incomplete. Even though Devlin’d made her come, or she’d done it, using his big cock as a device, she wanted sex. Probably could not have done it with Devlin, but Josh’s size would do the trick.

---

She guided him to sit on their bed, Josh saying, “Who does he think he is, anyway?”

“Who?” she asked, knowing exactly who he meant.

“Devlin.”

She kissed his forehead, said playfully, “Who is he?”

Josh sighed, shrugged himself out of his suit jacket. She took it from him, lay it over the arm of the chair across from the bed.

He said, “I don’t need any help from him or any of his asshole business friends to get ahead at Swanson, I hope he doesn’t start poking around my fucking business . . .”

“He won’t, Josh,” she said, “he’ll have forgotten the whole thing by tomorrow.”

Josh, surly: “What whole thing?”

“You guys being testy with each other.”

Josh groaned and his shoulders sagged. He began trying to work out the knot in his tie, then quit, letting his hands drop, saying, “That guy really loves giving out his card, huh? Slipping it in drawers, making sure tonight I got one just for me. So proud it says Stone Brokerage and his name in big letters: S-T-O-N-E. Like he built the business. So proud of something he didn’t build. Such a faker. What does he even do there?”

Kimmy chuckled, began working his tie knot for him.

Josh let her untie it, then pushed her hands away so he could finish. “Fucking guy,” he complained, “it’s companies like his with their fucking tax avoidance that are the problem, you know? Like he won’t pay you more because he’s trying to save it from going to the government?—this is how he thinks . . .?”

She smirked, shaking her head. “Josh, it’s just . . . not a bonus if it puts me over a threshold and the bonus goes to the government. It’s not really tax avoidance.”

“Right,” he grumbled, trying to snake his tie out from his collar, “pragmatism and all . . . but you know what I’m saying, right? Maybe not here with you it’s tax avoidance, but I can guarantee that’s the way he thinks—afraid to pay his fair share in case someone needy and therefore not as good as him might need it . . .”

“Would you just get undressed, please,” she laughed, pushing his shirt over his shoulders, getting him topless.

Right near her face, he exhaled this question: “At Stone, does he do anything?”

She laughed, threading his belt away, snapping it through his pant loops. She unbuttoned his pants, and he took over, and she ran down his zipper,

making him gulp when she squeezed his soft bulge. A real disappointment not finding it hard.

“Does he?”

“He works,” she said, pulling his pants down. He fell back, dug his heels into the floor, pushing his hips up, and she grabbed his pants and underwear, pulled them down to his knees and shoved them to his ankles. His penis and testicles lay in a small shriveled clump between his legs, and she winced at the instant thought, Devlin’s voice whispered in her ear: Double-A.

She slunk up Josh’s body like a cat, putting her knee between his naked thighs, trying to turn him on. His eyelashes fluttered, and she said, “Don’t you fall asleep on me, Josh.”

“I’m not,” he said, indignant, “I’m not.”

“You better not, I’m warning you.”

“Never,” he said, circling his arms around her back. “Does he do anything, Kimmy? Seriously. It’s his dad’s company. He’s just a spoiled figurehead.”

She kissed his cheek, ran her fingers from his hairline to the crown of his head, scratching his scalp with her nails. “He works.”

“Probably comes in at lunchtime, flirts, and then dips out for a late afternoon lunch or something, him and his fucking dumb asshole friends . . .”

“When I see him, he’s working. But I don’t see him all the time . . .”

“Fucking asshole,” he mumbled, and she smiled. Watched him with his eyes closed, his breath deepening.

“You’re falling asleep,” she said, and he didn’t answer.

She rolled to his side, lay by him, scratched her nails up and down his naked chest and stomach. Going down and taking his penis between two

fingers and wagging it back and forth. A short flaccid thing that jiggled. Whereas Devlin's penis hung heavy and slapped between his thighs when he walked. She could picture it now in the suite at the Royal York last night. Their fucking over with, her sitting on the chair all freaked out about being out so late with her husband at home, Devlin walking her way, that thing of his so much different from her husband's, bouncing between his legs . . .

She sighed, slunk off the bed, went to the closet and flicked the light on. She removed her suit, poked her head out to make sure Josh was still asleep. Peeled off her panties now, didn't see the mess that she felt. Held it under the closet's overhead light, then seeing the dark staining of Devlin's semen. She bundled the panties into a ball, put on her shorts and sweatshirt, went barefoot to the bathroom, tucked her dirty panties halfway down the hamper. Then she brushed her teeth, avoiding the mirror at first, but then looking in her own eyes and not punishing herself. Spat in the sink, flicked off the light, returned to bed with her hands tucked up inside one of the sweatshirts she wore at Queens when she was just dating Josh. That got her smiling again, thinking of their long time together, thinking how she crushed on him so bad at high school, kissed him, then missed him when she went to Taiwan. Then seeing him again at Queens, just hanging out with a bunch of other people they knew from Kingston. Gradually that crush returned, and she got thinking more and more about the kiss they'd shared. Wondered if Josh ever thought about it, too. And he had. And how glad she was when she found out that he had been thinking about it. Then they dated, and the rest was history. She lay beside him again, both of them with knees bent and hanging over the edge of the bed. She stared at him laying on his back practically unconscious. Mouth lightly agape, breaths slow and steady. She combed his hair with her fingers, traced her fingertip along the nice angle of his nose, curved down and tracing the edges of his lips. He stirred, licked his lips, then returned to Neverland. She used her nails to draw circles on his naked chest, running her hand down to his penis again. Yeah, it was a lot smaller, but it had serviced her well. Nothing wrong at all with it, no matter what the other boys teased him about. It was only small if you put it next to Devlin's. She played with it while her husband slept, running a finger and thumb up and down its sides, wishing it was hard. Smiling again, watching him sleep. But not wanting him to sleep. Kissing his shoulder, running her hands down his forearm, putting her fingers between his. And

taking his sleeping hand, with her other hand pushing open the waistband of her sleeping shorts, tucking his hand underneath there. She watched his face while she manipulated his middle finger to stroke between her creases, touching her labia, knowing how dirty she was. Laying on her side, legs spread, one foot curved over the inside of the other knee with her husband's hand touching where her boss had ejaculated on her. Unclean. Spoiled. Smiling, thinking this was so fucking crazy. Loving him, loving Josh, doing this terrible thing.

She guided his finger inside her a little, imagining the easy penetration was aided by Devlin's ejaculate, biting on her lower lip, wanting Josh to wake feeling her wet heat on his finger.

When he didn't stir, her smile faltered. She shimmied a little closer, studying his face, got near to his ear and whispered, "I've been thinking about how big Devlin's cock is . . ."



Alarm bells rang in his head and his heart jumped in his chest then thundered a drum roll, washing through his eardrums. He blinked and stared up at the bedroom ceiling, every nerve on fire. What he feared most was it was him who'd said it. His eyes darted to Kimmy, curled right up against him. But she wasn't angry, perturbed, or bothered. She watched him smilingly, lovingly. He said, "What?"

Still smiling: "You heard me."

He swallowed, licked his lips, took stock. He was naked, he remembered that. Kimmy was out of her suit, into her pajamas, ponytail gone, hair hanging in a shaggy frame around her beautiful face. His heart still hammered. Her skinny knee pointed to the ceiling, she gripped his wrist and hand. His finger was hot and wet. It was inside her.



“What is . . . what’s . . .?”

“Don’t fall asleep on me,” she said.

“I’m not. What did you say?”

She kissed his nipple, then bit it. He wiggled the finger inside her, felt her pussy grip him in response.

He asked again, “What did you say?”

“Did you hear me say something?”

“I . . . thought I did.”

“What did it sound like?”

He narrowed his eyes and looked at her, becoming more sure that he’d heard it in her voice. “What did you say, Kimmy?”

“Did it sound something like maybe . . .” Now she was smiling, looking up toward the ceiling as if she was trying to recall, her pussy milking on his finger. She turned back to him, met his eyes, but then looked downward to his chest. “I was . . . thinking about Devlin’s . . .”—she paused before whispering: “cock.”

There was an instant swelling between his legs. The drum beat of his heart kicked up again. He stuttered, “D-did you really . . . think . . .”

She broke into a small nervous chuckle, said, “I had to resort to dirty tactics because you keep falling asleep on me.”

“I didn’t fall . . . oh, maybe I did.”

“So I had to bring out the big guns,” she said, her hand slipping down his stomach, soft and warm and so amazing, the V of her fingers going through his pubic hair then scissoring on his penis. “Had to tell you,” she said, “that I was thinking about Devlin’s big cock.” Now she looked toward him, biting on her lower lip, trying to gauge his reaction.

“I’m not falling asleep now,” he said.

She giggled, waggled his penis, kissed his nipple, then cozied up to him, and now, even with his arm bent around awkwardly, the palm of his hand a hundred-and-eight degrees away from its natural, he fingered her as best he could while he watched her play with his penis.

“I think it’s working,” she said, fiddling with it, stroking it and flipping it around. “Devlin’s looked really big . . .” Her eyes flicked toward his.

He couldn’t help groaning and writhing on the bed, arching his back . . . The act of arching his back making his penis tuck into his body and look even less impressive. He instantly flattened, thrust out his hips.

“It’s definitely working,” she laughed, appreciating the growing plumpness.

And it really was working. He had all these reservations flittering up from his forest floor right now, wanting to apologize saying Gosh, I hope this doesn’t make you uncomfortable, I don’t want to make you say things you don’t want to say, is it all right that this turns me on? . . . But it was obvious that Kimmy was unbothered. She was the one who started it. She was the one who’d engaged in this. She knew—because he’d told her—the weird and dark thing that had been turning him on recently. She wasn’t afraid of it. The only problem he could see was that she actually knew Devlin Stone. This wasn’t some fictional person in their life who had a big dick. It was someone they knew. Someone she saw every day. Someone who was her boss . . . Only, as frightening and wrong as it was to engage in this taboo talk about Devlin, part of the excitement was that exact fact. The taboo. The closeness. That’s what was turning him on. The real live danger.

He humped his hips, felt her hand riding on his hipbone, fingered her, could feel she was wet. She was turned on. Turned on because she wanted to have sex—but he also liked to think she was turned on talking about Devlin’s cock. “Tell me more,” he ventured, his voice soft and tentative, the meaning earnest, the words timid.

“I wonder if he’s circumcised.”

His eyes widened, his head pushed back in the bed sheets, looking at the ceiling. It was unexpected and dirty and weird. He chuckled, but then his free hand pushed down on his belly like he had a stomachache—his stomach turning over at the terrible nature of Kimmy’s words. “That’s what you think about?”

“Is that no good?”

“No-no,” he said quickly, turning his face to hers. “Anything is good. Go on . . .”

“Wow, Josh, you’re getting hard so fast.”

“Go on,” he urged her again, pumping his growing dick through the loose grip of her fist.

She bit on her lower lip again, said, “I wonder if it’s circumcised. Like, I wonder what it looks like . . .”

His stomach tightened awfully at the disgusting words. How on earth would something so lurid ever occur to her? . . . “Are you fucking with me right now?”

She giggled, hid her face. “Of course,” she said into his armpit, then kissed his shoulder.

“Okay, keep going . . .”

“Josh, your dick is throbbing now—this really works.”

“Well, now you know my kryptonite,” he said.

She paused, eyes on his, gauging him, then smiling again. “Okay, Superman,” she said, “how many inches do you think he is?”

“Jesus, Kimmy . . .”

“I don’t know,” she said, wincing, “do you think he’s . . . twelve inches?”

“No,” he said, “that’s too big. Nobody’s that big.”

“I thought that was big. No?” Now she wagged his, said, “How big is yours?”

“Never mind,” he said, laughing, full throbbing iron in her grip now. He was happily erect and alert. He tucked his chin to his chest, looked down his body to see his wife’s grip on his normal-sized penis. Then felt a sudden strange shame. They were laying in bed together talking about her boss who by all accounts had a huge dick—Josh was the only one of them who’d really seen it, though not hard. Kimmy’d seen its bulge in his pants when he was hard. But what was Kimmy thinking? . . . Twelve inches? That was impossible. But he wasn’t going to tell her how many inches he was if she thought twelve was how big Devlin was.

She looked down now too, both of them seeing her grip on his super-hard erection. She stroked him lovingly, rolling her grip around on his shaft and circling the head of his cock. “How much bigger than yours is it?”

“Sheezus, Kimmy,” he said, bringing his knees up. Once he’d given her a glimpse of what turned him on, she certainly knew how to press his buttons. It was almost too much for him to bear. She giggled and kissed his chest again, soothing him. “Don’t,” he said.

“Don’t what?” she asked, a little worry in her voice like she’d done something wrong, her stroking stopping.

“Looking at mine and thinking about his.”

“I’m not really,” she said.

Now with her hand stopped, he felt the urgent need of her dirty talk’s return. “You saw it, though.”

She nodded, stroked him a little. “In his pants,” she said.

He swallowed. “What did it look like in his pants?”

“Really?” she said timidly. She stopped stroking, put her hand between his thighs and cupped his balls, gently kneading them. “Honestly . . . it was really big.”

“Oh my God,” he said, “I can’t take this . . .”

“Perfect,” she said, “I can’t take it either—all this talking.” Then she was moving, sitting up, his hand slipping out of her pants. He watched her naked back revealed as she tugged off her sweatshirt and threw it on the floor. The movement of her shoulder blades was so arousing, the muscles in her slender tawny back. He rested his pale palm between her shoulder blades, could see how well her pussy had left his middle finger glistening. Then she was up, pushing down her shorts, totally naked now like him. She was smiling at him, sucking on her lower lip, climbing up over his body on all fours. She sat on his lap as he lay on the bed still, her hands resting on his chest, her hair hanging down around her face. “Now it’s my turn,” she said.

“Your reward for the party.”

“Exactly,” she said, “you owe me.”

“I do, indeed,” he said, both of them light and playful, Kimmy scooting down his hips, lifting one knee off the mattress, weight on a hand, searching for his dick behind her, finding it, lining it right before easing it into place. She winced, spearing his tip inside her, then gently sunk her weight on his lap, going very slow and careful. The slithering feel of sliding into her greasy pocket had his balls pulling up high. The trigger of orgasm was frighteningly close, and he bit his own lip in preparation, trying to stave off what was impending.

“Careful,” she said—to herself—then finally settling in place, her butt on his hipbones. “That’s good,” she sighed, “oh, that’s good.” Then, fully seated on him, every inch he had buried inside her, she turned her chin to the ceiling, showing off all the tendons in her long fine neck.

Her hips rolled and humped, going slow at first, but before the first minute was up, he could feel the simmer in his balls become a boil. “Oh shit,” he

grunted, “oh my God,” wincing and thrashing, pushing his hips up to stop her movements on him.

“What?”

“You’re too hot,” he said, panicking, not wanting to go off so soon.

Serious as stone, she said, “Don’t you come.”

“I’m not,” he said, chuckling.

“Josh, I’m serious. Don’t come.”

“I’m not,” he said, a little more defiant now.

She stopped moving, and he settled his rump on the bed, let her sit on him. They were looking at each other, both friendly still, but there was that seriousness in Kimmy’s eyes she would sometimes get. She said, “Don’t. Okay? I need this.”

“Are you fucking with me?” he asked, meaning her no-nonsense tone.

“You’re supposed to be fucking with me,” she said. “Don’t. Come.”

“Easier said than done.”

Her brows lowered. “Josh . . .”

“I’m not going to . . .”

She slowly circled her hips, and he slapped his hands on her thighs. “Oh wait, oh, don’t, don’t, no, don’t . . .”

“Jo-osh,” she growled, exasperated.

“Just give me a minute,” he said.

“I don’t have a minute,” she said.

“I’m sorry . . .”

“It’s okay,” she exhaled, as if she realized the harshness of her words. But he was letting her down, and he knew it.

“I just need a minute.”

“I need this so bad right now,” she said to herself.

“I’ll just be a minute.”

She lowered her body over his, her head rolling around, her eyes wandering. She said, “Do I need to tie your balls off?”

That tightened his stomach, and he warned her: “Don’t say things like that.”

“Do I need to do it?”

“Seriously, just saying stuff like that you’re going to make me come . . .”

“Don’t come,” she said, being very stern. It was hard to tell if she was playful or if she was really mad about him not being able to fuck her.

“O-kay,” he said, adding: “Ma’am.”

She wasn’t smiling, sitting now, wriggling on him and getting herself upright. He hissed as the movement sent an electric tickle through his cock, and she made an annoyed sound.

“I don’t think we can do the dirty talk,” he said.

“I had to get you hard.”

“Okay,” he said, “it worked, I just . . . Maybe if . . . What if I go down on your first?”

“I like where your dick is right now.”

“Okay,” he said, “move a little,” feeling like this change in mood had fixed his problem. “All right,” he said, gritting his teeth, prepared to do what he had to do, think about things that would stop him from coming. Marvel movies—except Black Widow, but the Hulk or something—think about his grandma, think about Meyer . . .

“Okay,” he told her, “go . . .”





**Stern**

Once she began moving again, she showed Josh a smile. There was something she enjoyed about haranguing him over his sexual performance. Something fun about giving him a standard for which he had to perform while knowing that he wouldn't be able to. But hoping he could. And that provoked another thought she didn't like—but did enjoy. Josh's size inside her . . . she'd been with Devlin last night, and Devlin was twice as long, and so much thicker. Thicker from base to head. The head of Devlin's cock was maybe three times the size of Josh's. When Devlin put it inside her she could feel its shape going deep and deep and deep. Behind her navel. But with Josh inside her now, she could feel the point of his narrow tip probing a fist and a half's length inside. Poking and poking, but feeling good. Feeling very good indeed. So much different than Devlin. So much smaller, but not bad at all. And with Josh there was so much more emotion. So much more history. A friendliness, a comfort. Being home. Being in her apartment that she shared with him. The apartment they picked out together. Where they'd tried to conceive.

She purred for him, rolling her hips, not giving him too much motion because she knew he couldn't take it. Running her nails on his chest, feeling that nice familiar Josh-size giving her a little pleasure.

But with her nails running on his chest, he made that vexed face again, fighting an insistent orgasm, and he drew in a sharp intake of air. It wasn't going to happen. She wasn't going to come—Josh wasn't going to make it to her finish line. What she needed now was a lot more than Josh was up for. If Josh wasn't so close they could roll around a little. But Josh so close like this was unretrievable. He was going to come and he was going to feel bad about it, and she was going to make him feel bad about it. But also

enjoy making him come. She showed him her serious lawyer face again. Scolded him. "I'm going to go get a hair tie."

Frustrated, he grunted, "Why?"

"To tie off your balls."

"That won't work," he lamented like she'd been serious it might be a viable option.

She laughed at him, said, "I'm not serious."

"I know," he said, groaning, rubbing a fist across his forehead. "Okay, you can go again . . ."

"Why? You're just going to come."

"So you're not going to finish?"

"Why? You're like two seconds away from coming."

"I said I'm sorry."

She sighed, said, "Alright how long do you need?"

"Just sit still and don't move."

"Fine," she said exasperated, enjoying putting pressure on him and keeping it on. Loving him, but not letting him know. She tucked her feet under his thighs, squeezed herself to him, got down and hugged him hooking her forearms behind his shoulders. Now she was near his ear. She said, "You excited about going to Cayman?"

"Yeah," he said, sullen.

"Are you, or are you not?"

"Of course I am."

“Just making sure.”

“Of course I want to go,” he sighed, rubbing his hands up her back.

She said, “You don’t have to . . .”

“I told you I want to.”

She smiled where he couldn’t see, face hidden in his collar. “Devlin will go if you can’t or don’t want to.”

“What?”

“Devlin said he’d take me if you don’t want to go—So I don’t have to go alone.”

Voice tight and pained: “Kimmy . . .”

She reared up, got on her elbows, showed her face, showed Josh she was smiling. But Josh’s eyes were wide and excited and scared. His cock throbbed inside her. She waited a beat, let him ponder what she’d said before she cocked her head and added: “Wonder if he’d wear a Speedo?”

Now he got it, and he rolled his eyes. “Don’t,” he said, “you’re teasing me, you’re making it worse.”

She looked up, pondering, “I wonder if he’d fit inside a Speedo.”

“Don’t, Kimmy . . .”

“No, seriously,” she said, like this was something worth speculating—but it was weird for Josh to respond to this. Weird, but it excited her, too, in an unexpected way. “Bet he has to wear shorts. He couldn’t walk around poolside in spandex—”

“Kimmy, do you want to do this or not?” Josh was cross.

“I do. Of course I do.”

“So don’t say those things.”

“What?—it’s interesting. You don’t have to go, Josh, it’s not a big deal. I wouldn’t mind if Devlin took me.”

“You’re killing me,” he said, “stop . . .”

She squeezed him tighter, her hooked feet under his thighs clamping against him, making sure he couldn’t move. “Don’t move around—you’re going to make yourself come,” she said.

“I’m not . . . I’m trying to move around to get away from your dirty talk.”

“Can’t take it?”

Seriously, he said, “I want to have sex, Kimmy.”

“I’m the one that wants to have sex, Josh, you’re the one that’s having problems.”

“Then don’t say things like that.”

She licked her lips, eyeing him. “If I split a room with him, I bet he’d flash it to me, you know like accidentally . . .”

“Kimmy, stop . . .”

“Josh, I can feel you throbbing inside me,” she said, laughing.

“Kimmy, I’m serious . . . I’m going to . . .”

She wiggled her hips a little, kissed his nipple, got over him so her face was above his. She kissed his mouth, looked in his eyes. “I wouldn’t mind taking a look if he wanted to show it to me.”

That was the one that really got him. He began to writhe, trying to pull his hips back, and when he did, she lifted—when he moved up she slapped her butt down on him, took him deep.

“Kimmy, I’m going to come . . .”

“Then come, come inside me.”

Now she ran her nails up his forearms, grabbed his hands and put her fingers between his. She swiveled her hips and humped up and down on him, both of them looking into each other’s eyes. Josh right now (she knew in her heart) was rolling around those dark and scary words, but for whatever reason that worked for him. It was for sure. His cock was like a steel rod, every vein stood out on it, she could feel their lines, could feel the hard point of his cock one-hundred percent erect. It was amazing to know how he worked. Amazing to know how to control him. “Yeah?” she asked, rolling quicker and quicker, “You going to come?”

His eyes went pained and narrow. “I’m going to come . . .”

“Come for me . . .”

“Kimmy, I’m serious, I’m going to come . . .”

“Come, Josh, I want to feel it,” she said, “I want to feel it, give it to me,” humping faster, hair swaying around his face, and when she could feel it happening, could feel his erection beginning to throb and pulse and flex inside her, she sucked in her stomach, hugged his neck, kissed his mouth deeply, both of them panting and snorting through their nostrils. She rode up and down his meager thrusts, could feel the enormous regret in her husband. Could feel the disappointment. Josh’s disappointment larger than hers even. There was a thrill she got from this that was different than orgasming. But very enjoyable.

At last, when the flexing of his cock ceased, both of them panting into their kiss, she finally let him go, smiling and patting his cheek. She raised her hips, let his cock slide out from her, his goopy mess following suit. And there was another bad thought. Josh’s load was deposited so shallow that when he withdrew it slid free. When Devlin had come inside her last night it had been in her deepest pocket. It’d taken all night for it to drain.

She collapsed next to him, breath heaving, satisfied but in a different way. Nipples hard, sweaty and laughing.

“I’m so sorry,” he said quickly in the aftermath.

“Don’t worry,” she said, “don’t worry, Josh. I was joking. It was supposed to be your night, anyway.”

“Aw, come on, don’t say that,” he said, hiding his eyes behind his forearm.

“No, I’m serious. It was your night.”

“No,” he said, “I wanted to have sex.”

“We had sex.”

“I wanted you to come.”

“It’s okay, Josh. It was good. I mean it.”

“I can go again,” he said, “give me a few minutes.”

“Don’t worry, Josh, it’s late, I don’t want you to feel bad. I was doing that on purpose.”

“Being stern? Why would you do that?”

“You didn’t like it?”

He studied her face, and while he did she reached out and patted the point of her index finger on his lower lip, letting him know she loved him without using words.

He said, “Okay, yes, it worked.”

“So, don’t worry about it, then,” she said.

“I can go again, Kimmy.”

“I’m fine,” she said, sitting up, stretching, but definitely feeling unfulfilled. But she wouldn’t let Josh know that now. Not when it was real, only when he was aroused. “I told you I’m fine, baby,” she said, slapping the inside of his bare thigh, looking at his tightened ball sack jiggle. “I’m just going to hop in the shower, I’m a little messy right now.”

Josh hid his face and said no more, and she padded naked into the bathroom, closed the door behind her. But now there was a stomach ache, lower actually, below her stomach. That desire still there. That need provoked earlier this evening watching Devlin jerk off his huge cock into her panties. God, what a sight. What an awful and lurid thing to have done . . .

Shower levered on, she ran the sink, got out her toothbrush, brushed her teeth, could feel the buzzing of its electric motor in her grip. And with a mouth foaming with toothpaste, she lowered the toothbrush, down between her legs, pressing that wonderful vibration against her clitoris . . .



Twice now in the aftermath of Kimmy’s dirty talk, all he felt was a resounding shame. But the dark swirling pleasure of her awful words still whispered in his ears. It was impossible to believe this would arouse him at all. But a magnitude more impossible that Kimmy would help him out by playing along, feeding him dirty talk that hit his weirdest pleasure spot so fucking good she could make him come in less than a minute. And there was that guilt again too. Putting this dirty talk in Kimmy’s head, making her think of Devlin sexually . . . the weirdest thing was the coppery hurt of juxtaposing his innocent wife against the big well-hung sexuality of her boss raced his heart in such a way that he wanted it to hurt more.

In the uncomfortable wake of his sexual failure—his inability to perform for his wife’s pleasure—his mind raced to find a path where he could blame Kimmy. Caught those thoughts and felt guilty for them. Trying to blame her



for her dirty talk, how she'd teased him, how she'd made it impossible for him not to come. It wasn't her fault.

*And, hey, snap out of it—it's not a failure because it's not over. You could lay on the bed and blame yourself for not satisfying your wife, or you could make a difference . . .*

His hand went down his belly, the V of his fingers scissoring his penis like Kimmy had done, wagging it. It was slick with Kimmy's insides and his own ejaculation, shiny and shrinking. He wagged it and flopped it, got it flinging wet.

No, it wasn't over . . .

Now he was off the bed, moving to the bathroom door. Could hear the shower running, knowing then that he would join her in there, pleasure her, make her happy, make it right. Could hear her brushing her teeth. A familiar sound, but different in a way that had him pausing at the door. Her electric toothbrush would make a stroking sound, the little motor buzzing as it bobbed in her hand, in and out of her mouth. Only right now that electric motor wasn't clear and bright, it was muffled and constrained. Hidden, it's vibration absorbed . . .

In an instant, he knew what she was doing. Or at least fantasized what she was doing. How horny was she? His wife's over-the-top arousal had his knees weakening. All this talk about Devlin's cock was making Kimmy go into heat.

That wonderful tightness seized his stomach again. His balls climbed high, hiding in his body, and he cupped a hand over his package. His much smaller package. And he'd put it in Kimmy's head that he liked her thinking about how large Devlin's was.

His heart thudded hard again; he wanted to burst in, catch her in the act, but he couldn't do that. Instead, he rapped lightly on the door three times with a single knuckle. And there: the sound of the motor changed. Not muffled, bright again. She'd been masturbating with it, and, hearing him knock, snatched it out from between her legs, feeling guilty.

She didn't say anything, and he didn't wait to hear. Opened the door. Pushed it open, saw his wife with a guilty expression, her toothbrush buzzing, still held in two hands up by her collar. Totally naked, incredibly beautiful.

He looked at the toothbrush, and Kimmy showed an expression of being caught. He bit on his lower lip, bewildered at the sight of her.

*Catching your wife masturbating! Masturbating while she was thinking of another man . . .?*

He strode to her and she turned to face him. He removed the buzzing toothbrush from her grasp, kissed her mouth, holding her by the neck. In his hand her toothbrush buzzed. It was warm and it was wet. He wouldn't shame her by smelling it. She knew she was caught. But she wasn't in trouble. Not at all.

His kisses went from her mouth, down her neck to her collar. He seized her now by the narrow of her waist, lifting, Kimmy knowing what he would do, going up on her toes and letting him guide her to sit on the vanity countertop. Kissed between her breasts, thumbed her nipples, ran his tongue down the thin folds of her sitting abdomen. Down between her legs, feeling her heat, smelling her musk. His tongue wove through her pubic hair, low to where she was sopping wet, her arousal overflowing, his semen streaming from her. He suckled, grabbed all that curled hot sopping membranous flesh, pulled it into his mouth, tongue sweeping through the folds to find the bulging knot of her clitoris. She closed her thighs gently against his ears, scratched her nails through his hair sighing, "Oh Josh, oh Josh . . ."

He worked and worked, tongue doing amazing things—doing amazing things because his tongue loved being there. The best place his tongue could be. Between his wife's legs. Pushing inside Kimmy Chang's pussy. Breathed her in, squeezed the outside of her thighs, could feel how his pleasure made her legs tremble. But then her scratching fingernails lowered, grabbing to cup his ears, guiding his face upward. He raised his chin, showed her his glistening face. She was troubled. He kissed her in her fuzzy patch, wanting to know what it was she needed. Whatever she needed, he would do it.

She said, “I need . . .”

“What? Anything . . .”

She said, “I need to get fucked.”

The straightforwardness of gentle Kimmy’s dirtiest words sliced through his guts. “Fucked?”

“I don’t want a mouth. I want a cock, I need you inside me . . .”

He was quick to get to his feet between her open knees, kissing her mouth again, hoping she didn’t mind how much her wet had painted him. Her kisses were hungry, and he could feel a rising hardness between his legs now. All because of how horny she was. It was truly bewildering. There was no doubt about it. She might hate Devlin Stone, but the guy turned her on. Ever since she’d gone to work for him, she was a different woman in bed. Bolder, kinkier, needy . . .

She gasped next to his mouth, “Can you get hard?”

“Yeah . . .”

“Can you? . . .”

Her hand circled his shaft, and he wasn’t there yet. More than halfway, but it was happening . . . With his penis in her hand, she whispered, “Devlin would get hard for me . . .”

It was like he’d been punched in the stomach. His belly bounced, his heart jumped and seized. It was too much. Too far. That hurt. She wasn’t talking about Devlin’s big dick and about her curiosity . . . That dirty talk was about sex. That was insinuating she would have sex with Devlin. That was way too much.

Anger bubbled up from inside, a veritable witch’s cauldron bubbling, bubbles bursting. He gritted his teeth, but for fuck’s sake, his cock had snapped into an iron pole in two heartbeats, throbbing and steely in his wife’s hand. And as angry as he was, Kimmy made such an excited sound

feeling his arousal that pride and lust pushed all that anger down again. Kimmy was manipulating him. Getting from him what she needed by any means necessary. There would be another time to tell her the boundaries, but right now this wasn't it.

But, out of the blue, his mouth played along with her terrible game. "In Cayman?"

*No, not in Cayman. Don't say that to her. Why would you even ask that?*

Kimmy was off the topic now, didn't care about dirty talk, just wanting him inside her, gripping his hardness and aiming it between her legs. "Fuck me," she demanded.

He speared into her, pride building again. He wasn't going to bubble over. Not at all. He wasn't going to flop this time. And he didn't. He gripped her by the neck and looked in her eyes, hammered his spear into her, getting her mouth falling open, her eyes going hazy. She gasped and squeaked with his thrusts. He grunted, "Like that?"

"Yes . . . ah, mm, yeah . . ."

"You like it like that?"

"Oh God, ah, oh God . . ."

He gave his wife what she wanted. What she needed. Her pussy was hungry for cock, and he fed it to her. Hard as steel and urgent and throbbing, he fucked his wife good. Fucked her till she was gasping. Pushed away all the torturous thoughts that could get him ejaculating too soon.

*What was she thinking about now—Devlin's cock? Thinking about being in Cayman with him? . . .*

He pushed all that away and was one with his wife. Husband-and-wife, lovers and friends. Kissing her now, feeling her pussy clamping and gripping on him, sopping wet and overflowing, making his balls slick and soggy with her dew. She came. She came from fucking. Not some squirting

fountain like last night, like he'd promised this night, but she did come. Suddenly flexing her thighs and scissoring his hips. Shouting, flapping her arms around him and hugging him tight. Getting him to stop. "Stop, stop," she said, then: "Deep . . ."

He pushed in, gave her everything he had,

"Deeper," she moaned.

He went up on his toes and pumped his hips inside her—and his trigger was pulled.

Frantic, he grunted, "Are you coming?"

He could feel her chin jabbing up and down, her head nodding into his collar. And that was license. He ejaculated inside her again, not thrusting and getting pleasure, instead giving her what she needed: His hardest erection. His biggest erection. Pushed in as far as it would go while she milked his spurting with her undulating muscle.

They both rode out their orgasms, him on his tiptoes till his calves cramped, Kimmy clutched tight to him. Both of them heaving, their skin sticking. The room had filled with the steam from the hot shower, and when at last the tidal swell began to recede, they both chuckled. She smoothed her hand in circles on his back. She whispered, "That was pretty good."

"That was pretty good," he said, reminding himself to be cool enough not to say something dorky like Better than a toothbrush. Leave her alone. Be her man. Be what she needs.

*Because she's offering up what you need, as dirty as your thoughts are, she's willing to accept you, willing to play along and whisper the awful things you want to hear.*

He flexed his fading erection inside her, and she giggled, squeezed him in return giving him a double pump with her pussy muscles.

“God, Kimmy,” he sighed, letting himself slide out at last, putting his heels on the floor.

Her hand dipped down to cover her opening, but he could see the pearly mess he’d deposited leaking onto the vanity. His cock poked out from between his legs, and in the bathroom lights he felt embarrassed thinking about how she’d seen Devlin’s bulge in his pants. He put a hand over his slippery member. Kimmy sighed and heaved breath still, recovering from the orgasm. He got cocky, hand cupped over his manhood, he worked his way between her open knees again, released it to let it rest against her pubic hair and cupped her neck.

“I wouldn’t let you down,” he said, and kissed her.

She moaned, kissed him in return, rested her arms now up on his shoulders. “Come in the shower with me,” she said.



## Signals

In the shower with Kimmy, his hurting heart had him asking her: “You’re not really going to go with him are you?” Of course she wasn’t, but a weak and formerly bullied part of him needed to be reassured.

She had her back to the shower head, the spray fanning out over her shoulders, hair tied up high on her head, standing slim and beautifully naked, her skin shining with the wet. “Never, Josh. never,” she said and cupped his cheeks. “We’re going to have the best time together, I swear. We’re going to eat till our bellies burst, drink till we pass out, get sunburned . . . fuck a lot . . .”

And like that, Kimmy could restore his happiness. One minute she was a dominant lover, a cold and dark eyed femme fatale who could manipulate his lust with dirty words and chastise his performance to bring out the man in him because that was what she needed. Then, when she got what she wanted, his loving wife and longtime friend was restored to him. Each word from her lightened his spirits, removed the heavy weight from his chest. What was that weight—was it fear? It felt like fear, or dread. A worry of what was lurking around the corner.

But Kimmy kissed him, smiling, supportive and loving. Then she said, “Devlin will be there . . .” And it got him jerking, that shadowy dread casting across him again.

“He will?”

She nodded once, mouth firm. “He will.”



She let him squirm a moment before releasing him, saying while laughing:  
“In our dirty talk. . . .”

And a beautiful feeling of warmth washed through him and got him wrapping his arms around her and holding her tight, swaying with her under the water’s spray.

She kissed him, and when their lips came apart she eyed him slyly. He asked her what the look was for.

She said, “So tell me about that display in front of Devlin—all that macho stuff.”

“Macho stuff?—I didn’t . . .”

“Don’t forget Devlin’s my boss.”

The words tightened him. But it was true: he’d stood up to Devlin. It wasn’t the halls of Dalton High anymore. Devlin’s power had dissipated. If Devlin put his hands on him there was the consequence of jail. There were no peers to leverage against him. What would he do—fire Kimmy? So what. That would be Devlin’s loss. And he and Kimmy would be restored to where they were before the summer, which wasn’t a bad place at all. The money would be gone but it was crazy to think Kimmy wasn’t viable on the market. So he’d proven to himself that he could meet Devlin’s gaze and not wither nor kowtow. He chuckled at the good feeling. Kimmy chastising him for being too macho. Who would have thought? He smiled, said, “I know he’s your boss. I’ll be mindful in the future.”

She smiled too, said, “I didn’t hate it.”

“Me acting macho?”

“Very possessive, Josh.”

“Well, you’re mine,” he said, hugging her tighter.

“Are you jealous?”

“Very.”

“I love you,” she sighed.

“I love you, too. You’re mine.”

“Totally,” he said, making a happy grumbling in his throat.

What a day it’d been. What an incredible twenty-four hours, really. The awful torment of yesterday seemed so distant now, and it was hard to believe he was the same man who’d snuck downtown and crept around the Royal York looking for proof his wife was cheating on him. It seemed so long ago. Though, truly, the hurt was just below the surface. Kimmy’d topped up the reservoir of their marriage today, but if you looked straight down, and the light was just right, you could catch a glimpse of the weirdness of the past few weeks. It was his duty as well to add to their tank, to sink the badness to further depths.

But what could he offer? His best. Well, he’d done his best for her tonight, that was for sure. She’d been a veritable dynamo that had made his perseverance impossible, but she’d roused him again and he’d delivered. But what more could he offer beyond just sex? . . . Honesty and openness was a start. Something he’d already come to grips with. So now would be a good time to communicate to her an honest truth—and do it for once without embarrassment. It was clear that Kimmy was accepting of his weirdness, knew it was some holdover from boyhood that got sexualized. Public school and high school bullying and puberty all aggregating to a weird later-life kink. Big deal, right? Kimmy was over it, so he should be as well.

Quietly now, barely audible under the shower’s stream, he said, “I don’t want that all the time.”

She’d turned her back to him, his hands sudsing her shoulders and collar, being careful not to wet her hair tied up on her head. She quarter-faced him, her profile over her shoulder. “What was that? You don’t want what?”

“You know . . .”

She turned to face him again, totally naked, shower water spritzing off her back. She said, "Talking about Devlin?"

"Yeah."

"Not even to say his name?"

He shook his head no. "I know . . . It might turn me on, I can't deny it. It's not the mentioning . . . in here, in the bathroom, when you said you wanted more than . . ."

"Your mouth."

"Yeah. You said Devlin . . . you said Devlin would get hard for you . . ."

"Yeah?" She swooped her slick hands around the knobs of his shoulders, looking in his eyes and giving him confidence to continue.

"That's different. It made me feel weird, because . . ."

"Tell me . . ."

"That's more than play talk, more than you seeing his erection in his pants, that's like . . ."

"Uh-oh," she said, nodding, a sheepish smile tucking to one side, a sign that she understood.

"Yeah, uh-oh," he said, shrugging.

"That's more than seeing the size of his bulge, that's . . ."

"Like you want to . . . do something with him. It."

She snickered. "Sorry, baby. I'm just trying to make it hot."

"It was hot," he admitted.

"It worked though," she said.

“Yeah, it worked, but it hurt.”

“Aw, Josh, I don’t want that.”

“I know you don’t. I know. It’s not your fault. I get it. I appreciate . . . no, I love that you’re okay with exploring this weird thing going on with me and you’re not judging me . . .”

“I’m not going to judge you, Josh, I love you. You tell me the rules and I’ll follow them. But, really, baby, honestly, it worked. When I said that, you went wild.”

“I know, but I’m saying—”

“I heard you, baby,” she said, earnest eyes returning to lock on his, hands smoothing his collar. “I’m not arguing. I’ll say or not say whatever you ask.”

He nodded, hating that she noticed he went crazy at her awful prompt. Devlin would get hard for me. It put in his mind the picture of her in a Caribbean bathroom, reluctantly preparing to allow another man to fuck her, the two of them naked, her wanting Devlin to get hard . . . even now the idea stirred him. But made him so hurt, so angry. He hated the idea roused him. Dream-Devlin had said he asked for it, and now here he was in reality beginning to fold the idea over into their relationship, worrying words could someday become action, and how maybe Dream-Devlin had wanted this all along. And that Dream-Devlin was a facet of his own mind unrelated to the real Devlin. But he was safe in the shower with the woman he loved and so he chuckled instead, feeling more and more complacent with the recent revelations of his sexuality’s potential darkness and how Kimmy wasn’t an adversary or spy for a foreign embassy who had to be kept away from national secrets.

“You okay?” She was chuckling too, happy to see his mood lightened.

“I hate that I ever even brought it up,” he said. “Any of it. Any of that dirty talk. I don’t really want that.”

“We don’t have to, Josh.”

“I hate that I ever brought it up, but now you know . . . and there’s nothing I can do about it.”

“I don’t have to say those things.”

“It’s not just saying them, I feel like I put something weird in your head.”

“It’s not weird at all,” she said sympathetically, cupping his neck and thumbing his cheeks. “I swear to God it’s not weird.”

“I just don’t like the idea of him really being in our bedroom.”

“He’s not in our bedroom, Josh.”

“He already is though. I guess that’s what . . . I guess that’s why it works—because it’s so wrong.”

“I don’t want Devlin in our sex life, Josh.”

“The idea he got on top of you at Tiffany’s, it just makes me so mad—like so mad I want to beat his face in.”

“Don’t be like that,” she said soothingly.

He continued: “So when I think about it I get mad, it’s such a weird feeling I don’t know why it makes me . . .”

“Hard?”

He winced. There it was. That was what she thought. He got hard thinking about her with Devlin. Venomous Devlin injecting his poison into their bedroom. But it did sting so good . . .

Now she said, “We don’t have to, Josh. I only did that because you know . . .”

“I know. It works.”

Now she bit her lower teeth on her upper lip, sawing back and forth a second, deep brown eyes studying him. She said, “I don’t have to do it every time. I’ll keep it in my pocket. For special occasions.”

“I appreciate it.”

She let one hand drop from his neck, down between his legs to grip his balls and cock, giving them a few squishy pumps and saying, “When I need this thing to work is when I’ll do it.”

He groaned, squinting his eyes at her, watching the smile spread on her face. It was a mean smile, but loving. Manipulative. It was true: she knew how to make him work. Knew how to get the response from him she needed. And that was thrilling, surrendering his sexuality to hers. Giving over to her what was incredibly powerful. The keys to his car. The keys to his house. But why wouldn’t he give them over to her? She was his wife and he didn’t love anyone more in this world. His smile began to spread and meet hers, and she wagged his penis before letting it go. She said, “I think you’re getting ready to go again.”

“I’m so embarrassed,” he said, displaying his weakness to her words. All she had to do was provoke him with thoughts of Devlin between her legs, the threat of her dirty talk, and already he could feel his cock beginning to stiffen. She slunk against him, pressed her tummy against his, tilting her hips to squash his penis up against his belly, making it squirm between them.

He said, “I don’t know what I did to deserve you. Really, you’re so amazing. If we can move forward like this, just communicate . . .? I feel really incredible right now.”

“I do, too,” she admitted, melting her wet body against his. He took the suds from her shoulders, brought them down her back, round her tailbone cupping her ass cheeks.

How did he end up with someone so amazing, so incredible? So beautiful, so smart, so capable, her amazing body, how stunning she looked in her new clothes. And even with her naked in his arms and after the honesty

session, and the amazing party she'd thrown for him, he couldn't relax. How did he end up with someone like Kimmy? Was he even really good enough for her? Off every day now, Kimmy using her maiden name, not just hanging with asshole Devlin, but meeting other men too. Powerful men, rich ones. Looking the way she did. Chinese men. What if her DNA took a liking to men from where her family grew up? What if one of them wooed her? What if Devlin was the least of his concerns?

Or was he being stupid?

The party she'd thrown for him she'd said in the car cost almost seven-hundred. That's what she spent on him for no reason other than she cared about him. His first thought sitting drunken in the front seat of her car? Money that could have been saved so you didn't have to work longer for Devlin than necessary. Totally selfish. Totally uncaring to the act of a woman who obviously loved him. He'd better start shaping up and enjoying the ride because Kimmy was going to be at Devlin's side for the next little while. That might be how he'd show her respect. Lay off her. Follow along and support her and be by her side and don't be such a continuous time-sucking problem. Hell, maybe after the weekend is over, maybe you should be the big man and give Devlin a call. Meet him for lunch and show Kimmy how strong a husband can be . . .



Out of the shower now, they dried off together, getting each other's backs, then going naked into the closet and putting on fresh pajamas. Josh got ahead of her, and she flicked off the light as he crawled into bed.

"One second," she said, slipping into the bathroom again. There was a dark thought that brought her back to the bathroom.

Now she studied her face in the mirror again. Home Kimmy, Josh's Kimmy. Hair down, no makeup, pleasant and pretty face. Big oversized sweatshirt

that her skinny body swam in, and baggy cotton sleeping shorts. But in this room was evidence of Kimmy Chang, attorney at law. Savior of company money, pride of Devlin Stone—lover of Devlin Stone, a gorgeous man who was her boss—awarded a private plane ride to the Caribbean for the weekend as treasure for her victory.

Away from the mirror now, she rummaged through the laundry hamper, found what she was looking for. The panties she'd worn today, worn to work, worn to Josh's party, and held them out so Devlin could ejaculate inside them. Now she turned them inside out, examined the crotch—the evidence of his semen blatant like a siren. Pale hazy patches in lobulated forms from the crotch up the front of her panties. She arranged them at the top of the laundry hamper, but moved over a T-shirt of Josh's, eclipsing. On partial display—but if Josh mentioned it she would deny everything.

She stood staring at the evidence of her awful betrayal. This weird knife point of pleasure, riding the sharp edge of danger and destruction and thrilling sexual excitement. At the core, what was most exciting was Josh's arousal of her with Devlin. It got Josh hard as a rock to think of her with Devlin between her legs, knowing that the guy who'd made his life miserable was humping his huge cock against her. She bit on her lower lip, exciting thoughts racing through her head . . . Josh knowing more, of Josh knowing the truth and being aroused by it.

*I've had him inside me, Josh. I've sucked his cock off. Devlin Stone came in my mouth. I know what his semen tastes like. He fucked me like crazy. So deep, baby. Josh, I can't even explain to you how he makes me orgasm.*

Josh getting hard hearing her awful words, both of them so turned on by Devlin Stone . . . The truth was, though, it wouldn't be good. It wouldn't be as sexy as she fantasized. It would hurt Josh, it would end him.

The smile on her face slowly faded as reality flooded. It wasn't good, it wasn't good at all. It was hurtful. Hurtful to the man she loved. She tugged over Josh's T-shirt to completely cover her panties. Stood watching for a moment, Josh calling her from the bedroom.

“Just a second,” she called back.



The smile flashed again, and she tugged the T-shirt away again, revealing a small sliver of her soiled panties.

*I don't know what you're talking about, Josh. The stains in my underwear? From you. Who do you think they're from? Who else's semen would be in the crotch of my panties? Then: Aw, baby, did you think it was Devlin's . . .? Are you getting hard, Josh, oh wow . . .*

Now the smile returned, and she squeaked around in bare feet, flushing the empty toilet and leaving the bathroom, closing off the light, skipping to jump on the bed on her knees, climbing up to join Josh, kissing him, settling against him, letting him fold open the blankets, her kicking her legs up then shoving them down underneath the covers, cuddling up next to him. He closed her in his arms, kissed her forehead. She scribbled nails on his neck, kissed his chin.

“Spoons,” she said, then squirmed around to give him her back. He closed himself around her, and she hugged his arm.



## II

---

**Wednesday, August 12**



---

## Winchester

The address was near Yonge and Lawrence, a fifteen minute drive south from the office. Traffic was heavy and she waited almost two minutes to make the turn across Yonge to get on the side street and find the concrete sign with the thin and serif-less font reading: 1700 The Winchester. A short drive through a manicured green space brought her to the parking lot of The Winchester, a sleek black steel and concrete apartment building.

Devlin'd called her an hour and a half ago for a meeting saying he needed her expertise, wanted her at his side for a negotiation, and to meet him at this address. Wasn't even supposed to be in Toronto today, and yet here he was playing games. And now given that the Winchester was an apartment building, her imagination began to work down the path of Devlin's dark proclivities. That this wasn't a meeting at all, that he'd borrowed a friend's apartment to encourage from her a lunchtime tryst. Could picture some hotshot like Devlin living here, some UCC prick Devlin met at U of T, Devlin saying he needed to bang this lawyer he hired and, since you're in the Bahamas, what say you, old friend, give us your pad, and maybe the keys to your Fifty Shades room . . . or maybe this was a legit meeting. You never knew with Devlin. One minute all business, the next some incredible ruse meant to get you to suck his cock on your knees. Problem was, her stomach wasn't exactly tightening with dread. It was exciting not knowing. It was exciting to get the call, hear his voice, play along, say you'd meet him at apartment 2101, 1700 Winchester, 1:15 P.M. Let's see what happens . . .

As she guided the Leaf into a visitor's spot she weighed the odds. A tryst was a pretty good bet. No guidance from Devlin when he called, no suggestion of what to brush up on, or telling her to pull some company or

some character's file. No past data to worry about. So maybe it was someone new. If it was business, perhaps it was a new customer seeking help they were already familiar with. Most likely, though, it was a tryst.

And since that was most likely she'd removed her panties in the bathroom at work. Pretty terrible thing for a married woman to do, but this was the way it was. It certainly looked like she was going to bend to Devlin's weight, and engage in a few-times-weekly hookup behind Josh's back. And do it on the cushion of some weird rationale that Josh knew how hot it was—so much so it made her husband hard as a rock to even fantasize about it. If she was wrong, and this wasn't a tryst, she'd now have to engage in a business meeting with no panties, and it provoked another terrible realization: this wasn't the first time she'd done legitimate work with sex heavy on her mind and not wearing any panties. Coming into this employment opportunity she'd been armed with morals and virtue and yet somehow Devlin'd allowed her to cloak herself in righteousness and still spread his filth in front of her, a middle ground where she played in his dirt patch and still wear her vestments. An erotic rapprochement. A purgatory where she indulged the enormous sexual capabilities of her rich and handsome and powerful boss; where Devlin was satisfied getting his big dick wet inside her; and where she'd also kidded herself into thinking her own husband would somehow appreciate his wife spreading her legs for a man as well-hung and obviously gorgeous despite being the asshole who bullied him in high school.

The lobby of the Winchester was what she would expect, complete with black lacquer, austere cement faces, stainless steel accents, and polished mahogany furniture. The concierge was a bright-smiling African in uniform who met her with enormous pleasantries—maybe coming on to her. Which was exciting to consider. When she'd worked in immigration, all the clientele were too scared to consider her attractiveness, or too powerless to act on it. Plus, back then she'd never worn makeup, dressed professionally but mostly in earth tones. Things had changed, that was for sure. But it wasn't just in the style of dress. That was a reflection of the change inside her. Gone were the days of monumental paperwork, bureaucratic nonsense . . . No, that wasn't true. Her new job was also about bureaucracy. Only, for some reason now it seemed streamlined, coming at it from a

whole different angle. She knew what it was: Profit. That was the different angle. And when you came at the same old problems from this new direction everything sure did look different. And people looked at her differently, too. Just like Ella who'd administered her IV in the Royal York the day before yesterday. It was respect. Admiration, maybe—admiration mixed with a few drops of mystique. Not knowing what she did for a living, but knowing it was beyond them given her wardrobe and (she like to think) the steely look in her eye.

“One-fifteen appointment with Devlin Stone. 2101,” she told the concierge.

“Okay, okay,” he said humming, checking his LCD screen. “Devlin Stone,” he said, “there you are, 21st floor and then you turn left. It's the apartment at the very end of the hall, Mrs. Chang.”

She thanked him, the good-looking young guy keeping his smile the whole time, maybe even checking her out as she walked from the concrete bunker of a desk to the three black lacquer and stainless elevator banks. She pressed the up-arrow, never looking back. It was a quick and silent ride to the 21st floor, and turning left she saw a woman headed her way, eyes down, fingers dancing on her phone. As they came nearer, the woman's expression changed, going from iPhone concentration to immediate good humor, tucking the phone in a skirt pocket. She wore a black jacket and skirt, a white dress shirt, and carried a black briefcase. She approached to greet, holding out her hand. She said, “You must be Devlin's lawyer.”

“I am,” she said shaking hands.

She said, “Very good to meet you, I'm Betsy Shapiro.” Now a business card was passed, and she took it with both hands to read: Betsy Shapiro, broker.

Betsy said, “Mr. Stone's in the apartment. I have a few phone calls to make, you can tell Mr. Stone to take his time.”

She told Betsy she would, gave a curt nod and a restrained smile. Tucked Betsy's business card into her jacket pocket and watched the woman at the elevator banks, pressing the button and snagging the same cab she'd rode up in before it had descended.

A broker. So, not the tryst she'd thought. Business. But what kind of business?

She adjusted her suit jacket as she resumed her path to the apartment at the end of the hall, headed for 2101. The black door was ajar, and she entered.

No surprises, much like the lobby, the decor of the apartment was what she would have presumed. Gallery-like, also austere; big, bold and graphic paintings, similar patterns on the bright cushions that padded the ivory couches; ebony furniture; a glimpse in the kitchen showed her all stainless top-of-the-line appliances. The view was southward toward the city, sunny out there today, a spacious blue sky, a sliver of the CN Tower piercing into the horizon. She adjusted her jacket, put hands in the pockets of her skirt, let her heels click around on the floor. Devlin would call her, she wouldn't call him.

Then Devlin's voice at last, coming from down the hall: "In here."

She found him in the apartment's bedroom, standing in that masculine and familiar Devlin pose. In a steely suit, shirt in pale blue, royal blue tie and matching braces; fisted hands placed on hips, suit jacket open. He stood by the bedroom's huge window wall, admiring the view of the city.

She asked, "What, pray tell, kind of meeting is this one today?" She leaned casually on the doorframe.

Devlin turned, amused, eyes bright and happy—unmistakably pleased to see her here. How times had changed. When she thought of Devlin, she thought of him as menacing. But here he was today, calm, confident, and capable, but no menace. It was a subtle shift, and an exciting one. He said, "What do you think?"

"About Betsy, or about this apartment?"

"Think she's pretty?"

She chuckled. "You probably do."



Hands off hips, he crossed his arms now and studied her. “Is that jealousy?”

“What do I have to be jealous of?—I’m married.”

He nodded, said, “I’m asking what you think of the apartment.”

She sighed, said, “I appreciate the gesture, but I already have a place to live.”

He smiled, enjoying her banter, uncrossing his arms and putting hands in his pants pockets, slowly strolling across the hardwood floor toward her. She raised her chin.

She said, “It’s not for me, is it?”

“It’s not.”

“Why do you need an apartment?”

“You tell me,” he said.

Here was what was obvious: you called me here, so I’d guess you want an apartment for a fuck pad. She said, “I would say you’re tired of driving back and forth from Kingston to Toronto.”

“I told you I was.”

“So now you want a place to crash here. Tired of Toronto hotels?”

“I’m tired of Toronto hotels,” he said. “I’d like something a little more permanent.”

“Abandoning old Kingston, our home of origin?”

“It’s about time I joined the rest of you.”

“Josh and I? We only made it as far as Ajax.”

“For now,” he said, closing the distance further, practically joining her in the space of the open doorway.

She said, “I’m afraid to say what I think this apartment really means.”

“You’re that insightful—you know why?”

“I think so.”

“I think the future is in Toronto,” he said, pushing away from the doorframe now, heading toward the view at the window again. She watched the breadth of his shoulders in his suit jacket, the way he moved gracefully even with his arms crossed. She followed, coming to stand behind him at the foot of the bed. It was low, modern in a Japanese way, no headboard, it looked like a black lacquered ebony platter with a pure white mattress, white duvet flat on top with a wiggling black line as if paint’d been dripped high from above. The painting that hung above the bed was simple and geometric, black and white with spots of red.

She said, “You want to expand the Toronto office.”

“Why wouldn’t I?”

“The shipping’s been changing, I’m not arguing with you. And I only see it diminishing further.”

“I’d be crazy not to be here. There’s more than shipping, anyway.”

“So Stone would change its head office?”

“Stone?” he said, “Stone Brokerage?”

She frowned—Devlin being coy for some reason. “Right,” she said, “the company I work for.”

“Oh,” he said, “maybe. Maybe the company you work for.”

Her frown deepened. She asked him what he meant.

“I’m moving to Toronto. I’m moving for brokerage . . . and that’s all I’m ready to say right now.”

She studied his face, registered the confidence but looked deeper to find meaning and resolve. From his insinuation, she saw bigger and bolder moves than she’d ever even expected from him. A coldness throbbed at her core at the implication, but a light amusement still flickered at the forefront of her thoughts.

“That’s very bold,” she said.

He said nothing in return, only held her gaze, smiling, sucking on his lower lip a moment then letting it go. His smile deepened on one side, and his eyes narrowed. There was that menace again, and she liked to see it return.

She said, “I didn’t know what to expect when you called me here.”

“I’m glad you came.” Then: “Because I do want you at my side . . .” A simple statement, but in conjunction with the possible independence he was insinuating they held more weight. She nodded, unable to hide the wow from her eyes, thinking how huge this might be if he were serious. But also registering the disappointment that this wasn’t as simple a meeting as she’d bet on. Things had been much easier when she thought he’d borrowed a buddy’s apartment so they could have sex. She palmed her forehead a second, smoothed her hair, fingertips exploring the shape of her tight bun. Maybe it was all too much. No wonder he’d offered her the job. Was he looking for an ally all along? Why hadn’t he been more honest from the beginning? . . .

Now he changed the subject, saying: “Back to my first question: what do you think of the apartment?”

She asked how much it was and he told her four-K a month.

She said, “Do you have terms a term sheet, or something for me to look over?”

“I can get you whatever you want.”

“Okay,” she said, “email it to me. I’ll let you know.”

“But what do you think of the apartment?”

“It comes furnished?”

“As is.”

“It looks like Ivan Boesky’s mistress’s apartment,” she said of the eighties design.

Devlin’s smile spread even wider. “Should I change the artwork?”

“No,” she said, “somehow it’s all very fitting.” She crossed her own arms now, inhibited, looking around and taking it all in.

“I need you to like it,” he said in a low voice.

And there was the truth she’d suspected all along, Devlin’s coyness hiding it from her, his method of dominance. He didn’t care about terms sheets, or her educated opinion on the paperwork. He wanted her to know what she thought of the place where she would cheat on her husband a few times a week . . .

“I like it,” she said.

He nodded. “I’m going to take it.”

She allowed him a moment of command, but then took some control of her own. “I don’t want you to come to Cayman.”

He nodded again, not looking her way, eyes out the window taking in the stellar view.

When she’d taken the job, in her heart it was to make money. Maybe way in the trunk of her mind there was the knowledge she would submit to his sexual advances. One time. Now it was obvious it wouldn’t be only one time. A desire had built. One she hadn’t anticipated. If she didn’t make the effort to create new barriers, new rules, ones she could adhere to for once,

where would it lead her? What would it do to her and Josh. And what about poor Josh? What about his heart? God, his sanity?

Still not looking her way, Devlin said now: “No?”

“I’m going with Josh. It’s my time with him.”

“Your call.”

She unbuttoned the collar of her shirt, hands moving to the next one down. The sound drew Devlin’s attention and he turned to face her.

She looked at him, said, “But I need you to fuck me now.”

His expression went steely, his eyes warming with sudden lust. She was giving him what he wanted, but she was getting what she wanted too, doing it on her own terms. If she let Devlin dominate her it would end her way of life, she knew it in her heart. He would sever her relationship with Josh—he would crush Josh. If she fucked around with Devlin she would have to own it, do it on her own terms.

Devlin chuckled. “Here?”

She said, “On your new bed.”

He chuckled, looking her up and down. “Going to be a long weekend without a real cock.”

“I’ll make do.”

“Josh does other things for you.”

“He does indeed.”

“Did he fuck you last night? Was he eager to show you how much he appreciated the party you threw to hide your guilt?”

She shook her head, admonished him with her gaze, still unbuttoning. “We had great sex last night.”

“Did you come on his cock?”

“I did.” Her shirt was unbuttoned, the strap of her black bra drawing Devlin’s eyes. “Does it surprise you?”

She could see his devious mind at work behind his black eyes, looking for a way to get the upper hand, looking to spark her lust and to diminish Josh all at once. He found it, and it was the truth. “Josh asked about my bulge again.”

“Maybe,” she said, untucking her shirt, letting the tails hang over her skirt. Her eyes were drawn to the movement of his hand, watching it go between his legs and heft the large shape of his genitals. It was clear he wore no underwear, clear the unbuttoning of her shirt and her request to be fucked had begun to arouse him. He smoothed the fabric underneath the bulk of his cock and balls, made a hammock for his manhood, showing off the size to her. The sight thrilled her, gave her a tight string of anticipation between her legs and a tingling in her fingertips and stomach.

He said, “What did you tell him?”

“How big it was,” she said, her voice softer than she anticipated. Devlin liked hearing her say it. Liked to know she would tell Josh that. Devlin loving his own cock, his lawyer loving it, even his lawyer’s husband loving it. There was his power; that was how he got off. His own natural entitlement, his endowment by birth. A thing so powerful other men’s wives turned their backs on their spouses to interact with it. And seeing it his way, seeing how Devlin saw it suddenly aroused her too. Like a license. A pass. Devlin’s undeniable masculine appeal so apparent that even a cuckolded husband would accept the truth and kneel before his dominance.

Now she straightened her spine, shook her head to disengage the awful tractor beam of that lustful thought, reminding herself not to submit to him.

Devlin closed the space between them, her eyes lowered to watch the shifting movement of his cock behind the cradle of fabric. Face to face now, he guided her hand to caress the bulge, holding her wrist while she palmed the weight of his cock.

He said, “You’d rather go to Cayman with Josh? You’re sure?”

She fingered the girth of his hardening cock, fingertips tracing the flared shape of his bulging cock head. “That’s why I need you to fuck me now.”

“Fuck, Kimmy,” he groaned, “yes, that’s hot.”

Fingers still appreciating his cock under the fabric, she said, “I want to go with Josh because I like spending time with him. I want to hang out with my husband, I want to do couples things . . .”

“Yeah,” he asked, liking her words, betraying to her the source of his arousal, his own kink becoming apparent. He unzipped, tugged out his cock and put it in her grip. It was huge, hot and gummy, and not even hard yet. “Your pussy ready for me again?”

She stroked, hefted, teased his cock. “I need it. I need your big cock before I go away with my husband.” Her eyes moved from the wicked sight of his monstrous penis in her hand up to his ravenous eyes. “I need you to fuck me with your huge cock.”

The words’ effect on him was obvious in his eyes. And his cock surged hard in her grip, his rate of arousal increasing with her dirty talk.

“You didn’t get what you wanted last night?”

“From Josh?” She shook her head no.

“You need a real cock.”

“I need a big cock. Not his little dick . . .”

Devlin closed his eyes and his cock went to wood in her grip. She whispered, “I’m not wearing panties . . .”





## Wild Horse

An hour before lunch, he was outside Harjeet Bhatt's office waiting for his boss to get off the phone so he could ask about getting Friday off. It had been a weird morning where he was still flying high on the weird trip his wife'd taken him on last night. All that dirty talk Kimmy'd been cool with indulging had done some weird things to his mind and he couldn't shake them this morning. Got a full-on boner in the shower this morning reliving the time he'd spent with her under the water's stream, where she'd continued to milk his new weird kink, talking about Devlin while they had sex. It was time to stop wondering what the fuck it was all about and just embrace it. It surely turned him on. How long would this kink continue to work for him?—who knew. He'd once gone through a phase where he'd got super-hot for feet, but these days any of those old videos probably wouldn't work their same magic like they did when he'd hunted them down. Embrace it and enjoy it. Hell, look: Maybe Dream Devlin and his dirty words were really his own kink talking to his drunken mind, the whole escapade brought about by having his worst nightmare brought back into his life that night at Tiffany's party. Some shadow-sliver-self whispered some dirty deep secrets in his own ear, and he'd made sense of it by calculating a dream where the devil himself had come into his tent and said take a hold of my giant dick and then smell your hand . . . It was almost a relief. But it wasn't. No, it wasn't at all. Because of the text. The text had reminded him of his request. The text was real. The text did not arrive into a drunken mind.

And then at the worst time possible, this realization provoked the stirring of an erection.

If he had this weird kink, then who was to say he hadn't told Devlin when he was ripped out of his mind? Devlin'd texted him he was doing what Josh asked. So if the kink was real, the idea he'd asked this of Devlin was less outrageous. Far more possible. And much, much worse: the possibility Dream Devlin was the real Devlin. Coming into his tent and saying it was done, showing him his huge cock and getting him to put his hand on it. For so long he'd convinced himself it wasn't real, too far-fetched . . . Now his cock thundered with blood and became a full-blood hard-on that throbbed with urgency. The humiliation of it all. A man fucks your wife at a party because you said it would be hot, then shows you the proof, your wife's sticky smell clinging to his big cock.

Harjeet was off the phone now, laughing about something, tidying his desk, aware that Josh was outside the window wall, but not here with an appointment. Just popping by. Or not. Maybe just passing . . .

Another thing he'd been plagued by this morning was a sick but thrilling pleasure derived from the awful pictures Kimmy painted with her words—words he'd chastised her for. The idea she'd go with Devlin to the Caribbean, go with him and wonder what his bulge would look like in his swimwear, and the most terrifying thrill of all: that she knew Devlin's big cock would get hard for her.

It was this thought he'd thumbed over and over, hating that it excited him. The longer he put off asking for a three-day weekend, the more he could enjoy this sinful dread that swirled his core. All morning, in accompaniment to reliving Kimmy's words, he'd entertained the idea of Kimmy going to the Caribbean with Devlin, and him staying at home. The absolute blackness that wrapped him was like suppurating pleasure. He wouldn't let that happen, but still . . .

He waved to Harjeet and passed along the front of his boss's office without stopping. At the end of the hall, he turned right and headed for the bathroom. It was empty, thankfully, and he headed to the furthest stall, locked himself in and collapsed on the toilet. Pants unzipped, he pulled out his throbbing and traitorous erection. He thumbed it forward, examined it, judged the scale of his hand in comparison and thought more about what Kimmy'd seen bulging out Devlin's pants. The idea was thrilling and he

had to stop being angry about it. What seemed for sure now was that this arousing idea of Kimmy with Devlin existed in his head. Maybe Devlin put it there or maybe he'd divulged it drunkenly to Devlin. Either way, he had to emerge from Kimmy's shadow and face Devlin. And he'd already proved he could do it—aided a little by liquid courage, he'd faced the demon of his youth and looked him in the eye. Had even defied Devlin's confident gaze by tossing out the conjecture over who really ran Stone Brokerage. That took a set of balls he didn't know he had.

In his pocket was a card with Devlin's phone number and he would call Devlin. Call him, meet him, and find out what was real and what wasn't. Maybe Devlin had never been in his tent, but he sure as hell had sent a text, and that text had said he'd fucked Kimmy.

A month ago, the slipperiest mention of that idea could have wrecked him. Devastated him. The enormity of it had prevented him from doing the right thing. So afraid it was true, so afraid of Devlin, he'd cowered and shushed it all away, shushed it out of existence. But no more. The arousal he felt and Kimmy's acceptance of that arousal gave him confidence to face down the biggest bully in his life. Devlin'd taunted him with the greatest and most frightening threat: I fucked your wife. Only he hadn't. He'd relied on Josh's own insecurities and fears to do the bullying work on his own. And, damn it, it'd worked. But not anymore. He'd look Devlin in the eye and if Devlin had the guts to say it to his face, say I fucked Kimmy, he would say to Devlin: "No, you didn't."

For now, though, he'd indulge a little longer in his dark fantasy. He stroked his cock, stroked it to get rid of an unfortunate mid-workday boner. It had to be done, and while it had to be done, it was lunchtime on Wednesday and he still didn't have Friday off yet. So while he stroked with his pulsing pre-come, he closed his eyes and thought of Kimmy on the beach, husband Josh all the way back in Ajax, and she's turning, turning to see her boss coming down from the hotel and joining her on the hot sand. She's smiling to him, waving, wearing a tiny black bikini. And her eyes are lowering, going down between Devlin's legs. It wasn't like her at all, but that damn husband of hers put it in her head. And now she was biting her lips because sure enough, Devlin couldn't wear Speedos. Couldn't, but was, anyway. And the

enormous heap of man-flesh between his legs bulged the fabric comically, and Kimmy wondered what it would look like free of that spandex confinement. That's right, his wife wondered if he was circumcised, wondered how many inches it was. Maybe later she'd measure it. Put a ruler on that shower room monster and laugh. Yeah, it was enormous, but Josh was right, no one was twelve inches. Twelve inches or not, she would think, it sure was a lot of cock for one man to have and maybe she'd like to try . . .

And then he came, a bright but awful image behind his eyes of Kimmy and Devlin close together in some imaginary Cayman hotel bathroom, and she's awestruck by Devlin's naked cock, but oh-so-happy he's getting hard for her . . .



In an effort to restrict the wounding by his massive impalement, she had two hands thrust between her legs, his huge cock running through their grip. She was on her back on the bed of what would be Devlin's new apartment, fifteen minutes from her office. Skirt pulled up to her waist, legs wrapped around his strong hips, expensive shoes locked behind his back. Her suit coat was open, shirt unbuttoned, her bra tugged to one side, Devlin thumbing an exposed hard and rubbery nipple. He fucked her while her two hands prevented him from going too deep. For now.

Devlin kissed and bit her neck, and she bit on his earlobe. He smelled amazing. Firewood, leather, spice, and soap. His cock was enormous in her hands, and what he could get inside her was still satisfying. She let one hand go, fingered her own clitoris, let him get deeper. She gasped as his huge cock head spread her deep. She squeezed the base of his cock, and Devlin growled.

"You need this cock?"

“So big, so good . . .”

“Kimmy likes it—”

“Deep,” she finished for him.

“Like this?” He curled his hips forward, gaining an inch in her interior.

“Oh God,” she sighed, slowly releasing her grip on his cock, now hefting the impressive weight of his dangling balls. She kneaded them, played with them, and Devlin got even deeper.

“I love it deep,” she whispered in his ear.

“You’re the hottest fuck in the world, Kimmy Chang—”

“Deeper,” she whispered, letting his balls go and her hands sliding up his sides, under his soft dress shirt and feeling his hot muscle. He’d undone his pants, and they sagged below his round ass. His feet were on the floor at the foot of the bed—two executives fucking in the middle of the work day.

Devlin gave her what she requested, sliding do deep she could feel those big sticky balls resting in the crack of her ass. The bulb end of him nudged apart her deepest folds, and she knew to arch her back so he wouldn’t prod her cervix.

He whispered: “That good?”

“Incredible,” she told him, “don’t move, just . . .”

She gasped now as Devlin began pulse-flexing his dick, that fat cock head throbbing inside her like a pleasure-beacon. She chuckled at the insane gratification, eyes closing, lashes fluttering.

His hips rocked, his cock not thrusting, just rolling against her, getting her pelvis swaying as his huge size claimed her completely. Each roll around brought white blobs of light in the blackness of her shut eyes. “You’re so fucking big, baby . . .”

“That’s it, call me baby,” he said, chuckling and growling.

“Yeah, you like that, baby,” she whispered, “like fucking me with your huge cock?”

“I love you getting something your husband can’t give you.”

“He can’t fuck me like you do,” she said, hands going up higher, palming his strong hard chest. “You fuck me so good, so deep.” Her eyes met his, registered the effect of her words, giving her lover with deadly accuracy the thing that made his dick hardest. Devlin scowled, a mixture of lust and menace, hearing the thing that drove his sex-engine and now he began to fuck her. She gasped and moaned and squeaked, whimpering for him: “Oh, easy, baby, oh, baby, you’re so big . . .”

That was when she saw a pale shadow cross the wall opposite the open bedroom door and knew one Betsy Shapiro was spying on her client and her client’s lawyer fucking on the bed in the apartment she hoped the guy would take.

“Fuck, you’re so tight,” he growled, “Josh can’t please this pussy . . .”

“Only you, baby, this is our bed . . .”

“Our bed,” he agreed in a low animal rumble.

“Fuck me, baby, fuck me like I can’t get at home.”

This drove Devlin wild, and he responded with male aggression, claiming her hard and deep, hoisting up her pelvis and manhandling her. Her hair spread across the bed, her bun coming undone, her jacket bunching up behind her neck. He supported the small of her back and fucked her expertly, his thumbs pressing into her flat stomach. Her back was arched, and a knot pressed out her tummy with each thrust of his cock. Devlin was so hard, his cock speared out her flesh. She palmed the knot, moaning, whimpering again, saying, “oh, Devlin, you fuck me so good, I love that big cock,” the outrageous knowledge that someone spied on them spurring on the dirtiest talk. Hoping Betsy had a hand down her skirt and was jacking

herself, maybe wondering how big this guy's cock was, given his hot-ass lawyer's profane evocations.

For the first time, she seriously lamented not engaging in that threesome with Amy and Devlin—or at least had watched like Betsy surely was. But thoughts of Amy and Amy's honesty tugged her away from where she wanted to be—so she chased off the thoughts, re-engaged with Devlin, tugging his tie to bring his mouth closer so they could kiss.

What made Devlin tick wasn't much different than what made Josh tick. And the truth was, she got off on being the device between them, the thing—the sexual being—that completely dominated their erotic thoughts. Their master. When she was bad, she was powerful.

She growled near Devlin's ear: "Come inside me, baby, I want to feel your wet all day long, will you make me wet, baby? Make me wet with your come . . ."

Devlin made a low growling animal sound, his jaw setting firm. He looked in her eyes, and she could see a measure of amazement there. Maybe a miscalculation that needed correction, his dominant male mind looking to engage in a war of wills. He said, "You're too good to be true, Kimmy . . ."

She whispered, "Betsy's watching us."

Devlin chuckled and drew back, eyes still studying her as she writhed under him, giving him a face that told him she needed his cock. He took her skinny knee and tossed her legs onto one side of him, withdrew his cock, brought her to her hands and knees and walked her widdershins. When she looked up, she could see why: a mirror on a stand near the bedside. She said to his reflection over her shoulder: "We're going to watch ourselves fuck twice a week," then bit her lower lip.

Devlin's face was stone-serious with sexual intent and he grabbed his cock and shoved it inside her, making her squawk.

"Fuck me doggy, baby," she panted, bucking herself back into his thrusts. "Oh, fuck me good . . ."

With her skirt up, her long bare legs were knee-pointed on the bed, her hair hung in tangles, some locks still tucked into the remnants of her bun. Her jacket was open, her shirt open, and one nipple budded over the curled-over edge of her black bra. Her face showed demanding lust that surprised even her. Devlin was behind her, on the bed now on his knees, his hands gripping her waist, his handsome face pinched and angry as he fucked her hard.

“Ah, you’re so big—mm, I’m hardly ready for you again.” The words were meant for Devlin but they were beginning to take their toll on her, and now she could feel a new flux of her pussy’s wet squelching around Devlin’s girth. She made a squeaky gasp that almost sounded like a laugh, responding impishly to the flatulent sound his thick cock made with her gushing wet. “Ah, God, I’m so wet,” she gasped and tossed her hair around.

It wasn’t long before the presence of mind she had to holler out insanely dirty things for Devlin and Betsy’s benefit faded and soon the intense deep-dick pleasure of Devlin’s fucking consumed her forward-mind. Her breathy panting became real, her moans and cries genuine. When she grew quiet, Devlin grew dominant.

“You take it deep, Kimmy,” he growled.

“Uh-huh,” she gasped.

“And you didn’t think it’d fit.”

“It fuh-fits,” she gasped. The bed rattled against the drywall and now she had an image of Betsy with her back against the wall, fingering herself, listening to a woman get the fucking of a lifetime.

“No one’s ever fucked my cock better.” One hand spread on her lower back, sliding under her shirt and jacket then and gripping the back of her neck. “So fucking deep, so fucking tight.”

“Mm, fuck me, oh fuck me . . .”

The fucking and thrashing continued, Devlin with his neck in her grip, holding her in place for his deep impalement. All she wanted right now was



his come. She'd come twice already—little flutters and kicks, but what her belly craved was to be filled with a gallon of his hot load. When she knew he was close, she rolled her bottom against his thrusts, gripped hold of the bedding and growled and cried like a bitch animal being mated. It drove Devlin crazy and she could feel his thrust hitch, could feel his cock twitching inside her.

“Josh can't do me like this, baby, Josh can't give me what I need . . .”

“Fuckin' . . .”

“Only you, I need what you have—I need it so bad, so deep . . .”

He grunted, “You need a man.” His voice was tight and he was on the very edge of losing it. The swell built inside her as well.

“Give it to me—I won't have it for days, and I need it, Devlin, I need it, mm, I need it so bad . . .”

At last he exploded. Dick thrusting deep and flexing, his cock head swelling in her guts till it felt twice as big. The knowledge that his seed was being blasted inside her—beyond her cervix—set her off as well and her pussy began to quiver around Devlin's stretch. Soon she was flooding the bed. She could hear the patter of her wet on the bedding between her knees. Devlin growled and roared and tried to plunge deeper but he'd bumped his pubic pad against her tailbone. He thumbed her anus as he still ejaculated and she squirted around him.

They collapsed together on the bed, him on top of her. She could feel the sticky sweat of her skin against her clothing and wondered what the shower pressure in the apartment's bathroom would be like and if she should buy wooden hangers for her jackets.

He lay heavily on her panting against her back, his orgasm as big as hers. That was an orgasm she delivered. That was her work.

“Fuck, Chang,” he said at last, exhausted, exhaling, lifting off her with one arm, his other hand withdrawing his cock from her. It made a liquid gushing

sound and she could feel wet spilling through her pubic hair. She chuckled and got on her elbows. Devlin slapped her ass and fell back, laying at her side, his huge wet cock laying up on his stomach, bowed over his dress shirt and making a dark stain on the fabric. She leaned to one side, reached and ran her fingers up its belly, then touched her lip. “Wow,” she said, then peeped over her shoulder toward the open bedroom door, wondering if Betsy had tip-toed out or was stuck in the hall now in the quiet aftermath expecting she would get caught eavesdropping.

For Betsy’s sake she returned to face Devlin saying, “I guess you’re going to take it.”

“The apartment?”

“It’s perfect,” she said.

“Fucking perfect,” Devlin said, looking up at the ceiling. Then his head rolled her way. “What got into you?”

“What do you mean?” She gave him a coy smile, tucking her chin down.

He went to his side to face her, his cock swinging down to point straight into the bedding. “That dirty talk . . .”

“You like it?”

“You’re into this.”

She shrugged a shoulder. “For now.”

He nodded. She could tell from the sag of his posture that he was enervated. And it made her proud to turn the tables on him. He said, “You don’t look like you can take what I’ve got—the way you’re built—but, Kimmy, I swear you are the hottest fuck ever.”

She tried to keep emotion from her face, not give away her thoughts to her adversary, but his words had her scalp tingling. She shrugged the shoulder again. No big deal. Said, “I was just really horny.”

“You definitely wanted it,” he said.

She opened her hips and rolled to a side, facing him now. With one high heel planted in the bed, she winged open a leg and fiddled with her pubic hair. Devlin’s eyes were mesmerized, watching her play with herself. Now that she’d rolled away, her copious wet was visible on the pristine wet of the bedding. She chuckled, said, “I had no idea I was that horny.”

His eyes moved up to hers and he studied her. She showed him nothing. Then she smiled and asked him, “Do you like fucking me?—or do you like fucking Josh Waters’ wife?”

His pupils flared. She’d sprung it on him and hadn’t even known she was going to do it. But the questions even you didn’t expect were the best ones at finding the truth. Devlin struggled, and she knew he was reassessing how to deal with her. Once he figured it, his confident smile returned. “What’s the difference?”

Now she took her pussy wet and moved to touch his lips, stroking his good-looking mouth with the product of their fucking.

He kept his eyes on hers, gripped her small wrist in his big hand and held it firmly. He made a grumbling sound in his chest, smiling still. He said, “You’re a wild horse, Kimmy.”

She raised her chin, looked at him through narrowed eyes. “I am.”

He chuckled, cocked his head. “But I’m still going to break you.”



## Afterword

Another episode with Kimmy, Josh, and Devlin will be coming soon!—join me on Patreon to read further ahead . . .

---

Sign up for my newsletter on my website to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two!

---

Visit my website!

[ktmorrison.com](http://ktmorrison.com)

---

[hotwifebooks.com](http://hotwifebooks.com)

